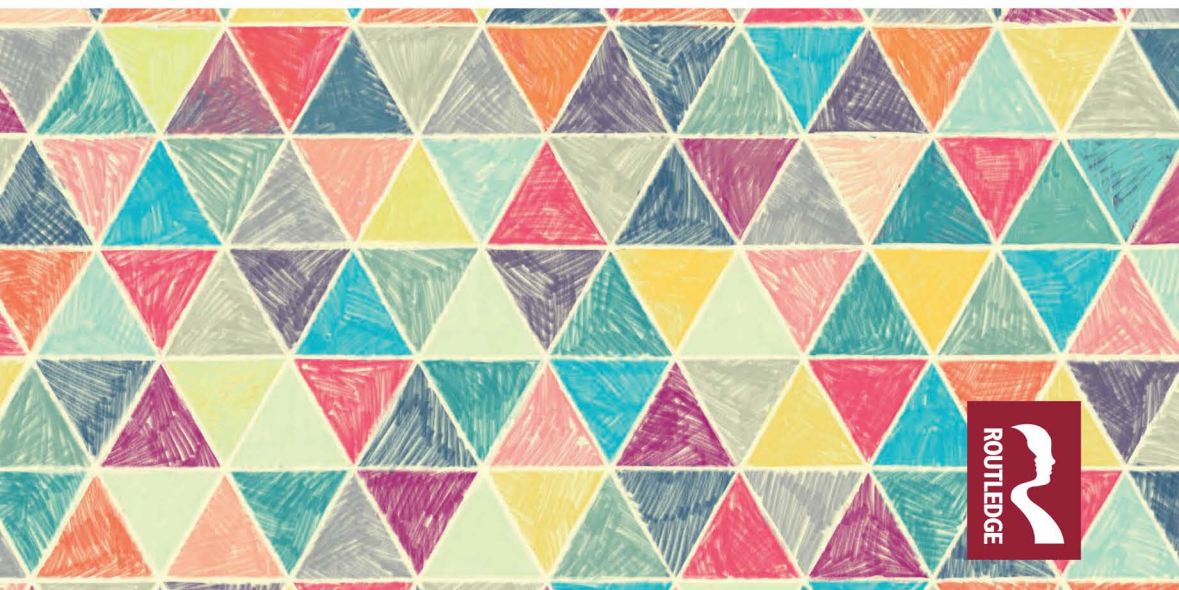


PROTEST AND DEMOCRACY

HOW MOVEMENT PARTIES, SOCIAL MOVEMENTS AND ACTIVE CITIZENS ARE RESHAPING EUROPE

Edited by
Claudius Wagemann, Toma Burean, Dan Mercea,
Lorenzo Mosca, and Christina Neumayer



Protest and Democracy

This book offers an interdisciplinary analysis of the interplay between protest and institutions during an era of multiple crises in Denmark, Germany, Hungary, Italy, Romania and the UK. Focusing on the interaction between citizens, social movements and movement parties, and questions of democratic quality related to participation, competition and responsiveness, it considers the role of traditional and social media when connecting institutional and non-institutional arenas. Building on insights from political science, sociology and communication studies, it combines an original cross-national survey, interviews, media analysis, document analysis, statistical analytical techniques, critical discourse analysis, social network analysis and natural language processing, in a comparative perspective.

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Protest and Democracy

How Movement Parties, Social Movements and Active Citizens Are Reshaping Europe

Edited by Claudius Wagemann, Toma Burean, Dan Mercea, Lorenzo Mosca, and Christina Neumayer

Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group
LONDON AND NEW YORK

First published 2025
by Routledge
4 Park Square, Milton Park, Abingdon, Oxon OX14 4RN

and by Routledge
605 Third Avenue, New York, NY 10158

Routledge is an imprint of the Taylor & Francis Group, an informa business

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British Library Cataloguing-in-Publication Data
A catalogue record for this book is available from the British Library

ISBN: 978-1-032-76784-0 (hbk)
ISBN: 978-1-032-87401-2 (pbk)
ISBN: 978-1-003-53250-7 (ebk)

DOI: 10.4324/9781003532507

Typeset in Sabon
by Apex CoVantage, LLC

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1 Protest and democracy

How movement parties, social movements and active citizens are reshaping Europe

Claudius Wagemann, Toma Burean, Dan Mercea, Lorenzo Mosca and Christina Neumayer

An overview

It is commonplace to claim that, during the last years, Europe's political landscape has been shaped by multiple crises. European democratic countries might respond to this development by enhancing more responsiveness to citizens' needs, by strengthening accountability mechanisms, or by emphasizing citizens' rights. With such a reaction, crises could have beneficial effects on democracy. Alternatively, however, we might witness an even stronger proliferation of so-called illiberal regimes, challenging the legitimacy of traditional media and political institutions. And this would certainly be less beneficial for democracy because it endangers central components of contemporary liberal democracy.

In this book, we investigate the ways in which interactions between citizens, social movements and a specific breed of political party – the so-called movement parties (della Porta et al., 2017; Kitschelt, 2006; Mosca and Quaranta, 2017) – influence democratic quality in times of crisis as during the recent years in Europe. Research into political culture describes the increase in protests as a consequence of long-term sociocultural change, leading to growing numbers of "critical citizens" who question authority but remain committed to democratic values (Dalton and Welzel, 2014; Norris, 2011). Protesting therefore belongs to civic attitudes deeply rooted in European democracies (Klingemann, 2014). However, the literature also provides us with the opinion that the spread of protests is symptomatic of democratic backsliding (Bermeo, 2016; Foa and Mounk, 2016; Krastev, 2014). Dissatisfied with the performance of democracies, sizeable sections of the citizenry have protested by voting for populist parties, contributing to an erosion of liberal democratic standards (Pirro, 2015).

The book is the final summary of a three-year international and interdisciplinary research project, fully funded by the Volkswagen Foundation. The ProDem project ("Protest and Democracy – How Movement Parties, Social Movements and Active Citizens Are Reshaping Europe") focuses on the relationship between protest and democracy covering six EU countries (Denmark, Germany, Hungary, Italy, Romania and UK). It is characterized

DOI: 10.4324/9781003532507-1

by three main conceptual angles. First, we take a joint look at the protest and the institutional political arena that was often analyzed separately in the past (McAdam and Tarrow, 2010). Second, we consider the key role of the hybrid media system (Chadwick et al., 2017) in facilitating or discouraging such interactions, differentiating between traditional and social media. Third, we connect our research to the discussion on democratic quality (Morlino, 2012) which underlines the importance of participation, competition and responsiveness.

With our research, we follow five research objectives. First, with regard to the protest arena, we investigate citizens' propensity to participate in protests and its relationship to voting. This enables an assessment of whether new social movements and movement parties have succeeded over the past decade in representing sociodemographic sectors previously marginalized by representative politics. Second, still in the protest arena, we gauge the role of discursive strategies for mobilizing citizens. We aim to understand how social movements and parties politicize conflicts and enhance or hinder socioeconomic and cultural inclusiveness. Third, in the institutional arena, we combine social movement and media studies to research interactions between movement parties and traditional media. We investigate how challengers' media strategies change over time, prompting reactions from media institutions. Fourth, also in the institutional arena, we assess social movements' and movement parties' use of social media, focusing on the linkages they develop with other actors over time. We thus probe any shifts in network structures and alignments at moments of transition. Finally, we investigate whether movement parties politically represent the concerns voiced during mass protests within the core of the political-administrative system. More specifically, we consider whether they contribute to legislative initiatives enhancing citizens' political participation.

This research is innovative in three main ways. Theoretically, we propose that examining the triple interaction between citizens, social movements and movement parties is key to understanding democratic quality in the current turbulent climate. We cover the spectrum of the triple interaction's behavioral, discursive, social network and temporal patterns. Methodologically, we model the triple interaction and its effects on democratic quality with an original research design. Multiple data sources (our own cross-national survey; interviews; media and social media data; policy documents) are used, and various social science methods (multiple regression analysis; structural equation modeling; critical discourse and qualitative content analysis; social network analysis; natural language processing; comparative methods) are applied. Finally, our work is also interdisciplinary, since political science, sociology and communication studies scholars collaborated with regard to our main questions.

In brief, it is our aim to offer an interdisciplinary analysis of the triple interaction between citizens, protest and movement parties in an era of multiple crises. This book offers an up-to-date analysis of such different countries

as Denmark, Germany, Hungary, Italy, Romania and the UK. It is timely, not least since it shows a broad approach, considering movements from the left and the right of the political spectrum.

All chapters can be read individually, but only together the reading will result in a coherent storyline.

Chapter 2 by Mercea, Trif and Wagemann lays the theoretical basis of what follows. The chapter sheds light on the most important contributions to research on movement parties and adjacent fields. Specifically, it focuses on the analytical combination of the protest and institutional arenas, which have been treated separately so far. Furthermore, the chapter discusses the importance of traditional and social media with regard to protests and movement parties. Finally, it embeds the topic of the triple interaction of citizens, movements and movement parties in the broader discussion on democratic quality, above all with regard to the criteria of participation, competition and responsiveness.

Chapter 3 by Santos and Wagemann takes a methods perspective. It departs from the central idea that topics studied in the book require different methodological approaches. For example, the "demand side" of protest (i.e., mass demonstrations) often invites researchers to conduct large-N studies on transitory groups, while the "supply side" (i.e., the targets of protests, such as political institutions) looks at smaller numbers of research objects that are comparatively stable over time. Democratic quality is also a typical macro-level concept analyzed for a limited number of cases sharing certain scope conditions. It is challenging to bring all these methodological perspectives together, not least since different types of causality are involved. This chapter will not only outline the mixed-methods approach of the book but also discuss the topic of methodological pluralism from a more abstract perspective.

After these two introductory chapters, Chapter 4 by Santos and Mercea starts from the observation that the emergence of movement parties in Europe has disrupted the conventional landscape of party politics, introducing fresh avenues for citizen involvement and political mobilization. The chapter provides an analysis of who the voters of movement parties are, drawing on nationally representative survey data from six European countries. It explores the relation of socio-demographic variables, political ideology, previous political electoral and non-electoral involvement, and other political attitudes to citizens' likelihood to vote for movement parties. Through this analysis, the chapter provides a comprehensive overview of the factors contributing to citizens' support for these increasingly prominent political actors.

Chapter 5, authored by Trif, Mărgărit and Burean, looks at the protest arena as the place where ideological discourses are created and molded. Most analyses on the ideology of movement parties focus on right-leaning populist parties and less on the progressive ones. Three progressive movement parties – USR (Romania), Momentum (Hungary) and The Alternative

(Denmark) – are at the core of this comparative approach. The claim is that the readiness of progressive parties to consistently embrace socioeconomic and cultural inclusiveness depends on their ideological backgrounds. Communication produced by, among and beyond these types of actors delineates the discursive boundaries of social inclusion/exclusion. The chapter concludes that the ideological discourse on democracy, freedom and equality is convergent for all three parties. Despite this, their ideological discourse on inclusion is divergent. Inclusiveness is prone to different interpretations that seem to be dependent on the national context.

In Chapter 6, Mosca and Paxton respond to the observation that empirical research remains limited in understanding how movement parties adapt their media strategies once they institutionalize and how their interactions with media institutions evolve. They examine the dual dynamics of the interaction between movement parties and the media in four Western European countries (Denmark, Germany, Italy and the UK). The chapter is based on in-depth interviews conducted with movement party representatives and journalists from selected media outlets. The analysis identifies two primary features shared by movement parties that contribute to similarities in their relations with the media: informal organizational structures and reliance on digital media. Despite significant ideological variation among the parties analyzed, the chapter highlights commonalities in their approaches and resulting media relations.

Yet another perspective is taken in Chapter 7, contributed by Hoffmann and Neumayer. They argue that the social media communication of movement parties allows us to observe their alignments and realignments in the protest as well as institutional arena. The chapter scrutinizes this positioning and repositioning over time by a longitudinal analysis of movement parties' social media communication on Facebook, Twitter and Instagram across the six country cases. Taking official party accounts as a starting point, it develops the argument by analyses of parties' protest-related digital public communication, of their visual communication – that is, the use of protest images across platforms – and of movement parties' positioning in the institutional arena reflected in their mentioning of traditional party families. Adding a temporal layer to observe changes over time, this chapter provides an overview of the different trajectories of movement parties and subsequently, their alignments and realignments between the protest and polity arena in their social media communication.

Finally, Wagemann, Glukhova and Geyer take a policy perspective in Chapter 8. It considers how movement parties articulate political demands (as citizens express them through social movements) in parliamentary proceedings and government action. In other words, this chapter looks at the transition of social movements' political demands into the political system, discussing several variants of success and failure for core policy demands made by protest movements in Denmark, Germany and Italy.

In the conclusive Chapter 9, Paxton, Glukhova, Hoffmann, Mărgărit and Santos enlarge the aim of our project regarding an enhancement of democratic quality. The chapter discusses the single objectives of the book and identifies the common themes of the single chapters, in order to arrive at a coherent summary. This will includes indications for future research and a discussion of the policy relevance of the findings.

At the end of this research process which for us was a wonderful experience in many respects, the authors and editors of this book want to express their gratitude to important protagonists without whom it would have been much more difficult to arrive at our conclusions.

First of all, we are most grateful to the Volkswagen Foundation, for accepting our research proposal and financing our proceedings. We are thankful for all the support from Annabella Hüfler-Fick, Malene Hummel and Nicole Richter, but our deepest gratitude goes to Cora Schaffert-Ziegenbalg, who has always been very interested in our research project, has contributed with her ideas and her encouragement, gave us the pleasure to be with us at two policy events and supported our efforts in all possible ways. Thanks to the great people at the Volkswagen Foundation, the funder's engagement went far beyond financial support but was also substantial and occurred with regard to dissemination. We could not think of a better funder!

We are furthermore grateful to all policymakers and NGOs who were involved with our two conferences in Brussels in late 2022 and late 2023. The 2022 event was hosted at the European Parliament by MEP Nicu Ștefănuță with the support of EP Vice President Katarina Barley, MEP Daniel Freund and MEP Dacian Cioloș, and we welcomed NGOs from Brussels as well as from some ProDem partner countries. The 2023 conference was organized at the premises of the European Youth Forum, to which we would like to express our gratitude, particularly to Marina Jarcevic, Anna Blackwell and Kristof Papp for arranging all the necessary logistics. We are also thankful to European Commission's Vice-President and Commissioner for Democracy and Demography (2019–2024), Dubravka Šuica, and to MEP and Vice-Chair of the Committee on Constitutional Affairs, Gabriele Bischoff, for their active participation during the event and engagement with the policy recommendations of our report.

Finally, we want to thank all those who collaborated at various steps of this process with us (in alphabetical order): Anna Anlauft, László Boroffka, Hannah Curran-Troop, Laura Debell, Ralf Keil, Heike Langholz, Lex Metzeld, Anna Nørgaard Hansen Nielsen, Max Propadalo and Nils Sartorius. And without Anna Geyer's continuous administrative support, such an international enterprise would have been much more difficult.

With this book, we hope to contribute to an ongoing discussion on protests and democracy. During the time of our research, we had to witness quite some serious changes in the world which surrounds us. Not only did protest activity intensify – not least to the COVID pandemic – but it also changed its character. We see an increase in more fundamental protests which

target the second part of our acronym: democracy. Protests not only are directed toward or against substantial issues but also often connect the interest in the issue with doubts on or questioning of democracy. During and after the COVID crisis, which also affected our work processes, we discovered that our topic will be even more relevant in the near future.

This project was financed by the Volkswagen Foundation, AZ 98 144.

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2 Democratic quality and the triple interaction of social movements, movement parties and citizens

From protests to institutions

Dan Mercea, Dana S. Trif and Claudius Wagemann

Protests and democracy

A renewed focus on the triple interaction of citizens, social movements and movement parties

Since 2011 and in the wake of the European financial, economic and migration crises, mass protests have engendered new social movements and political parties. This development has been interpreted in two main ways. Research into political culture describes the increase in protests as a consequence of long-term sociocultural change, leading to growing numbers of "critical citizens" who question authority but remain committed to democratic values (Dalton and Welzel, 2014; Norris, 2011). Protesting therefore belongs to civic attitudes deeply rooted in European democracies (Klingemann, 2014, pp. 139–140), albeit while assuming a new form.

Some of the researchers studying the "quality of democracy" have developed a more ambivalent interpretation that paints the spread of protests as symptomatic of democratic backsliding (Bermeo, 2016; Foa and Mounk, 2016; Krastev, 2016), with regard to (at least) two dimensions. On the one hand, protests express dissatisfaction with the performance of democracies in terms of political output: citizens are not satisfied with the substantial results originating from policy processes. On the other hand, sizeable sections of the citizenry no longer use voting as the conventional form of political protest. Such citizens may no longer consider their vote to be effective or meaningful, or they might not have found suitable electoral alternatives among established political parties. However, this latter perspective does not only trigger unconventional participation such as street protests or which manifests in other non-institutional forms. Instead, protest can also occur *through* conventional participation, such as by voting, namely as an electoral decision in favor of those political parties which consider and present themselves to be skeptical (to different degrees) about established democratic processes and actors. Often, this entails voting for populist parties, which ultimately

DOI: 10.4324/9781003532507-2

contributes to an erosion of liberal democratic standards from within party politics (Pirro, 2016).

Such processes often unfold as an interplay of top-down and bottom-up processes. Some social movements and their populist party vehicles actively mobilize citizens by framing political conflicts as a confrontation between corrupt, unaccountable, foreign-controlled, mainstream media-supported elites and ordinary people (Mudde, 2004), often expressing their grievances on social media (Engesser et al., 2017; Neumayer, 2015). As researchers, we tend to care more about those more extreme cases that are concerning when contemplated from the perspective of pluralistic and consensual ideas of democracy. Polarizing worldviews, often coupled with nativist frames, tend to negate political pluralism and erode attachment to the norms underpinning liberal democracy (Levitsky and Ziblatt, 2018; Mudde, 2007). At the same time, it should be noted that serious worries about the state and the results of democracy might have also incentivized protest activities, since there are many examples of activists who have resorted to protest to resist illiberal policies (Dimitrova, 2018; Fomina and Kucharczyk, 2016). In the end, such changes in the workings of democracy may be worrisome for some while being regarded as a healthy development in contemporary democracy, by others. What is important to note is that they involve a sometimes-complex interplay between individual actors and different types of political organizations. Also, some protests harm contemporary democracy, while others try to protect it.

Our research takes into consideration how interactions between active citizens, social movements and a specific variety of political parties (so-called movement parties, della Porta et al., 2017; Kitschelt, 2006; Mosca and Quaranta, 2017) affect democratic quality in Europe. By movement parties we understand a political organization, historically instigated by social movement actors seeking to transfer a set of issues from the arena of protest politics to the electoral and policy-making arenas (Kitschelt, 2006). Resulting organizations – typified by socialist parties that emerged out of the labor movement and the green parties that arose out of the environmental movement (della Porta et al., 2017) – may continue to track closely to their founding movement and its repertoire of actions, formalizing its rules and procedures to different degrees.

In this volume, we situate movement parties within what we understand as the *triple interaction* between active citizens, social movements and movement parties. We do so to develop a theoretical perspective for an examination of the medium- and long-term effects of the triple interaction on democratic quality in European democracies. Our aim is to chart a new pathway to a fuller understanding of how social movements and movement parties, alongside shifting divisions in citizens' values, ideologies and attitudes, have affected democratic quality in Europe. In that analysis, we pay particular attention to the role of "media" (including both traditional mass media and newer forms of social media), since, in our framework, changes

within their sphere are closely connected to changes with regard to protests and challenges for democracy. In what follows, we outline an integrated conceptual framework for empirical investigations of the triple interaction of citizens, movements and movement parties. This assesses the extent to which the transmission belt of traditional representative politics has been readjusted by recent waves of mass protests and by these protests' impact on democratic quality across the dimensions of participation, competition and responsiveness, which we discuss later.

Relationships between active citizens, social movements and movement parties unfold in two arenas that are often studied separately, namely the protest and the institutional arena (McAdam and Tarrow, 2010). The protest arena is that of informal political actions among participants in protest events and civil society. The institutional arena pertains to the articulation of issues at the electoral and governmental levels. Movement parties assume a special position in this, as they can be a bridge between the two arenas. Boosted by protest waves, they emerge from the protest arena and compete with political parties in the institutional arena. This process plays out on multiple stages: in the streets, on social media, in the traditional media, during elections and inside political institutions. The interaction then, between movement parties, active citizens and social movements, that we thus seek to understand is a topic that speaks directly to the observation by some social movement scholars that there is an apparent lack of systematic cross-disciplinary work on the growing synergies between movements and political parties (Borbáth and Hutter, 2021; Hutter and Borbáth, 2019; McAdam and Tarrow, 2010; Pirro, 2019). An early warning from McAdam and Tarrow (2010, p. 532) called attention to the disconnection between the theoretical realization that "elections and social movements are two major forms of political conflict in democratic systems" and the fact that they were academically largely considered in isolation from each other. Conversely, those authors proposed a focus on elections as a flashpoint that sees social movements and political parties acting either in concert or in conflict (see also Schwartz, 2010), thereby presenting an opportunity to examine them together, rather than as discrete figures on the canvas of history or the political system. By so doing, McAdam and Tarrow (2010, p. 533) invited observers to question the means and motives that social movements have for joining electoral campaigns; what impact they have on existing political parties or how and why they become or establish parties themselves; how they innovate electoral campaigns by adding their action repertoires to a campaign; how they drive or thwart electoral mobilization.

In the similar language used to refer to the capacity of political parties to bridge the relationship between the citizenry and the government (Luttbeg, 1974), McAdam and Tarrow (2010, p. 533) called these processes "linkage mechanisms". Whilst they highlighted both how social movements can strengthen connections with the electorate or weaken them, and how they can change existing parties or create new ones, their conceptual foray was

narrowly confined to the context of electoral competition. Likewise, they had little to say not just about how social movements influence political parties more broadly but also how political parties react to social movements.

More recently, however, comparative research has pointed to a mutual reinforcement between political parties and social movements to the extent that party members were shown to be particularly likely to participate in movement protests if they believed doing so would help their party (Giugni and Grasso, 2021, p. 97; see also Schussman and Soule, 2005). Conversely, there is evidence that protest participants were likely to be members of civic organizations, parties or trade unions (e.g., in Belgium; Norris et al., 2005). At the same time, a situation left mostly unexplored by this literature is when social movements actively found or transform into a political party, for example *Momentum Mozgalom* ("Movement Party"), the Hungarian movement party whose name mirrors its social movement roots or the epitome movement party in Italy, Movimento 5 Stelle (Mosca, 2014). Yet, another strand of research has posited a negative relationship between the access to the institutional arena afforded by parties and movement mobilization (Piven and Cloward, 1978), the latter of which was described as more likely in a context where movement claims are not championed by parties in the institutional arena (Giugni et al., 2005). This view presumes a mutual compensation function. What is more, McAdam and Tarrow (2010) gave no consideration to other arenas where political parties and social movements may meet, such as in the media or on social media.

If social movements and political parties work in complementary ways, then the question about the analytical arena – protest or institutional – arises. With regard to this, more recent research emphasizes that "the choice of political arena in which they [movement-party coalitions or new movement parties both on the left and the right] express themselves is . . . an expression of their underlying message" (Hutter and Borbáth, 2019, p. 488). Put differently, movements and parties may deliberately choose the protest and/or the institutional arena to enact their socio-culturally conservative or liberal issues such as immigration or gender rights, as they deploy strategies for maximizing their strengths in either of them. For example, Green activists may favor tried and tested protest mobilization whereas far-right parties may expend more effort into mobilizing voters on immigration (Hutter and Borbáth, 2019).

However, McAdam and Tarrow's (2010), Schwartz's (2010), Hutter and Borbáth's (2019) and Borbáth and Hutter's (2020) treatments of the linkages between movements and parties share the idea that the citizenry is an abstraction rather than an active agent whose preferences and behavior have an impact on the operation of the other two. Moreover, all these studies conceive of an unspecified arena of movement–party interplay and eschew a situated analysis of these actors in relation to the media or on social media. There are thus two blind spots which we will detail further later. The first blind spot will be overcome through the integration of citizens as a further actor into

the model which adds to the interplay of social movements and political parties. The interaction thus becomes a triple one. We posit that extending the analysis of the dynamics between movements and parties to account for their relations with the citizenry instigates an analytical departure from the more common, objectivist and static inspection of political opportunity structures that may or may not facilitate them (Kingston, 2019, p. 119). To that end, *we propose the notion of the triple interaction as the mutual, dynamic activation of relations between active citizens, social movements and movement parties, across the protest and institutional arenas, which ultimately affects democratic quality.*

The first blind spot – bringing citizens into the picture – enlarges the analysis from a meso perspective looking at political organizations such as social movements and political parties by a micro-level interest in individuals, such as active citizens. This necessarily results in a discussion on political participation which has certainly evolved along with the post-industrial transformation of many late-modern societies (Dalton, 2006; Dalton, 2017; Giddens, 2013). Evidence-based classifications of participation point to a cultural turn away from conceptions of participation as a duty – based on an allegiance to democratic institutions and organizations such as parties (Bennett et al., 2009) – and toward an "assertive" stance predicated on a critical evaluation of them (Dalton, 2006, p. 101). As such, taxonomies of participation record an array of modalities of engagement beyond the dutiful act of voting, for example to include *party, protest* and *contact activities* along with *consumer participation* (Teorell et al., 2007). The latter refers principally to value-based spending decisions – for example, pertaining to the ethical sourcing of goods and services – while the former are acts of involvement with organizations, community or political leaders and in public events (e.g., demonstrations), allowing a greater scope for accountability and influence outside of the electoral cycle or of the framework of representative institutions (Ekman and Amnå, 2012).

These modes of participation have been shown to be correlated with voting as the most conventional form of participation (e.g., in a cross-national analysis of European countries from East, Central, Northern Europe and Portugal; Teorell et al., 2007, pp. 351–354) while participating in a demonstration has been linked to voting for some varieties of movement parties (see Santos and Mercea in this volume). The correlation between unconventional forms of participation and voting may be explained as a generational change as younger citizens disavow the interpretation of voting as a duty whilst harboring a declining sense of political efficacy (Blais and Rubenson, 2013).

Against this backdrop and a noted secular drop in support for political parties (Gauja, 2015; Van Biezen et al., 2012), a decrease in electoral turnout (Kostelka and Blais, 2021) and a rise in non-electoral participation especially among the young (Dalton, 2017), it is all the more important to reflect on the first of the two blind spots mentioned earlier. It regards the interaction between active citizens, on the one hand, and social movements and

movement parties as political organizations, on the other. This triple interaction may signal a transformation of political participation, at the beginning of the 21st century, inviting a renewed consideration of political mobilization. On the one hand, decreasing voter turnout has been attributed to a loss in the mobilization capacity of traditional parties and trade unions (Gray and Caul, 2000), although a generational effect likely supersedes it (likely also thanks to the diffusion of the internet and social media, Kostelka and Blais, 2021; Teresi and Michelson, 2015). On the other, recent empirical scholarship has shown that new movement parties emerging over the last decade have successfully attracted the votes of protest participants in Italy and Spain (although not in Greece or Portugal where movement parties have longer histories that include parliamentary representation; Mosca and Quaranta, 2017, p. 438). Such studies show that citizen-driven protests either transform social movements into movement parties (Italy and Spain) or connect with movement parties that already exist (Greece, Portugal). Moreover, Movimento 5 Stelle (M5S) in Italy and Podemos in Spain have portrayed themselves as electoral innovators seeking to marry loose, open and horizontal modalities of involvement in *party activities* by drawing on their movement legacies, relying on online platforms and social media to enable them (Mercea and Mosca, 2021). As illustrated, such movement parties are noteworthy for our purposes. For instance, it has been suggested that lately, in well-established and consolidated European political systems, traditional parties concentrate on electoral competition, thereby leaving open a space for other political groups to mobilize public support for issues outside of the institutional arena (Borbáth and Hutter, 2020). In such contexts, traditional parties that are nevertheless becoming involved in protests were akin to movement parties in that "they belong to the green or radical right party family, are in opposition, without government experience, and adopt a mass-party organisation" (Borbáth and Hutter, 2020, p. 9).

Importantly, also, citizens' protest mobilization may contribute to electoral outcomes without the explicit involvement of traditional parties in them in as far as protests "can draw voters' attention . . . educate voters on a topic and lead them to vote for candidates whose platforms and ideological positions are consistent with [their] grievances" (Gillion and Soule, 2018, p. 1660). Equally, the same authors argue, when challenging incumbents, candidates may champion issues surfaced by citizen-driven protests. As such, protests can reinforce ideological leanings, inform voting preferences and act as an additional layer of a social environment that is conducive to participation (Gillion and Soule, 2018, p. 1660). To sum up, the triple interaction links together active citizens, social movements and movement parties in highly differentiated political systems where the latter act as challengers to incumbent parties. The analytical inclusion of the active citizens' perspective and role into our theoretical model makes it possible to consider a core function of political organizations, such as social movements or political parties, to wit, to foster political participation.

Turning now to the second blind spot, namely of the arenas where citizens, movements and parties meet, a relationship has been evinced between attention afforded by the media to issues at the heart of a protest or other social movement activities and their airing by members of legislatures (Vliegenthart et al., 2016). Put another way, mass media mediate this interplay providing political elites with a signal as to "*how many* people care about the problem and *to what* extent they care about it" (Vliegenthart et al., 2016, p. 840). Indeed, the same study highlighted the absence of direct effects of protest on parliamentary agendas in all but one of the six Western European countries analyzed (i.e., Belgium; Vliegenthart et al., 2016, p. 864). The significance of these findings is not only that they situate the triple interaction in a concrete setting – namely of the media coverage of protest – but more importantly that they alert us to the possibility of a lack of a direct effect of protest on representative politics.

Further reflection moreover allows one to see the triple interaction in a different light. Such mediation is not simply a functional process; it is a cultural process situated in economic, political and social relations that puts active citizens, social movements and movement parties in competition with media organizations for the interpretation of social movement identities and actions (Mattoni and Treré, 2014). The latter observation is rooted in analyses looking at the diffusion of information and communication technologies (ICTs). ICTs were hailed for ushering in a new age of disintermediation (Castells, 2007) thanks to increasingly inexpensive alternatives and later social media presenting a growing plurality of groups with the means to signal to multiple publics – including political representatives – what issues concerned them and those to whom they gave voice online (for a meta-analysis, see Boulianne, 2015). Among such groups were "a coalition of excluded opinions, views and expression that no longer fit within the liberal parliamentary political arena" (Neumayer and Svensson, 2016, p. 132) embodied by social movements such as Occupy Wall Street, #MeToo, Black Lives Matter, Fridays for Future as well as by the Pegida rallies against the purported Islamization of Europe or protests against COVID-19 public health measures and vaccination initiatives. Such disintermediation did not only affect the relationship of social movements with political parties as old and new parties reimagined memberships (Deseriis, 2019). It was likewise seized on by political parties as an opportunity to connect directly with supporters (Mercea and Mosca, 2021) in a plebiscitarian turn predicated on the direct mobilization of popular majorities (De Nadal, 2023). Again, it is the consideration of the citizens' perspective that completes the picture of the democratic political landscape. Altogether then, such research has been successful in disentangling dyadic relations between social movements and movement parties, social movements and active citizens, or movement parties and active citizens as they play out in contemporary public life, in the mass media and/or on social media. Next, we discuss how these developments reflect democratic quality.

The analytical relevance

Dimensions of democratic quality

As has already been specified in this chapter, our ambition is not only to study very specific processes of a triple interaction or a linkage between different political arenas. This is rather embedded into a broader interest in democratic quality. We consider protests and their function as potential modes of articulating citizens' demands and, as such, a central category of democracy. Protest activities can only occur in a healthy democracy which opens sufficient spaces for mobilization. Furthermore, the question of how far protests are then absorbed into the core of the political system where political decisions are made (usually in the parliamentary or governmental sphere, which we have identified earlier as the "institutional arena") opens the door to enquiries into the accountability and responsiveness of central actors, and of their connection to (parts of) the *demos*. It thus also becomes a question of issue representation in a democracy.

At the same time, however, protests can also be dysfunctional: if unconventional participation dominates conventional participation, then this might be an indication that the channels of conventional participation do not function well enough. If issues brought forward in protests by a minority dominate a different opinion of the so-called silent majority, the question of issue representation arises again. If protest promotes illiberal or even undemocratic content, or if it supports other actors' illiberal or undemocratic agendas and strategies, then the substantial side of democratic quality might suffer. Thus, the blunt statement "the more protest, the more democratic quality" is too simple.

Of course, democracy is *the* key term in political science, and it is therefore not surprising that there are not only a variety of definitions, but that there is also an intense and often contradictory scientific literature. As it happens often, scholars have the tendency to try and "measure" those definitions quantitatively, no matter how vague they are (for the relation between concepts and measurement, see Goertz, 2020). Indeed, there are many accounts of how democracy can be measured, originally used in order to differentiate between democracies and non-democracies, no matter whether in a dichotomous or a gradual understanding (Collier and Adcock, 1999; Coppedge et al., 2011). These attempts to "measure" democracy resulted in an interest in a subset of countries which are all considered democracies, but which differ in terms of their "quality" (Diamond and Morlino, 2004). The term "quality" has the fruitful characteristic that it can be understood as a rank order concept (more quality or less quality), but also as a typology, referring to different qualities (or types, or variants, or sub-dimensions) of a concept. Since our ambition is to consider democratic quality as the ultimate *telos* of the processes we study, rather than to establish causal and quantifiable links between protest representation and democratic quality, we limit ourselves to

using this debate as a framework within which we operate and which we use in order to position our work in a broader discussion.

We take advantage of a concept of democratic quality which, as a first step, establishes "secondary-level dimensions" (as per the wording in Goertz, 2020, p. 28). In other words, it guides our decision as to which specific aspects or democratic quality to consider. We rely on the conceptual dimensions developed by Morlino (2011). Among the dimensions he has defined, *participation*, *competition*, and *responsiveness* appear as the most relevant to us (Morlino, 2011, pp. 204–207). The importance of participation is obvious, since our thinking is closely tied to protest as one of various modes of participation. Also, our reflections on potentially dysfunctional aspects of protest point to a differentiated evaluation of political participation. In short, the notion of participation relates to a set of behaviors (conventional or unconventional, legal, or borderline illegal), allowing individuals or groups to have an effect on group identification and influence (representative and/or governmental) political authorities.

Competition, the second dimension, is characterized by fairness and freedom to compete for all informal and formal groups. With regard to informal groups, competition is related to questions such as possibilities for mobilization, but also aspects such as representation of (silent) majorities and (loud) minorities. The idea of competition is more widely considered for formal groups such as political parties. Parties compete for mandates, offices and policy issues. Being linked to social movements and/or citizen protests can equip them with competitive advantages or, equally, disadvantages. On the advantage side, social movements can lend electorates to political parties and thus increase their competitiveness. On the disadvantage side, the identification of political parties (or also other corporate political actors, such as trade unions) with certain forms of protest or social movements might alienate potential voters and create challenging ties with an arena that follows a different logic of action. Finally, responsiveness describes the capacity to respond to people's political demands. This is also a two-sided sword. While one may assume it to be the core attribute of a democracy (and it actually is), the question remains whether protests or social movements really represent the *demos*.

These dimensions are useful analytical frames, since they respond to various moments of the triple interaction: protests, movement parties and – in response – also traditional parties affect modes and qualities of participation; the shifting relevance of actors in the triple interaction – no matter whether protests or movement parties – affects competition; and the policy measures and other forms of resonance which may follow protests and that are often transported into the institutional arena via movement parties are connected to questions of responsiveness. Taken together, these three dimensions of democratic quality provide us with the insight that studying the triple interaction also means studying democratic quality in a larger sense.

Within this conceptual framework, we advocate for a cohesive perspective following through on the growth and political effects of citizen participation

within emerging social movements and movement parties in the era of multiple European crises experienced since the start of the 21st century. These crises have prompted large-scale protests while widening political and societal divides over democracy as a political system, globalization, EU integration and immigration (Bastos et al., 2018; Hooghe and Marks, 2018; Kriesi, 2012). These processes, unfolding at the intersection of institutional politics, social movements and citizen engagement, foreground democratic quality.

Protests increasingly shift from targeting single issues to skepticism about the functioning of (representative) democracy in general. This is not new and has continuously occurred amidst both the political left and the political right. But complaints seem to have become more fundamental. Furthermore, the recent crises have triggered two new phenomena: on the one hand, new sources of protest are not limited to the political left or the political right but are claimed to emerge in the "middle of the society", or are associated with novel political spheres such as conspiracy thinking or also radical climate activism. On the other hand, political orientations grow into each other, as far as criticism of democracy and its processes as such is concerned. The left and the right take sides in criticizing the dominance of elites; migration is attacked from the left and the right; the right embarks on conspiracy theories, and the left follows, etc. Thus, the era of multiple crises seems to have galvanized protests, and this time, it seems that these protests do not favor democratic quality, but rather bear the risk of democratic backsliding. This makes it relevant to consider democratic quality when studying the triple interaction at the heart of our research.

A unified framework

Protest, movement parties and democratic quality

Our analysis of the triple interaction of active citizens, social movements and movement parties – within the framework of democratic quality – is grounded in a simultaneous assessment of the two arenas in which the three elements of this interaction play out. Such an expanded and complex analytical focus has certain gains: first, when we expand the analysis of the protest arena to the institutional arena, we take into account that the political system in general shapes and influences the protest arena (Tarrow, 2011); second, when we expand the analysis of the institutional arena to the protest arena, we consider phenomena such as mainstream conservative parties using arguments of the radical right, or social democratic parties reacting to protests on inequality, or green parties becoming vehicles of climate protests. In other words, such analysis focuses on actors of the institutional arena (e.g., political parties) when looking at the protest arena and those of the protest arena when looking at the institutional arena (e.g., active citizens and social movements). This allows us to arrive at a more complete picture encompassing the two.

In the protest arena, this analytical framework enables us to investigate citizens' propensity to participate in protests and its relationship to voting. This allows us to assess whether social movements and movement parties have succeeded over the past decade in representing sociodemographic sectors previously marginalized by representative politics. Yet, democratic quality does not remain in the protest arena, but this approach makes its intrinsic connection to the institutional arena visible, since voting is the key linkage between citizens and the institutional arena. Placing democratic quality between the protest and the institutional arena, we are able to analyze patterns of political participation by citizens drawn to protests, their values, political attitudes, ideologies, socio-psychological orientations and digital media usage.

We can take either the protest or the institutional arena as a point of analytical departure. If we start from the protest arena, we are able to gauge the role of discursive strategies for mobilizing citizens. This furthers our understanding of how social movements and parties politicize conflicts and enhance or hinder socioeconomic and cultural inclusiveness. The language employed by protesters, civic organizations, social movements and movement parties helps systematically identify the ideological elements at play in the protest arena but also participation and competition within it.

These elements affect wider socioeconomic and cultural inclusiveness allowing us to devote particular attention to populism and contribute to the emerging research interest connecting the latter to political identities (Meléndez and Rovira Kaltwasser, 2019; Mosca and Tronconi, 2019; Mudde, 2007; Pirro, 2016). Understanding such discourses and their consequences for democratic quality between the protest and institutional arena offers sufficient flexibility for identifying the usage of both traditional ideological elements and new, alternative constructs.

Conversely, taking the institutional arena as a point of departure enables us to investigate how challengers' (such as movement parties) media strategies change over time because of institutionalization processes, prompting reactions from media institutions to further our understanding of competition instigated by movement parties and responsiveness by media institutions in light of these challengers' actions. In considering mutual relationships between social movements and media, we build upon the "4 A" model, a social movement studies typology describing four non-exclusive communication strategies used by movements in reaction to lack of media coverage (Mosca and Vaccari, 2017; Rucht, 2004): abstention, attack, adaptation and alternative.

Social movements can decide to abstain from communicating publicly, shifting all communication within the group or to engage in explicit and even violent attacks on traditional media. Alternatively, social movements that desire better media coverage may adapt to media codes, formats and routines. Finally, many social movements attempt to create alternative media to offset the lack of interest or description bias from mainstream media. From media studies, we borrow and adapt the "media-market life cycle" of populist movements (Mazzoleni, 2008).

According to Mazzoleni's model, a distinction between elite media/quality press and tabloid media/free press is key to understanding relationships between various media outlets and social movements at different phases. On the one hand, elite media bear the risk of defending the status quo when it is threatened by anti-establishment movements. This often implies more or less overt opposition to challengers, including stigmatization and minimization. On the other hand, tabloid media are sympathetic to such new political actors, not necessarily due to an ideological affinity but more due to their inherently commercial character, marked by receptiveness to popular tastes and by their novelty. Elite media's critical stance toward challengers is typical of their early phases, tending to change with access to representative assemblies, institutionalization (Pedersen, 1982) and "parliamentarization", as parliamentary activities become the primary focus of party action (Leonardi et al., 1978, p. 162). Institutionalization and parliamentarization can act as critical junctures for both party communication strategies and their media coverage.

The two processes may lead to the eventual acceptance of challengers within the institutional arena. Spectacle-hungry tabloid media are prone to granting access and visibility to new movements and their controversial issues from the start, yet such legitimation may become indifference or even hostility once movements stabilize within institutional routines. The simultaneous adoption of Rucht's and Mazzoleni's typologies sheds light on the game of mirrors between media and movement parties from a comparative perspective, elucidating both how movement parties react to traditional media and how media respond to movement emergence and consolidation.

Moreover, starting the analysis from the institutional arena, we can assess social movements' and movement parties' use of social media, focusing on the linkages they develop with other actors. Social movement strategies in the "4 A" model (see earlier; Rucht, 2004) are increasingly dominated by the use of digital and social media (e.g., Facebook, Twitter and YouTube). Social media communication has become increasingly relevant in political campaigning throughout Europe and particularly for less-established parties, the "underdogs" of the political system (Larsson and Kalsnes, 2014), such as movement parties. Alongside their links with traditional media, movement parties may establish connections to interest and civil society groups, social movements, religious organizations, traditional political institutions and alternative media (della Porta et al., 2017). Yet, this may change with electoral success as the previous "underdogs" step into the role of the governing or opposition in parliament.

Political parties, interest groups and social movements may borrow digital organizational and mobilization repertoires from one another (Chadwick, 2007), in contemporary "hybrid media systems" (Chadwick et al., 2017), as they actively shape their public representation. At the same time, observing alignments of movement parties on different social media platforms over time makes it possible to understand how their general network structures diverge

as well as to map changes in their organizational networks and linkages to the media in key transitional periods, such as following electoral success or failure (Hoffmann and Neumayer, 2024).

And finally, what then happens when movement parties may politically represent the concerns voiced during mass protests in the institutional arena? Inspecting their relationships with institutions and considering whether they contribute to legislative initiatives enhancing citizens' political participation allows us to understand the responsiveness of movement parties, a further dimension of democratic quality. The degree to which movement parties shepherd the primary concerns of a social movement into the institutionalized core of the political system clarifies the relative success of political participation via movement parties and the responsiveness of the system. Such translations can thus be regarded as positive indicators of democratic quality. However, it might be that the contents (hotly contested or extremist positions) or political styles (populist rhetoric) that movement parties introduce into the core of the political system are partly or completely unconnected to the issues raised by social movements.

Movement parties may define movement demands as their own political agenda and therefore compete with the social movement for public attention. They may thus exercise self-interested selectivity in the choice of issues they carry into the institutional arena. Inspired by the process-tracing literature (Bennett and Checkel, 2014; Blatter and Haverland, 2012), our theoretical framework recognizes that various temporal processes may influence choice formation (Grzymala-Busse, 2011): movement parties may initially embrace the demands and subsequently relinquish them or decrease their prominence.

At the same time, responsiveness to requests from social movements could spill beyond movement parties when established political actors embrace movement concerns. As a result, movement parties' bridging function in linking the movement and the core political system may diminish. Movement parties may furthermore themselves move into government (e.g., Italy's Movimento 5 Stelle and Romania's USR PLUS), represent the primary opposition (e.g., the UK's Labour Party), have no impact on government activity (e.g., Germany's AfD), or have their issues absorbed by adjacent government parties (e.g., Hungary's Jobbik). A multifaceted image of relationships between movement parties and the core political system thus emerges. Ultimately, assessing the complexities, as they transpire, between the protest and institutional arena, calls attention to democratic quality as a concept accounting for the triple interaction's effect on the political system. Interaction modes mainly vary by two sets of factors. On the one hand, they reflect citizens' demands (and thus characteristics of movement parties), which themselves reflect divisions and conflicts present in the individual political systems. On the other hand, as additions to established political systems, movement parties are also shaped by those systems' embedded rules and traditions; their range of action inevitably depends upon structural and cultural aspects of the political environments in which they act.

The research strategy

An agenda for the empirical study of the triple interaction

The empirical study of the triple interaction engages with the already-mentioned representative transmission belt of politics. The country cases analyzed in this volume encompass established Western democracies as well as newer democracies of Eastern Europe. Our aim is to both bridge the protest and institutional arenas, which have so far been studied separately, and overcome research challenges raised by the separate study of the actors in the triple interaction, in Western and Eastern Europe. In this section, we put forward five propositions for this undertaking.

Proposition no. 1. Social movements and movement parties enhance sociodemographic inclusiveness by mobilizing citizens who were previously disengaged from politics. With this proposition, we propose an examination of the varying degrees of participation in protests and electoral support for movement parties across six European countries. This can be achieved by means of *a representative, cross-national survey* constructed within a composite conceptual framework grounded in political participation, social movements and digital media theory on a continuum spanning institutional (e.g., voting) and extra-institutional (e.g., demonstrating) actions. The empirical treatment of this proposition helps to determine whether and under what conditions extra-institutional participation is a key correlative to support for movement parties. We present some of this analytical work in Chapter 4.

Proposition no. 2. The readiness of social movements and movement parties to consistently embrace socioeconomic and cultural inclusiveness depends on their ideological backgrounds. With this proposition, we advocate a deepening of the focus on informal politics occurring in the protest arena between citizens, protesters, civic organizations, emerging social movements and movement parties. Given that *Proposition no. 1* stresses the importance of assessing the extent to which new social movements are successful in electorally mobilizing previously politically disaffected citizens, *Proposition no. 2* identifies the discursive strategies through which such citizens are mobilized and (re)included into institutional politics. It thus aims to gauge the role discursive strategies play in mobilizing citizens and how social movements and movement parties politicize conflicts as well as enhance or hinder socioeconomic and cultural inclusiveness. *Proposition no. 2* thus opens the door to an analysis of the extent to which social movement and movement party discourses possess ideological diversity and a plurality of collective identities. We present some of this analytical work in Chapter 5.

Proposition no. 3. Movement parties tend to polarize public debates on sensitive issues by delegitimizing traditional sources of information at an early stage, adapting to media codes and routines once they access representative assemblies and institutionalize. Our third proposition concentrates on the analysis of democratic quality on how the relative electoral success

of movement parties affects their relationships with the media. A qualitative analysis of press coverage of movement parties, a qualitative analysis of discursive reactions on movement parties' media outlets, TV ratings for movement parties' visibility in newscasts and interviews with movement party communication managers, civil society leaders and journalists belonging to selected media outlets – all these give empirical and methodological flesh to *Proposition no. 3*. A timeframe sampling key phases in the movement party life course (official founding, entrance into representative institutions and more recent activity) can be adopted for qualitative analysis of newspaper, TV newscasts and movement party media outlets. We present some of this analytical work in Chapter 6.

Proposition no. 4. Social media linkages between movement parties and civil society actors as well as media and political institutions vary with their electoral success or failure. With this proposition, we draw attention to shifts over time in movement parties' social media presence. Their social media ecology now incorporates broadcast, interactive (i.e., audiences engaging with media outlets) and participatory media. The temporal perspective on movement parties was informed by findings on key phases in the movement party life course discussed in Chapter 7. *Proposition no. 4* allows us to map the social media presence of movement parties, to identify moments of substantial shifts over time (in activity on platforms, networks of social movements, media, civil society and political institutions). The analysis includes social media platforms that we believe to be most relevant in the European context, such as Facebook, Twitter, or Instagram. We present some of this analytical work in Chapter 7.

Proposition no. 5. Responsiveness to new political demands articulated by movement parties varies according to contextual conditions, including specific societal conflicts and demands, salience of policy issues, movement size (also in terms of public visibility), parties' parliamentary strength and polarization of the party system. This final proposition considers how movement parties articulate political demands (as citizens express them through social movements) in parliamentary proceedings and government action and concerns the transition of social movements' political demands into the political system. We expect that the success and failure of such integration vary according to contextual conditions, such as movement parties' parliamentary strength, their inclusion (or potential inclusion) in government activities, general salience of political demands, polarization and fragmentation of the party system and movement size. We present some of this analytical work in Chapter 8.

Scope of the analysis

Toward a better understanding of the democratic processes

In a time of continued and cross-national transformation of the electoral and party-political landscape, our focus on *the triple interaction of social*

movements, movement parties and citizens proposes a vital reassessment of democratic quality in Europe. Reconceptualizing the links between the *triple interaction* and *democratic quality* enables a meaningful, evidence-based, comparative and systematic approach to unconventional political participation and its effects on democratic political systems. Multiple crises suffered by European countries over the past decade have cast doubt on the ability of entrenched institutional and representative actors as well as the media to maintain democratic quality for the European citizenry. The triple interaction is a prominent manifestation of the challenge facing these actors.

Our design identifies citizens' voting patterns and their relationship to large-scale protests and evaluates whether public discourses used by protesters, social movements and movement parties are ultimately conducive to socioeconomic and cultural integration and, consequently, to deepening democratic quality. Further, it enables us to investigate the extent to which these political actors not only polarize but also distort public opinion or, alternatively, whether they promote countermeasures to disruptive communication; and, indeed, to research communication strategies that may engender disruptive communication. Finally, it allows us to highlight the challenges to which contemporary political systems are exposed.

Ultimately, our goal is to see whether democratic quality develops positively or negatively, as a result. Our hope is that this volume helps shed light on existing and potential measures that established democracies can take to respond to citizens' demands. This is politically highly relevant, given that new political actors increasingly determine European and EU politics, connecting our research with Europe's transforming democratic reality. In thinking about political relevancy in this way, then, we recognize that scholarly work often seeks to be policy-relevant. The overarching policy aim of our research is to enhance democratic quality in European countries by bringing our systematic comparative analysis into the public debate, thereby contributing to the empirical basis for policy change to address the issues that face contemporary democracies.

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3 Methodological pluralism in the study of political participation

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This volume deals with protests and democracy ("ProDem"). In our research, we claim that the enduring crises that surround us have also had an impact on protests and democracy as the two key phenomena under study and on the relation between them. However, it is commonplace that the ongoing crises did have their effects not only on abstract concepts, such as protest activities and democracy, but also on many other aspects, among them obviously people's concrete lives, but also on the way how science is perceived and, subsequently, how we conduct science. On the one hand, scientific results are increasingly quoted when it comes to political action, be it in the institutional or the protest arena. A first famous recent example is the climate crisis for which protesters very often underline that one main goal of their protests would be to make political decision-makers listen to and follow the climate protection advice given by scientists. Another recent example is the COVID pandemic during which scientists were frequently called upon in order to justify lockdown measures or to promote vaccination campaigns. On the other hand, this inclusion of scientists in public policymaking also resulted in scientists becoming targets of political protests, organized by those who felt their basic rights were being endangered through COVID measures. The same holds for some of the populist propaganda against climate protection who question the scientists' political neutrality or even their expertise. This public importance of scientists and science is partially new. It also means that scientific production cannot be primarily oriented toward an inward perspective, following which scientific results are mainly relevant for other scientists. Science increasingly has to consider a broader audience, and the reception of science can even become a political issue when people start to ask how far political decisions are taken by elected and accountable political decision-makers, or whether scientific experts directly or indirectly exert (too) much influence in political decision-making processes. While some Ancient Greek thinkers had much sympathy for such a "noocracy" (or, in Plato's terms, "sophocracy"), and also, citizens in some countries welcome "expert" or "technocratic" governments as a desired alternative to conventional governments which do not seem to work well, this is obviously a challenge for

DOI: 10.4324/9781003532507-3

modern democracy. Scientific advice and findings have to be built into societal and political procedures with care.

Apart from the necessity of the development of appropriate skills for "going public", this increasing connection between science and society requires science to be of "high quality". Only such high-quality science has the chance to have a credible effect on transformation processes and to be a legitimate part of public discourse. Many aspects can be considered when thinking of high-quality science (such as transparency or replicability), but an appropriate use of methods is certainly also part of such an agenda. What is more, next to the reliance on established (and often challenged) theories, the application of scientific methods can even be considered a core aspect of scientific work, differentiating the academic profession from adjacent fields that also deal with society and politics, such as journalism, belletristic literature, movies or artwork (see also Ragin, 1994). The appropriate application of scientific methods can be claimed to be central in order to render science "scientific".

While certainly some scientists might already disagree with this central role attributed to methods, the real quarrels start when it comes to the appropriateness of the application of methods. Rigid walls seem to exist between methodological camps and paradigms which were called "separate tables" or "sects" already early (Almond, 1988). However, also within the various methodological paradigms, such a myriad of methods has started to exist which requires an ever more specialized technical knowledge. As a consequence, the necessary overview to judge the appropriateness of the use of methods easily goes lost. On the other side, however, we witness a certain enthusiasm about "mixed methods" approaches, which seems to be the solution for all methodological problems and the new gold standard of doing research, thereby risking to overshadow important ontological and epistemological foundations (Beach and Kaas, 2020).

This chapter discusses these views with regard to our research in the ProDem project. We proceed in three steps. First, we elaborate on the topic of the appropriateness of methods from an abstract point of view. The overview which we give might sound well-known to those of our readers who are familiar with the debate, but rather new to novices who care more about substance than methods – which is pretty acceptable in a pluralistic world of science. Second, we refer to what this means for the study of protests, social movements and movement parties, which are the main research objects of this book. And, third, this chapter explicitly shows for the ProDem project how it was (hopefully successfully) tried to work with a multi-method approach in order to do justice to such a multifaceted research topic as protest and democracy.

The debate

The importance, but also the development of methods, not only is inevitably linked to the pursuit of the scientific discipline itself, but also relies on

the outside world which surrounds scientific activity. This latter point refers to those technical advances which can be considered watersheds in human development as well as in terms of scientific potential, such as the introduction of powerful computers half a century ago, or the availability of large amounts of data through the expansion of the internet a couple of years ago, or the victory of AI-governed procedures which becomes visible at the horizon in our times. The former point – the history of the discipline – is instead more complicated to address. First of all, topics are often, but not always, tied to one specific discipline. While our project title "Protests and Democracy" (ProDem) clearly suggests an important role for political science (democracy is one of *the* central terms of the discipline), it has nevertheless interdisciplinary characteristics. Protests as well as social movements are indeed political science categories, but have also been intensively studied by sociologists. Not least, the "merger" sub-discipline of political sociology exists. The importance which we assign to the study of traditional and social media (see Chapter 2) points to communication science as a further (young) discipline which has to be considered. Because of the increasing importance of algorithms and IT aspects in communication, communication science cannot be thought of anymore without reference to more technically oriented disciplines. Finally, there are good reasons to look at our topics under research from a linguistic perspective (e.g., considering the role of propaganda in protest mobilization) or from a historical one (since citizen grievances, political opportunity structures, protest modes or mobilization patterns might have historical roots).

Therefore, an interdisciplinary topic – and most social science topics carry interdisciplinary aspects – also relies on methods which have been developed in the different disciplinary communities. And since disciplinary boundaries themselves are fuzzy, not only the disciplines quoted earlier play a role when researching political science topics, but also neighboring ones, such as economics or philosophy.

This means that there cannot be *the* method for a social science project, since the disciplinary sources of the social sciences are so multifaceted. What is more, scientific disciplines do not develop at the same speed. Modern political science, for instance, can only be thought of when we assume a democratic environment where it can develop. Ultimately, political science means democracy science. As we all know, European democracy is a rather recent thing, and so is European political science. The various waves of democratization (Huntington, 1997) were also waves of the proliferation of political science. For example, political science in Central and Eastern Europe certainly has to be differentiated between its pre-1990 and its post-1990 variants. This, however, also means that professional, modern and democratic political science (in Europe, but also elsewhere) is *younger* than many other disciplines such as economics, sociology or ethnography, not to mention the ancient disciplines of philosophy and history. Indeed, most political science methods are borrowed from somewhere, be it from history, sociology or economics. Political science has only recently started to develop its own

methods, mainly for comparisons at the macro (country) level which do not have an easy equivalent in other disciplines.

As a consequence, political and social science scholars find themselves in a jungle of methodological opportunities. This renders their life particularly complicated since there is no single method which lends itself for ready and automatic usage. It might be an oversimplification to state that the natural sciences can rely on experiments as a characterizing standard method,[1] but such a ready-to-use answer does not exist in the social sciences.

It is therefore no surprise that the maturation of the discipline of political science (and other social sciences), which becomes manifest in the foundation of own professional associations (the European Political Science Association ECPR was founded in 1970) or the creation of political science chairs or even institutes at universities, also led to an increasing awareness on the use of methods. This professionalization of political science in Europe coincided with the era when the first powerful calculators (forerunners of our computers) were ready to be used to process huge amounts of data, but also when European and US-American political science developed different research interests, based on the fact that the (rather young) European branch detected the beauty of the variety of European political systems and engaged more in macro comparison and less in survey research at the individual level (Munck, 2007). In other words: at a certain point, political science had become so well-profiled and professionalized, and technicalities had developed in such a way, that the question of the *How* of research gained in importance.

Indeed, the fights over the appropriate approach already started in that era. Lijphart's (1971) seminal article on comparative politics and the comparative method testifies this. Although it is usually quoted as an incentive to use comparative methods, a careful reading creates some skepticism about Lijphart's enthusiasm regarding comparative methods. Very much to most scholars' surprise, Lijphart calls the comparative method "a very imperfect substitute" (Lijphart, 1971, p. 685). In fact, he makes up a rank order which places experiments at the top position of methodological choices. Being aware of the (at least at the time) impossibility to use the experimental logic of the natural sciences for the social sciences, Lijphart accepts the statistical method as his number two of the rank list which at least shares the central element of randomization with experiments. The comparative method (which we would call a small-N comparison today) then comes into play as the number three. Considering that Lijphart's rank list only comprises three options, this is no good news for small-N designs. Indeed, it is the "N" – the number of cases – which Lijphart considers as a defining element for research practice. In his view, there is large-N research which can use statistical methods and comes close to the advantages of experiments; and then there is small-N to which researchers are forced when they compare countries and which, in his view, is methodologically clearly subordinate.

Apart from the funny insight that those many quotations which use Lijphart (1971) as a justification for or a defense of small-N methods

overlook Lijphart's central and very critical message, this is an early account of the skepticism toward certain types of political science methods.

Certainly, the critique of the large-N community on other approaches was no one-way street. Nevertheless, the large-N community was in a more advantageous position. The fact that this approach used numerical information rendered it clearer. The advent of modern computers made huge portions of data processable. And mathematics provided a complex toolset of procedures and techniques which made it possible to establish easily communicable and widely accepted parameters on the basis of which the quality of the findings could be judged. Compared to this, traditional macro-comparison which relied on thick descriptions and finally arrived at conclusions on many variables after studying only a few cases necessarily had to receive inferior recognition. This is even more the case for so-called interpretative approaches which are based on a different, usually non-positivist epistemology. Their view on the social world being (partially) constructed and their emphasis on the importance of the subjective attribution of meaning gave them the position at the other end of the spectrum, always under the threat of being regarded as non-scientific and greatly dependent on individual researchers' viewpoints.

This acute discussion certainly underwent an important moment when King et al. (1994) published their book on "Designing Social Inquiry", with the somewhat provocative sub-title "Scientific inference in qualitative research". The more senior author of this chapter was a political science student at the time and remembers the publication of "KKV" (using the initials of the three authors' surnames) as path-breaking, since many younger scholars in those days considered KKV to offer a possibility to overcome the accusation of being not scientific brought forward to qualitative research. Qualitative research in this sense can be understood as both the small-N comparative positivist approach in Lijphart's sense and the interpretative variant, although there is no real and broadly accepted definition of what qualitative research is.

The disappointment regarding KKV followed soon, namely when small-N scholars started to read the book. Not only was the book full of mathematical formula, but its bottom line was that qualitative research can develop a potential for scientific inference as more similar it becomes to quantitative research (most visibly in the sixth chapter which is full of recommendations on how to increase the number of cases under research). However, this disappointment with the hopes initially created by KKV triggered an impressive wave of reactions which can be seen as the start of an increased self-confidence of qualitative researchers (at least of those of the positivist small-N comparative camp) who used this window of opportunity to further develop and promote their methodological position. Although it took a decade, Brady and Collier (2010 [2004]) edited a volume with a potential response. Quite some other alternative proposals to a purely large-N perspective were made in other contributions (reviewed in Mahoney, 2010),

some of which – such as process tracing (Bennett and Checkel, 2015; Beach and Pedersen, 2016) or qualitative comparative analysis (QCA; Ragin, 2008; Schneider and Wagemann, 2012) – survived this discussion as case study designs of their own right.

After this more historical account, let us look at the current state of affairs.

There cannot be any doubt about the existence of a plentitude of available methods today, at the level of both concrete techniques (even leading to a problematic need for a specialization in terms of technical competencies) and designs. With regard to the latter, various proposals for a differentiation exist. The dichotomy of quantitative and qualitative methods is only one of them and certainly prevails, despite all lack of concreteness with regard to what "qualitative" is. Goertz and Mahoney (2012) give a number of (certainly debatable) criteria with the help of which qualitative and quantitative approaches can be differentiated. Recent empirical research by Kühn and Rohlfing (2022) suggests that it is difficult to find publications which are univocal applications of these criteria, so that Goertz' and Mahoney's (2012) proposal rather has to be seen as the formulation of ideal types and less as a recipe. However, Ragin (1994) also acknowledges that the "qualitative quantitative" dichotomy is not differentiated enough and adds "comparative" as a third category, referring to those approaches applying the "comparative method" in Lijphart's (1971) and later also Ragin's (1987) sense. Della Porta and Keating (2008) try yet another typology for methodological approaches and distinguish positivist, post-positivist, interpretative and humanistic methods. A more recent and currently not widely shared proposal is brought forward by Thelen and Mahoney (2015), who propose to differentiate between experimental methods on the one hand and quantitative or comparative case studies on the other.

Lieberman (2015, p. 243) even represents the available designs and methods in a three-dimensional cube and locates numerous different designs in the corners of the cube, on one of the plains or somewhere in the space of the cube. While Lieberman's representation seems very complex to the beginner, and not even methodological experts might know about all of the designs represented, his model is quite interesting for our purpose. As mentioned, his cube is (of course) made up of three dimensions. One is fairly well-known and has also been mentioned in this chapter, namely ranging from large-N (which Lieberman calls "quantitative") to small-N ("qualitative"). Being a continuum, this dimension also allows for intermediate situations of mid-sized-N (famously discussed in Ragin, 2000; therefore, it does not take any wonder that QCA is the only typical method for this scenario in Lieberman's representation). The second dimension is made up of micro and macro research, certainly also highly relevant for research at the crossroads of political science and sociology. Finally, experiments – Lijphart's (1971) gold standard – are taken up in the third dimension which differentiates between observational data/methods and experimental ones. These three dimensions can be combined in all possible ways. Just to give a couple of examples: standard surveys

represent the combination large-N * micro * observational; small sample experiments with aggregate subjects represent the combination small-N * macro * experimental; and comparative-historical case studies occupy the position of small-N * macro * observational, etc. Such a representation of methodological options is certainly useful, since it draws our attention to two facts: first, the number of cases ("N") is not the only criterion. There are more. Second, there is no natural and deterministic connection between the dimensions, such as large-N always looking at the micro level and small-N at the macro level, but all combinations of the dimensions are possible, even enriched through those methods which take an intermediate position with regard to one or several of the dimensions.

This is already a useful account when we want to speak about methodological appropriateness. Certainly, we might wonder whether these dimensions are already sufficient to describe the methodological world. We are convinced that, for example, ontological and epistemological perspectives are also important (Hall, 2003; Blatter et al., 2018). Furthermore, methodological appropriateness also depends on research questions, research interests and research goals. We follow Shapiro's (2002) plea following which the research question (he calls it the "problem") comes first, and only then methodological (and theoretical) decisions should be taken. For example, if interpretations of political phenomena are being researched, then a method (and a theory) which is powerful in dealing with them should be applied, most probably stemming from the interpretative, constructivist and discourse-oriented realm. If, however, protest frequency has to be assessed, then surveys or even observational techniques, looking at a large N, seem to be appropriate.

Next to this predominance of the research interest and the precise research question, we also adhere to a view which, despite all acknowledged importance of methodological rigor, design clarity and transparency, respects the needs of research pragmatism. On the one hand, this refers to research constraints. Although textbooks often tell us a different (and incorrect) story, research heavily depends on money and time constraints. Armchair research which does not have to respect the amount of available funds or submission deadlines is a nice but unrealistic illusion. Therefore, a mass survey might well be the best way to approach a research question, but if the researcher lacks the appropriate technical equipment or cannot financially afford to send out huge amounts of questionnaires by post services, then s*he has to look for a methodological alternative – or alter the research question (at least in part).

Finally, it is often overlooked that *all* research is prone to errors. It is an illusion to think that researchers are able to fully and completely correctly represent complex social processes in their results. If we just think of a rally as a form of protest, no research in the world is able to represent the complex and manifold actions connected to the rally, not to mention the participants' motivations, ideology, readiness to engage in a variety of

tactics, biographies, etc. Therefore, research is always approximative. The world will always look (much!) simpler in research than it actually is. Therefore, the appropriateness of methods is also determined through their limitations which are never zero. For instance, the search of quantitative methods of common patterns across research units that are rarely identical forces researchers to develop "thin concepts" (Coppedge, 1999) that simplify the dynamics they study even prior to data collection and processing. Thin concepts seek to provide a basic framework that can be applied across various contexts with little additional specification. They tend to simplify reality into more unidimensional and easily adaptable constructs that provide the space for measurements that can include non-identical units in the same analytical group. This simplification unavoidably leads to noise and errors generated by the differences across cases and deviations in the representation of a complex pattern into a single measurement. Statistical methods have found a useful way to deal with their limitations through standardized and widely known parameters, such as goodness-of-fit parameters (most prominently R-square measures or significance levels), although statisticians have warned against an excessive focus on these measures (see, for instance, Cumming, 2014; Gigerenzer, 2004; Wasserstein and Lazar, 2016). Rather than being used in order to underline the reliability of a result, they are above all indications of "errors" which can occur in the process of simplifying complex political dynamics into operationalizable research questions and hypotheses. For example, standard statistical methods only claim to be "estimations", and this is indeed what they are able to achieve.

Qualitative research is not free from problems of approximation, either. The small-N nature common to this scholarship allows researchers to develop "thick concepts" (Coppedge, 1999), which integrate a broader array of multifaceted attributes and contextual details, of the dynamics they study. However, qualitative research is also approximative as it derives from the co-construction of the reality of the researcher with the subjects under study (Finnemore and Sikkink, 2001), above all in its interpretive variant. Instead of using quantifiable measurements of error, qualitative scholars make their research accountable by carefully disclosing their relationship with their field of study, their research process and their background.

So, the history of social and political science methods is a history of rising differentiation, with most variants being characterized by their approximative nature. To acknowledge such limits is an important aspect of a high-quality application of methods. Thus, whichever approach we use, the quest for transparency unites all approaches.

This is also the basis of the use of methods in our research. There are many options. Our ambition is to choose a method which is (1) appropriate in terms of the specific constellation of Lieberman's (2015) dimensions, but also with regard to the research question, (2) applicable to real-world research and (3) transparently informs us about its possibilities and limits. This is how we intend to produce a high-quality application of methods.

Protest, democracy and methods

(Edited) volumes on the use of methods do not only exist at the disciplinary level but also with regard to specific topics. The rationale behind this is twofold: from a more pragmatic point of view, this helps to attract the attention of more substantially interested scholars who would never open a volume on methods in general, but are more willing when this directly speaks to their research. From a more substantial perspective, if we follow Shapiro's (2002) advice (see above), then the topic is the departure point for the discovery of the method, and thus any methodological decision must be based on substance.

The study of citizens' protests, social movements and movement parties, with the goal of making a contribution to the discussion of democratic quality, requires such a specific approach. Thoughts on the use of methods in social movement studies have already been brought forward by other authors (Cox et al., 2024; della Porta, 2014; Jenkins, 2022; Klandermans and Staggenborg, 2002), although the number of available publications on the intersection of methods and social movements/protest is surprisingly low.

Let us re-consider the dimensions discussed earlier with regard to Lieberman (2015) and apply them to studies like ours, on electoral politics, protest, social movements and democratic quality.

With regard to the difference between small-N and large-N research, this field of research faces both situations (and situations in between): for example, small-N research can refer to a single or a low number of events of political violence which is so difficult to study that no huge case numbers can be covered. Another "classic" application refers to in-depth studies on democratic quality at the country level.[2] However, small-N research also occurs when biographical studies on the motivation of single activists are conducted. Small-N research is also applied when protest cultures of two or some more countries are compared.

The idea of large-N research can instead first and foremost be connected to surveys, either of the whole population or about large numbers of demonstrators. But such a strategy can also be imagined in cases when the unit of analysis is not an individual person, but the protest itself. A longitudinal analysis of the (development of the) number of participants in climate protests is an example for this. Furthermore, considering the big data discussion which often refers to text data available through the internet, huge amounts of text usually imply a subsequent large-N analysis. However, while the availability of data may encourage researchers to assume the validity of this type of approach, scholars should be aware of the limitations of these analyses, including the quality of the available data, the challenges of processing it, as well as the reliability of the analyses performed (Hoffmann et al., 2022). The dichotomy of small-N and large-N can also be understood as a continuum. When comparison is expanded to numbers of cases which go beyond the usual choice of between two and four but do not arrive at

a statistical analysis yet, we reach the fuzzy world of mid-sized N. Examples can include studies on the consolidation and regression of democracies (Tomini and Wagemann, 2018) comparisons of the success and outcomes of a diversity of social movements (Berker and Pollex, 2023; Giugni and Yamasaki, 2009; Guzman-Concha, 2015), and a variety of party strategies of different sorts (Kurz and Ettensperger, 2023).

In part, this continuum overlaps with Lieberman's (2015) second dimension, namely the macro and micro perspectives. Protests are predominantly seen as micro-level phenomena when it comes to the study of motivations, forms of behavior, etc., which are then studied for single activists. The macro perspective is more oriented toward social movement studies (Minkoff, 2002), considering the movement or one of the social movement organizations by which it is composed as a "macro" unit, but we can also imagine a macro analysis at the country or society (or continent) level. The small/large-N and the micro-macro dimensions are often linked, with small-N * macro and large-N * micro being the most conventional variants. However, more combinations can be imagined. This is easier for small-N * micro, which is common in social movement studies and consists of interviewing activists (e.g., Mercea, 2012; Santos, 2024) or social movement targets (e.g., Santos and Geva, 2022). Examples of large-N * macro consist of surveys of a large number of civic organizations (Han, 2014), applying network analysis to study relations among social movement organizations (e.g., Diani, 2015; Saunders, 2007), and studying cycles of mobilization using protest event analysis datasets (e.g., Carvalho, 2022; Portos, 2021; Portos and Carvalho, 2022). The discussion on the micro–macro dimension also raises the question about an intermediate variant, that is, a kind of meso-dimension. Indeed, the organizational or group level is often considered to be neither micro nor macro, but meso. Therefore, an analysis like ours which explicitly expands the micro view on citizens through a focus on social movements (or social movement organizations) and movement parties is a good candidate for such a meso perspective. The usefulness of such intermediate positions (and even a continuum can be imagined) heavily depends on the additional value, which is offered by adding such a category to the micro–macro dichotomy. If group dynamics are studied, then the consideration of a meso-level seems rational. This seems justified, since, in the end, this would also require the use of specific methods, such as focus groups or participant observation in order to study group processes. However, if the social movement organization or the movement party is regarded as a corporate actor, then the question becomes important whether this does not follow the logic of the macro analysis. As is often the case with regard to methods: it depends.

Concerning Lieberman's third dimension, namely the continuum between observational and experimental data, we first have to acknowledge that the object of study of the social sciences in general complicates the use of experimental research. This is not different for protest and social movement studies. While there are attempts to use experiments in social movement research, for

example relying on formal models of action (Oliver and Myers, 2002), there is an obvious limit: "while we can boil water as often as we want, we cannot produce riots on order" (Della Porta, 2002, p. 289). However, there cannot be any doubt that experimental methods have started to shape quite a notable portion of social science research; in 2014, for example, Cambridge University Press started the publication of *Journal of Experimental Political Science*. Furthermore, there are several introductory books (Druckman et al., 2011; Kittel et al., 2012; John, 2017, and of course, others). Indeed, there is potential for an application of the experimental logic in protest research, although we see more limits for such research in which social movements, social movement organizations, or movement parties are being researched, since their "behavior" is not only difficult to manipulate, but even to conceptualize. Experiments can also be imagined when it comes to democratic quality or at least its perception. Nevertheless, however, we do not expect experiments to be very influential as a method in protest or social movement research, with the exception of experiments administered through surveys.

When it comes to the pragmatic dimension in the use of methods in protest and social movement studies, of course, the question of pragmatism occurs. There are (at least) three dimensions to this point with regard to this particular field. One dimension refers to the researchers' biographies. If we consider that at least a part of protest and social movement studies has a connection to rather critical forms of theorizing or doing research which should also give "voice" to the underprivileged people and to topics which are under-represented in societal discourses (Martínez, 2023), then this might create opportunities for such methodological options which are considered to be more open or appropriate for participatory research. Advocates of participatory approaches underline that individuals are not only "objects" of research, but should actively be involved in research processes and count with the entirety of their personality. If we translate the dichotomy of qualitative and quantitative research as case-oriented *versus* variable-oriented approaches (Della Porta and Keating, 2008; Ragin, 1999), then participatory research clearly tends toward the case-oriented side where individuals are not (only) understood as data rows in a spreadsheet which adds information on the variables under research. As a consequence, case-oriented methods will be used, or those methods which underline case particularities more than average findings across cases. Nearly necessarily, a political ambition of this type of protest and social movement research will tend to lean toward qualitative approaches. If we furthermore consider that many social movement researchers also agree with much of the content they study, or are even activists themselves, then this centrality of the case as such becomes even more evident. Furthermore, activist or engaged research may be the only way to access certain types of knowledge. Not only activist experience provides a unique type of understanding of the details around any case study, but criticisms from many social movement groups about "academic extractivism" – referring to a common practice in which

researchers engage with social movement organizations exclusively for the purpose of their fieldwork to then produce knowledge that is often not relevant or accessible to activists themselves – may mean that researchers may have to reconsider their ways in which we engage with social movements.

The second pragmatic dimension refers to the question of the availability of information. Political actors tend to see university researchers in general, and those who study protests and social movements in particular, as adhering to a progressive, or even radical left, ideology (e.g., Cottom, 2024; Noonan, 2023). This perception may often complicate entering in contact with key agents, particularly from rightwing groups, most commonly because these actors refuse to be interviewed by academics, turning a research project impossible or forcing researchers to triangulate data points from other sources (e.g., Santos and Geva, 2022) or to limit their research to the use of secondary data.

There is a final pragmatic dimension, closely connected to this question of data availability, namely concerning ethical questions. Since the study of protests and social movements often (although certainly not always) concerns individual people who cannot be counted as the elites, researchers also have a special ethical responsibility toward them. With regard to protest research, it must be especially carefully observed whether individuals involved in the research project risk being harmed in any way. The political dimension also plays a role. Through their analyses, researchers might be involved in the diffusion of political messages, and this might or might not be the researchers' intention. Furthermore, if political science is a democratic science, as mentioned earlier, then political science is not entirely politically neutral. Political science rather constitutes one of those societal sub-systems which are actively involved in the promotion and safeguarding of democracy. Therefore, with regard to its methods and designs, political scientists always have to wonder how to present extremist actors and views in a way that does not undermine their democratic mission. While researchers should always strive to provide truthful information and balanced analyses, students of democracy should not be neutral when it comes to the defense of democratic values. This is not only a substantial or theoretical question; it is also a methodological question. This chapter started with considerations on the appropriateness of the use of methods, and, somewhat pathetically, it can be stated that one of the furthest-going ideas on such appropriateness concerns the political and democratic mission of social research. This is important for any kind of political and social science topic. However, this is even more important, if the topic itself concentrates on protests, social movements and movement parties (some of which are not fully democratic) and, ultimately, democratic quality. Such topics require special care. With regard to these topics, researchers acquire political responsibility. As a consequence, the final research object of our research, therefore, becomes our motivation for research and should consequently also guide our hand when choosing the appropriate methodology: democratic quality.

The methods used in ProDem

As mentioned, our research combines different research objects which have often been studied separately, namely, citizen protests, social movements, movement parties, institutional(ized) political systems and democratic quality. Since all these topics are shaped differently by the analytical dimensions discussed hitherto, and thus require different methodological choices, a project ranging from protest to democracy ("ProDem") also has to give an answer to the multitude of available methods, without risking to confuse a welcome eclecticism with arbitrariness. Our response to this challenge is again given via appropriateness. Our project targets various elements of the realm of protest and democracy, and while there cannot be a one-fits-all methodological strategy for such a multifaceted set of research questions, methods have to be appropriate with regard to the single perspectives ProDem takes.

Chapter 4 focuses on exploring the characteristics of voters of movement parties, comparing their commonalities that set them apart from the rest of the population, as well as how voters of different movement parties diverge from each other. The interest of this chapter requires finding patterns that repeat often enough in certain subgroups (i.e., movement party voters overall and voters of specific types of movement parties) to be of statistical interest and that are not as common in the comparator category. Santos and Mercea use nationally representative survey data to quantify attitudes of interest in the population and analyze it through a series of regression analyses that provide strong evidence of which characteristics are common to these voters, as well as those that set them apart.

Chapter 5 delves into the discursive strategies used by progressive movement parties. This research approach requires a nuanced understanding of the narratives used by a small number of actors (three progressive movement parties, in this case). Therefore, this study is interested in how subtle frames and understandings within a handful of documents create a discourse that seeks to (re-)frame certain concepts such as the European Union and democratic principles and co-produce a political reality, in competition with the narratives of other political actors. Consequently, Trif, Mărgărit and Burean use discourse analysis methods to disclose details that may not be evident in a straightforward manner, as well as the inconsistencies of these frames.

Chapter 6 discusses the relation between movement parties and the media, and how these have evolved. This approach requires knowing hidden details about the interactions between relevant party representatives and journalists, as well as how each interprets the reasons for their actions and those of the other side. Mosca and Paxton utilize interviews with both party and media representatives and qualitatively analyze the perspective of each actor, triangulating the information provided by each group about themselves and others to build a coherent narrative of their relations and how they have evolved over time.

Chapter 7 studies how movement parties communicatively position and re-position themselves vis-à-vis the institutional and protest arenas, over time. The interest in this interactive presentation in relation to different areas requires relatively constant data about movement parties' communications that allows to pinpoint patterns and moments of change. Hoffmann and Neumayer collect traditional and movement parties' messages on social media (Facebook, Twitter and Instagram) and explore how movement parties present themselves in relation to the protest and institutional arenas, over time, using both their textual and visual communication, across platforms. Using a combination of network analysis of movement parties' mentions of traditional party families, and a qualitative exploration of the images they post on social media, the authors are able to provide a longitudinal study of how movement parties evolve in their relations with the institutional and protest arenas.

Finally, Chapter 8 explores the conditions that facilitate that movement parties adopt social movement demands into their political agendas and, thereafter, into policies. Understanding the different pathways in which social demands enter institutional politics and policies requires identifying cases of success and failure in order to later identify logical patterns that lead to each outcome. Wagemann, Glukhova and Geyer collect this data from a variety of sources, including social movements' online communications and press releases, party programs, coalition agreements and draft legislation, as well as secondary sources. Their comparison explores the variety of pathways through which movements can translate their policy demands into institutions.

Each chapter in this book, we believe, provides good examples of how the same object of study, movement parties, can be approached through a variety of methods and epistemologies. Overall, the data and analytical approaches of these studies demonstrate how the research interest and question should precede decisions related to data collection and methodology. Moreover, moving away from old debates related to competitive comparisons, this volume ultimately shows that, if done correctly, different epistemologies and methodologies can provide equally interesting studies of comparable quality.

Notes

1 As mentioned, this is an oversimplification, since natural sciences use of course many more methods than just experiments.
2 There is certainly also a notable number of quantitative attempts which correlate numerical measures of democratic quality with other concepts.

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4 Young democrats, critical citizens and protest voters

Studying the profiles of movement party supporters[1]

Felipe G. Santos and Dan Mercea

Introduction

In recent years, the rise of movement parties across Europe has disrupted traditional notions of party politics and opened up new avenues for citizen engagement and political mobilization. Movement parties are the reflection of a wider socio-political transformation of increasing interconnection between electoral and non-electoral politics (Giugni and Grasso, 2021; Hutter, 2014; Hutter and Borbáth, 2019). Despite their growing prominence, however, our understanding of the factors that contribute to their success remains limited. This chapter fills this gap by examining the determinants of voter support for movement parties, drawing on novel nationally representative survey data from six European countries: Denmark, Germany, Hungary, Italy, Romania and the United Kingdom.

We categorize movement parties into four political families: green/left-libertarian, far-right, eclectic and centrist and explore similarities and differences among their voters. We find that, in line with previous studies (Mosca and Quaranta, 2017), movement party voters share an affinity for protest behavior, as all of them believe in the capacity of protest to influence the workings of their country. Likewise, they take part in non-electoral activities to a greater degree than the rest of the population. However, beyond these characteristics, voters of different movement parties do not share many more features.

Looking into the characteristics of each category of voters, green/left-libertarian movement party voters tend to be younger and more educated and engage more in online political activities. Furthermore, they report having greater faith in democracy than in other, alternative, political systems. Far-right movement party voters express greater discontent both with democracy as a system and with political elites. They are also more likely to be men, less well-educated and have a full-time job than the average citizen. Centrist and eclectic movement party voters support democracy but are dissatisfied with how it currently works. They also report lower-than-average formal education and income.

We argue that each type of movement party voter reflects political transformations previously identified by other scholars. First, green/left-libertarian

DOI: 10.4324/9781003532507-4

movement party voters reflect Dalton's identification of different patterns of participation across generations (Dalton, 2006). Being often younger and more educated, this group shows clear support for democracy and views protest participation as a new mainstream and legitimate means for political expression. This group's vote reflects a generational shift with regard to protest repertoires as well as new policy issues, emphasizing environmental and post-industrial concerns (cf. Inglehart, 1977). Second, far-right voters represent a "protest vote" (Alvarez et al., 2018; Birch and Dennison, 2019), driven by discontent with a democratic system and its elites that they regard as having, by and large, ignored them (Hochschild, 2016). In this way, their electoral and non-electoral participation may amount to a challenge to a political system they perceive as unresponsive. Finally, centrist and eclectic voters reflect a pattern similar to what others have referred to as "critical citizens" (Norris, 2011). While they are generally supportive of democracy, they also express dissatisfaction with its current state. In this context, they look to expand their political repertoire, voting for new parties and engaging in non-electoral activities.

We conclude that the movement party concept may be useful when analyzing the internal organizational dynamics of some parties but may have little to offer when one seeks a unifying understanding of their electorates. While movement parties represent organizational attempts to find new ways of rebuilding the link between parties and society that was eroded by the cartelization of political parties (Katz and Mair, 1996, 1995) and the "hollowing of western democracies" (Mair, 2013), their electorate characterized by diversity. Beyond a general perception that protests can influence the situation in their country, we find that there is little else that voters of different movement party types have in common.

Our analysis contributes to the literature on party politics in several ways. First, it provides a more nuanced understanding of the voters of movement parties, showing that they ought not to be seen as a homogeneous group. Instead, they exhibit distinct patterns depending on their ideological orientation. Second, our study explores the factors that contribute to voter support for these parties, shedding light on the complex interplay between non-electoral participation, political attitudes, media consumption and demographic characteristics. Finally, our analysis provides insights into the changing dynamics of party politics in Europe, highlighting the emergence of new political actors and voter profiles that are transforming European societies and political systems.

The rest of the chapter proceeds as follows. First, with the help of the previous literature, we conceptualize movement parties and analyze their existing different political families across Europe. Second, we develop our hypotheses of what drives citizens to vote for movement parties, based on an overview of the literature on the topic. Third, we present our data and analytical approach. Fourth, we report the results of our binary logistic regression models. Finally, we highlight the conclusions of the chapter and their importance for understanding party politics in Europe.

Understanding movement parties and their varieties

Movement parties are "coalitions of political activists who emanate from social movements and try to apply the organisation and strategic practice of social movements in the arena of party competition" (Kitschelt, 2006, p. 280). Because of their characteristics, these political actors bridge the concepts of "party" and "movement" (Gunther and Diamond, 2003, p. 188). On the one hand, they are political parties insofar as their goal is electoral competition and supporting candidates who seek to legislate in parliaments and lead governments (cf. Sartori, 1976). On the other, they are social movements because they employ non-electoral means to advance or oppose certain social and policy changes (cf. Della Porta and Diani, 2006; Snow, 2004). In this way, we could understand movement parties either as political parties that are part of social movement networks, who share ideological affinities and use some of their tactics, or as social movement organizations that have included electoral participation in their repertoire of action.

The growth of movement parties across Europe happened after a period of grave concern about the increasing disconnection of conventional political parties from their electorates and societal demands. During the late 20th and early 21st century, political parties once considered as "mass parties" – because of their capacity to appeal to ample parts of the electorate and keep large and active membership bases – began to cartelize (Katz and Mair, 1996, 1995). Given their increasing dependence on state subsidies and the professionalization of their representatives, cartel parties started to lose connection with their members and their electorates, and their political manifestos became increasingly similar (Katz and Mair, 1996, 1995). In parallel, citizens across Europe reacted to this transformation by decreasing party membership, a reduced turnout in elections, and higher electoral volatility that signified lower loyalty to these parties (Mair, 2013). In this context, movement parties can be understood as organizational attempts to rebuild the links between political parties and society (Della Porta et al., 2017). In addition to seeking to organize their electorates through active membership in the party, movement parties use their involvement in the non-electoral field as a bridge with society and its emerging demands.

The way in which movement parties merge political party and social movement features leads them to have certain unique characteristics that make them stand out from conventional parties. First, similarly to social movement organizations, movement parties typically maintain minimal formal internal structures and low membership requirements (Kitschelt, 2006; Mosca, 2020). Conventional political parties have a clear structure, expect contributions from their members and set a chain of command with a clear division of labor with the objective of coordinating the actions of their members and supporters (Kitschelt, 2006). Conversely, movement parties lack mechanisms for mediating between leaders and rank-and-file members. Instead, progressive movement parties tend to emphasize bottom-up decision-making

through assemblies and grassroots initiatives (Kitschelt, 1988), while radical right parties employ plebiscitary forms of engagement to secure the membership's allegiance to leadership positions (Pirro and Gattinara, 2018).

Second, movement parties tend to focus on specific issues that have received relatively little attention in political discussions. Rather than developing an overarching program that covers a wide variety of interconnected policy issues like conventional parties do, movement parties tend to focus on single issues, often overlooked by the political establishment, that are paramount to certain social groups (Kitschelt, 2006). In the case of progressive movement parties, prominent issues have been the environment (Kitschelt, 1988) and opposition to fiscal austerity (Font et al., 2021). By contrast, radical right parties' programs are predominantly guided by their nativist policies and opposition to migration (Kirkizh et al., 2022; Pirro, 2019). Finally, centrist movement parties that have recently appeared in Central and Eastern Europe have democratic reform and the fight against corruption as their *raison d'être* (Dragoman, 2021).

For Kitschelt (2006), this combination of factors renders movement parties as transitory phenomena. Their focus on a handful of salient issues, together with few to no membership requirements allows movement parties to mobilize large sections of the population at specific moments. However, their lack of structures – for formalizing commitments from their members, for setting clear directions for the party and for channeling disputes – poses serious challenges to movement parties' capacity to maintain their form and capacity over the long term. For this reason, Kitschelt asserts that after a period of balancing party and movement features, movement parties tend either to formalize their structures, becoming more similar to conventional parties, or to return to prioritizing grassroots mobilization through non-electoral means. However insightful with respect to organizational structure, such arguments leave questions about the electorate of movement parties and its defining characteristics unanswered.

Movement parties in Europe

Given their characteristics, movement parties have, historically, appeared during moments of critical junctures and in places where political entrepreneurs have been able to politicize social demands ignored by the political elite (Della Porta et al., 2017). Moreover, the issues that gained salience during a specific historical period translated into distinct political ideologies that were the hotbed for the movement parties of that time. First, green parties materialized in Western Europe following the so-called 68 Revolution, when environmental issues made it to the forefront of the political agenda (Kitschelt, 1988). Animated by a similar progressive spirit, new radical left parties appeared in Southern Europe against the backdrop of the 2008 global financial crisis. Parties such as Syriza in Greece, Podemos in Spain and Bloco de Esquerda in Portugal channeled the large street mobilizations

against austerity policies in those countries into electoral support (Carvalho, 2022; Flesher Fominaya, 2020; Stavrakakis and Katsambekis, 2014). While the green parties originating in the 1968 mobilizations and the new radical parties that emerged after 2008 formed two distinct political families, the increasing attention paid by the latter to environmental issues and the overarching concern of the former with social justice matters has led these two groups to become increasingly coordinated in their defense of a red-green agenda (Wang and Keith, 2020).

In their turn, radical right movement parties in Western Europe grew exponentially, riding the wave of the 2015 crisis prompted by the lack of capacity of European governments to manage the increase in migration flows originating from asylum seekers escaping the wars in Iraq, Libya and Syria. Parties such as the German Alternative für Deutschland and the British UK Independence Party capitalized on the growing resentment against migration in some sectors of the population for their institutional gain (Dennison and Goodwin, 2015; Franzmann, 2016). In Central and Eastern Europe, authors have explained the appearance of radical right movement parties as a result of the disappointment with the transition from state communism after the 1989 revolutions, as well as the reappearance of national political cultures following that historical moment (Minkenberg, 2002; Pirro, 2014). Parties such as Hungary's Jobbik, Romania's Alianța pentru Unirea Românilor and Slovakia's Ľudová strana naše Slovensko have politicized the resentment felt by the "losers" of the transition to market capitalism turning it into traditionalist and nativist policies that have brought them electoral support (Kazharski, 2019; Norocel and Băluță, 2023; Pirro and Gattinara, 2018).

Central and Eastern European countries' challenging transition from state communism has also provided the context for the appearance of another movement party family. Centrist movement parties emphasizing the unfinished democratic reforms in those countries have also recently gained importance. Following a challenging transition to democratic politics and market capitalism, these parties have gained prominence, in the region. Some relevant examples of centrist movement parties such as Momentum in Hungary and USR, formerly known as USRPLUS in Romania have grown in importance by championing anti-corruption policies (Dragoman, 2021; Olteanu and Beyerle, 2018).

Finally, the eclectic ideology of the Italian Movimento 5 Stelle has become a category in its own right. While having its origins in the crisis of democracy that became apparent after the 2008 financial crisis (Mosca, 2014), the party's emphasis on social policies as well as anti-immigration discourses complicated the party's categorization, leading some authors to refer to its ideology as "eclectic" (Mosca and Tronconi, 2019). The party has governed by all types of allies, ranging from the far-right Lega to the center-left Partito Democratico and the radical left Liberi e Uguale. It was also part of a government of national unity that included parties ranging from the far-right to the center-left (Barbero, 2021). Hence, given the diversity of policies this party

has defended, and the variety of coalition partners it has sought, we follow Mosca and Tonconi's suggestion to regard Movimento 5 Stelle as an eclectic movement party.

The bases of electoral support for movement parties

Given the electoral success of many movement parties across Europe, in this section, we focus on scrutinizing the drivers of their electoral support. Our theoretical interest is to revisit hypotheses from previous studies that focused on a smaller number of cases and to compare competing explanations regarding the electoral support base of movement parties. Reflecting on the literature we have reviewed, we divide the explanations of the vote for movement parties along their connection to protests, sources of grievances, media consumption, political attitudes and ideology. Furthermore, we use earlier studies to build our hypotheses about what drives electoral support for movement parties.

The movement party vote has been termed "the vote of protesters" (Lobera Serrano and Rogero García, 2017; Mosca and Quaranta, 2017). Previous studies of support for movement parties in Greece, Italy, Spain and Portugal have pointed to a positive relationship between having participated in a street protest and having voted for movement parties in those countries. Moreover, one of the main characteristics of movement parties is their connection to social movements and openness to their demands (Della Porta et al., 2017; Weisskircher and Berntzen, 2019). Hence, we expect that this special connection is also reflected in support from members of social movement organizations, as well as citizens who believe protest can influence the situation in their country regardless of their non-electoral involvement, who are then more likely to vote for the movement parties. Accordingly, we hypothesize that:

H1a: Participation in non-electoral activities is positively related to electoral support for movement parties.
H1b: Membership of social movement organisations is positively related to electoral support for movement parties.
H1c: Believing that protests can influence the situation in a country is positively related to electoral support for movement parties.

Other studies of support for movement parties have focused on the types of grievances their voters' experience. Some have described support for movement parties, such as the Movimento 5 Stelle, as a "protest vote" (Passarelli and Tuorto, 2018), operationalized by these authors both as discontent with the system and as discontent with elites. We operationalize system discontent either as lack of support for the democratic system as a whole or as dissatisfaction with how democracy works in the country. Furthermore, we operationalize elite discontent as a lack of trust in political parties. While Passarelli

and Tuorto's analysis only found a positive relation between elite discontent and support for the Movimento 5 Stelle, given that our analysis goes beyond the Italian case, we explore hypotheses related to both types of discontent.

H2a: Not believing that democracy is the best system of government is positively related to electoral support for movement parties.
H2b: Dissatisfaction with democracy is positively related to electoral support for movement parties.
H2c: Distrust of political parties is positively related to electoral support for movement parties.

Media consumption is also a relevant factor in understanding support for movement parties. Gibson and Ward (2009) note that information and communication technologies (ICTs) represent a significant resource for emerging political parties and those with limited access to mainstream media. Many movement parties have skillfully used information and communication technologies (ICTs) to set the political agenda and obtain public support (Mercea and Mosca, 2021). Moreover, scholars have identified a positive relation between the use of ICTs for political information consumption and support for movement parties, in Southern Europe (Mosca and Quaranta, 2017). Hence, we expect voting for movement parties to be positively related to the frequency of using ICTs for accessing information about politics.

H3: The frequency of ICT use for political information is positively related to electoral support for movement parties.

Moving to other political attitudes, Mosca and Quaranta's analysis (Mosca and Quaranta, 2017) shows a positive relation between political interest and voting for movement parties, in Southern European countries. We thus expect that:

H4: Political interest is positively related to electoral support for movement parties.

Ideology has also been discussed as a relevant factor for understanding support for movement parties. Overall, and while conceiving of populism as a thin ideology (cf. Stanley, 2008), previous research has highlighted the use of "populist communication" by many movement parties (Della Porta, 2021). Hence, we expect that parties' communication strategies resonate with their voters who are likely to display populist attitudes. Simultaneously, while scholars have identified commonalities among movement parties, they acknowledge that their policies and ideologies set them apart. Support for far-right movement parties has been associated mainly with their nativist and anti-immigration stances (Kirkizh et al., 2022; Stockemer et al., 2021), while environmental concerns are at the core of the vote for green/left-libertarian

parties (Haute, 2016; Hutter and Borbáth, 2019). The electorate in many Central and Eastern European countries is not as easily organized along the economic left–right axis as it is in Western Europe (Coman, 2017) and the issues at the core of movement party ideologies are better explained from a cultural liberalism/conservativism viewpoint (Abou-Chadi, 2016; Hutter and Borbáth, 2019), we approach these issues from the latter perspective. Consequently, we hypothesize that:

H5a: Populist attitudes are positively related to electoral support for movement parties.
H5b: Cultural liberalism is positively related to electoral support for green/left-libertarian movement parties.
H5c: Cultural conservativism is positively related to electoral support for far-right movement parties.

Data and methods

In this study, we utilize a unique dataset (N=10,347 participants) obtained from online panel surveys conducted across six European countries, covering both Eastern and Western Europe. These countries include Denmark (N=1,001), Germany (N=2,024), Hungary (N=2,051), Italy (N=2,101), Romania (N=946) and the United Kingdom (N=2,224). Countries in the study were selected following a "diverse method" (Seawright and Gerring, 2008). We sought to cover a wide variety of movement parties, ranging from the green/left libertarian and far-right movement parties already identified in the literature (Kitschelt, 2006, 1988; Pirro and Gattinara, 2018), to the new types reviewed earlier in this study (eclectic and centrist movement parties). We also selected country cases with the objective of covering a wide diversity in the degree of openness/closure of their party system (Casal Bértoa and Enyedi, 2016). According to these authors, open-party systems are more conducive to the emergence of new political parties and limit established parties' inclinations toward cartelization, while in closed-party systems challengers have more incentives to engage in non-electoral action or attempt to transform major parties from inside (Casal Bértoa and Enyedi, 2016, p. 266). These authors rank the UK, Denmark and Germany in top positions in their ranking, while placing Hungary and Romania toward the bottom in Europe and Italy in the middle. Through this selection, we attempted to have a comprehensive overview of the variety of movement parties in Europe, as well as of party systems. Sample differences across countries are due to our pollsters' operational capacity and their strategy for attaining a sample that matches national population dynamics as closely as possible. In order to ensure that the results of our analysis are not guided by a potential excessive influence of some country or countries, we replicate our analysis excluding one country at a time, as well as restricting our data exclusively to each country. The surveys took place from 21 February 2022 to 11 March 2022 and were carried out

by the international polling firm YouGov, which employed quotas in each country to align the sample with national population statistics in terms of age, education, region, gender and past voting behavior.

Although concerns have been raised about the representativeness of online panel-based survey data (Elliott and Valliant, 2017), later research using simulation and online experiment testing found the data to be "broadly representative" due to the sophisticated sampling protocols developed by leading polling companies like YouGov (Miratrix et al., 2018). In the following section, we describe how we operationalized the aforementioned hypotheses using our survey data.

Dependent variable

Our dependent variable identifies whether individuals voted for a movement party in the last general election. As part of our survey, we asked participants about their vote in the last general election in each country (2018 for Hungary and Italy, 2019 for Denmark and the United Kingdom, 2020 for Romania and 2021 for Germany). Based on their answer, we created a binary variable whereby we assigned all movement party voters a value of 1 and everyone else a value of 0. Separately, we created another binary variable for each movement party family. Table 4.1 shows the distribution of the dependent variables in each of our models. So, in addition to exploring the predictors of voting for movement parties overall, we were also able to analyze the support for the different movement party families covered in the study.

Table 4.2 presents the political parties identified as movement parties in each country, as well as their categorization. All of these parties share their origins in social movements that appeared at critical historical junctures. Moreover, despite some of these parties having lost their challenger status after going through a process of institutionalization that culminated, in some cases, with them going into government (e.g., the German green/left libertarian Bündnis 90/Die Grünen, the Italian Movimento 5 Stelle and the Romanian centrist USR), all of them remained involved in extra-institutional activities and sought to bring social movement claims to institutional debates. Hence, this diverse selection of parties allows us to account for the different varieties of movement parties present in Europe.

Table 4.1 Distribution of the dependent variables

	Movement party voter	*Other*
Model 1: All	1,912	8,435
Model 2: Green/left libertarian	652	9,695
Model 3: Far-right	521	9,826
Model 4: Centrist & eclectic	739	9,608

Table 4.2 Selection of movement parties in the study

Country	*Green/left libertarian*	*Far-right*	*Centrist*	*Eclectic*
Denmark	Alternativet	Nye Borgerlige	–	–
Germany	Bündis 90/Die Grünen	Alternative für Deutschland	–	–
Hungary	– LMP: Magyarország Zöld Pártja – Párbeszéd	– Jobbik – Mi Hazánk Mozgalom	Momentum	–
Italy	–	–	–	Movimento 5 Stelle
United Kingdom	– Green Party of England and Wales – Scottish Greens – Sinn Fein	– United Kingdom Independence Party – Brexit Party	–	–
Romania	–	Alianta pentru Unirea Romanilor	Uniunea Salvati Romania	–

Independent variables

As per the predictors included in the model, we explain each of them later and report the descriptive statistics in Table 4.3.

We first describe the variables pertaining to an individual's connection to protest activities. First, we include a binary variable accounting for whether, in the past two years, individuals participated in non-electoral activities that are commonly part of the repertoire of social movements. These activities include taking part in a strike, participating in the activities of a social movement, boycotting certain products and joining a demonstration. Second, we add a binary variable for whether individuals were members of a social movement organization. Finally, we use a variable ranging from 1 to 5 for whether the respondent believed that, by taking part in a protest, s/he could influence the situation in the country.

Furthermore, we integrate a number of variables to account for respondents' discontent with democracy. To proxy individuals' discontent with the system, we include two predictors. First, a binary variable that reflects whether respondents thought democracy was the best system of government or not. Second, a variable ranging from 1 to 11 measures respondents' degree of satisfaction with the way democracy works in their country. As for discontent with elites, we include a predictor ranging from 1 to 5 accounting for the level of trust individuals have in political parties.

When it comes to individuals' online media consumption, we measure it with a variable ranging from 1 to 6 for the frequency of ICT use for information about politics. We create this variable by averaging the frequency of consumption, ranging from the maximum option of "several times a day" to the minimum of "not once in the last seven days" for online video platforms, social media and messaging apps. As to political attitudes, we measure interest in politics with a variable ranging from 1 to –4.

Table 4.3 Descriptive statistics of predictor variables

	Mean	*Std. Dev.*	*Median*	*Min.*	*Max.*	*Range*	*Skew*	*Kurtosis*	*Std. Error*
Non-electoral participation	0.47	0.50	0.00	0.00	1.00	1.00	0.11	–1.99	0.00
SMO member	0.25	0.43	0.00	0.00	1.00	1.00	1.14	–0.69	0.00
Protest influence	3.13	1.29	3.00	1.00	5.00	4.00	-0.13	–1.00	0.01
Support for democracy	0.60	0.49	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00	-0.41	–1.83	0.00
Satisfaction with democracy	5.66	2.95	6.00	1.00	11.00	10.00	-0.17	–1.04	0.03
Trust in political parties	2.27	1.03	2.00	1.00	5.00	4.00	0.32	–0.75	0.01
Online media consumption	3.14	1.60	3.00	1.00	6.00	5.00	0.17	–1.22	0.02
Political interest	2.44	0.91	2.00	1.00	4.00	3.00	-0.03	–0.81	0.01
Liberal	6.02	1.94	6.00	0.00	10.00	10.00	-0.18	–0.06	0.02
Populist	3.62	0.73	3.67	1.00	5.00	4.00	-0.26	0.35	0.01
Female	0.53	0.50	1.00	0.00	1.00	1.00	-0.12	–1.98	0.00
Age	47.58	15.87	47.00	18.00	99.00	81.00	0.05	–0.94	0.16
Formal education	0.54	0.36	0.50	0.00	1.00	1.00	-0.12	–1.07	0.00
Income	0.41	0.28	0.36	0.00	1.00	1.00	0.43	–0.77	0.00

When it comes to ideology, we account for it through two scales. First, we measure respondent's populist attitudes through a commonly used index proposed by Akkerman and colleagues (2014), composed of six items that range from 1 to 5. Second, we measure respondents' cultural liberalism through the five-item index originally proposed by Heath and others (1994), ranging from 0 to 10. Both of these scales have acceptable internal consistency scores (Cronbach's alpha = 0.84 for the former and 0.76 for the latter).

Finally, we control for respondents' socio-demographics that studies have shown to influence voting behavior (Bermeo and Bartels, 2014; Bernhagen and Marsh, 2007; Brady et al., 1995; Inglehart and Norris, 2003). These include sex (0 = "man"; 1 = "woman"), formal education (standardized as a 0–1 range variable) and income (standardized as a 0–1 range variable prior to merging each national dataset) We also include individuals' age in the model, standardized as a 0–1 range variable, as studies have shown that voters of movement parties tend to be younger than the average population (Mosca and Quaranta, 2017; Segatti and Capuzzi, 2016). Finally, we include country controls. Prior to running our models, we standardize all non-binary variables to a 0–1 range so the magnitude of regression coefficients can be compared across predictors.

Analytical approach

After recording all variables, we employed multiple imputations (Rubin, 1987) to address the prevalent problem of incomplete data in survey research.

Due to respondents frequently skipping survey questions, some observations contain missing data. We utilized the R package "mice" (Buuren and Groothuis-Oudshoorn, 2011) to generate five datasets using a probabilistic model with the variables incorporated in our analysis. Each imputed value includes a random element to factor in the uncertainty of the predictions. Once the datasets are generated, estimates are independently calculated, and later, the results are pooled.

As for the analysis, we employed four binary logistic regressions in each of which we used a different dependent variable. In the first model, we explore the correlates of voting for any movement party. In the other three models, we explore the predictors of voting for the different movement party families: green/left-libertarian movement parties, far-right movement parties and eclectic and centrist movement parties. Given the limited number of cases of eclectic and centrist movement parties, we decided to pool these two categories in the same analysis. To ensure that our analysis reflects broader national dynamics, we include post-stratification country weights. Furthermore, in order to control for national contexts, and to account for the non-independence of our data points, as we expect that responses from individuals within the same country will be more similar to each other than to those from other countries, we cluster observations by country. First, we confirm that no country is driving our results by running six separate models, excluding a different country in each of them.

Results

We report the results of our binary logistic regressions in Figures 4.1–4.4. In these forest plots, the left column contains the variable names. The central column displays the coefficient plots. The black circle represents the coefficient estimates, while the line covers the span of the 95% confidence interval. The dashed vertical line highlights the value "0". When a dot is located on the right of the dashed vertical line, it means that there is a positive relation between the predictor and the outcome variable. Conversely, when a dot is located on the left of the dashed vertical line, it means that there is a negative relation between the predictor and the outcome variable. If the horizontal line representing the span of the confidence interval does not cross the vertical dashed line, it means that the correlation is statistically significant at 95% probability. Conversely, if the horizontal line representing the confidence interval overlaps with the dashed vertical line it means that the correlation is not statistically significant at 95% probability. Finally, the column on the right lists the numerical values of the coefficient estimates, as well as the 95% confidence intervals in brackets, represented in the plot. Positive coefficients point to a positive relation between the outcome and predictor variables while negative coefficients indicate a negative relation. If the lower and upper bounds of the confidence interval have the same symbol, either negative or positive, the correlation is statistically significant at 95% probability. If they have opposite symbols, the correlation is not statistically significant at 95%

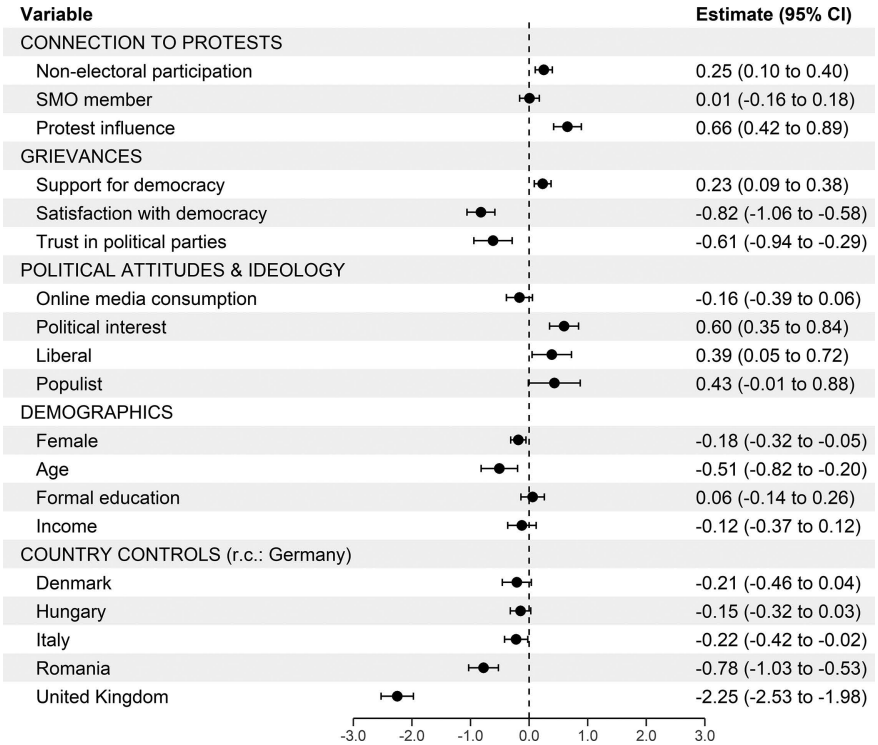


Figure 4.1 Predictors of electoral support for movement parties (N = 10,347 respondents)

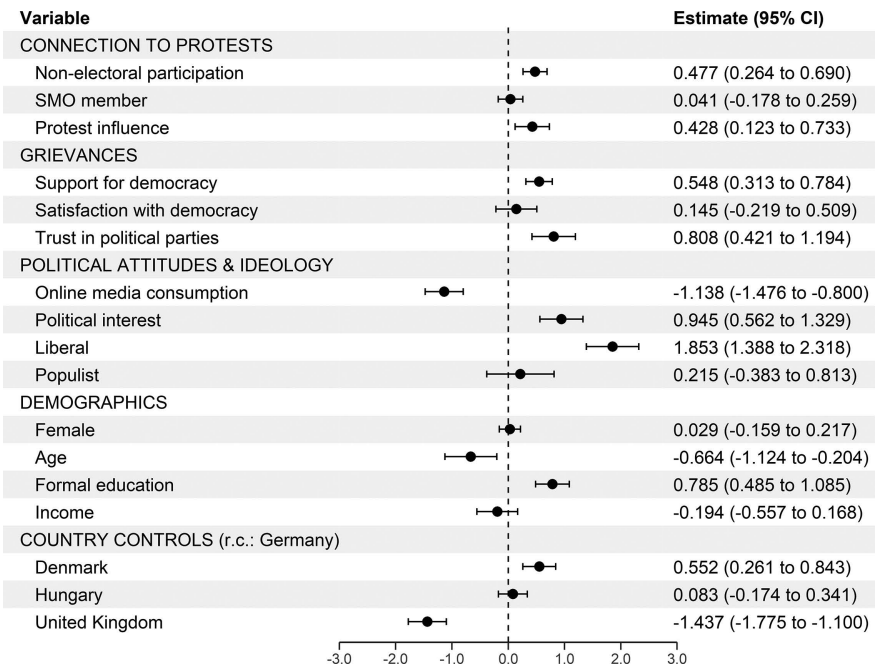


Figure 4.2 Predictors of electoral support for green/left libertarian movement parties (N = 10,347 respondents)

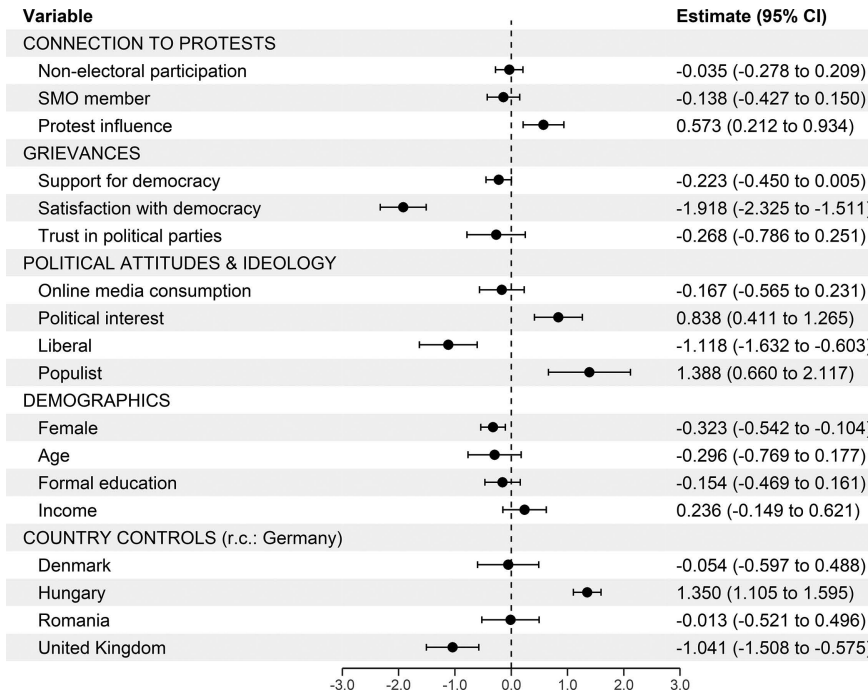


Figure 4.3 Predictors of electoral support for far-right movement parties (N = 10,347 respondents)

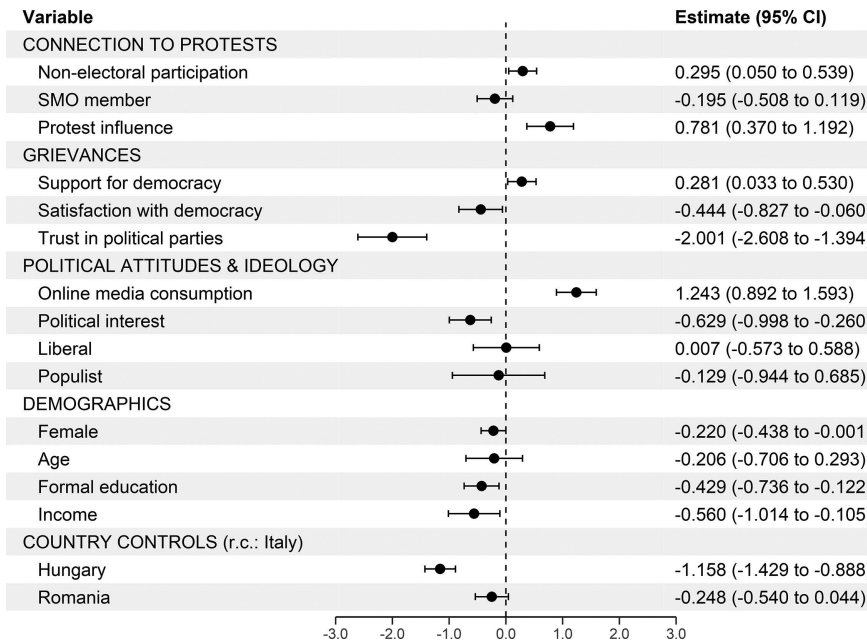


Figure 4.4 Predictors of electoral support for centrist and eclectic movement parties (N = 10,347 respondents)

probability. Overall, it is interesting to see that while there are some commonalities among movement party voters across categories, our hypotheses need to be qualified because voters from different ideological families show distinct patterns. Hence, overall, our analysis calls for a more refined analysis of movement parties and their voters that avoids simplistic generalizations.

When it comes to movement party voters' connection to protests, our results confirm previous studies that showed a positive relationship between protest participation and voting for a movement party. Individuals who have experience with participating in contentious politics (H1a) are more likely to vote for movement parties. When exploring differences across movement party families, the effect is similar for voting for green/left libertarian as well as centrist and eclectic movement parties, while it is not significant for far-right movement party voters. Notably, membership in social movement organizations (H1b) has no significant effect on the propensity to vote for movement parties. Conversely, believing that protest can have an influence on the country (H1c) is positively related to voting for movement parties across families. Overall, these results indicate that movement party voters are more likely to believe that protest participation is an influential component of citizens' political repertoire. Moreover, green/left-libertarian, and centrist and eclectic movement party electorates do not only believe in protest participation but also show a greater propensity to engage in non-electoral activities than the rest of the voters. Notwithstanding, we can also extrapolate from our results that movement party voters are more likely to be protest participants but not protest organizers, as these tasks are commonly performed by members of organizations and our results do not show any significant relation between these variables.

Our analysis of the relation between different sources of dissatisfaction and movement party voting speaks clearly against a generalization of a single movement party voter profile. While an undifferentiated analysis of movement party voters would lead us to conclude that there is a positive association between voting for this party variety, satisfaction with the system and dissatisfaction with elites, a finer grained scrutiny shows specific patterns for each type of movement party voter. Believing that democracy is the best system of government (H2a) is positively related to voting for green/left libertarian, as well as centrist and eclectic movement parties. However, the association is negative but not significant in our model predicting voting for far-right movement parties. Indeed, at a level of significance of 90%, the results would indicate that those who do not believe that democracy is the best system of government are more likely to vote for far-right movement parties. Focusing on satisfaction with democracy (H2b), we observe a positive correlation between dissatisfaction with democracy and the movement party vote. However, this effect is driven mostly by far-right movement party voters, as this is the only model in which this association is statistically significant, being the greatest coefficient to explain support for far-right movement parties.

When it comes to dissatisfaction with elites, trust in political parties (H2c) is positively associated with voting for green/left libertarian movement parties and negatively related to support for centrist and eclectic movement parties. Trust in political parties is negatively associated with support for far-right movement parties but the association would only be significant at 90% probability and not 95%. Based on these results, we can conclude that green/left libertarian movement party voters contradict our theoretical expectations and display both system and elite satisfaction. The opposite is true for far-right movement party voters, for whom their vote is associated with the system and elite dissatisfaction. Finally, centrist and eclectic movement party voters seem to be rather supportive of the general principle of democracy but distrustful of the performance of the current political parties.

Looking into online media consumption, next, we find some interesting results. The frequency of consumption of political information online (H3) is inversely correlated with voting for green/left-libertarian movement parties. Conversely, a high frequency of ICT usage increases the odds of being an eclectic and centrist movement party voter, while it has no relation to voting for far-right movement parties. These results qualify previous studies that found an overall positive relation between online media consumption and voting for movement parties (Mosca and Quaranta, 2017). Next, with regard to political interest (H4), our results partially confirm previous studies that found a positive relation between high political interest and electoral support for movement parties (Mosca and Quaranta, 2017), which we can confirm is present among green/left-libertarian and far-right movement party voters but not among supporters of eclectic and centrist movement parties.

We now move on to exploring the relationship between ideology and electoral support for movement parties. Overall, we find that the relation between populist attitudes and movement party voting is positive but only marginally significant (H5a). Looking at our specific movement party profiles, we see that this association is only statistically significant for far-right movement party voters, for whom it is the second largest coefficient in the model. Hence, despite movement parties tending to use populist communication strategies (Della Porta, 2021), only far-right movement party voters seem to display more populist attitudes than the rest of the population. Finally, regarding their cultural liberalism (H5b), as expected, this relation is very different across movement party families. This coefficient is the largest biggest in the model explaining the vote for green/left-libertarian movement parties and shows a positive relation between cultural liberalism and support for this type of movement party. Conversely, cultural liberalism decreases the odds of voting for far-right movement parties (H5c), being the third largest coefficient in the model. As far as support for centrist and eclectic movement parties is concerned, cultural liberalism has no statistically significant relation in this case.

In summary, our analysis indicates that, with the exception of their belief in the capacity of protests to influence the situation in their country,

movement party electorates are quite distinct from each other, when broken down along ideological lines. The profiles of movement party voters are quite different with respect to an array of theoretically pertinent features. Green/left-libertarian movement party voters seem to be keen supporters of democracy who, being younger and more educated, see protest participation as yet another legitimate tool to express their political desires, as Dalton (2017) pointed out when he theorized a generational participation gap. Hence, green/left-libertarian movement party voters may be understood as part of a wider generational change that is reflected in greater attention to environmental and other post-industrial issues (cf. Inglehart, 1977) as well as an expansion of citizens' repertoire of political participation.

Quite differently, far-right movement party voters could be framed as exponents of a "protest vote" (Alvarez et al., 2018; Birch and Dennison, 2019). Far-right movement party voters seem to be guided by their discontent with the democratic system as well as their populist attitudes. They are also the only movement party voters who do not necessarily channel their political views through non-electoral political means. In this way, the electoral participation of far-right voters may be associated with an intention to challenge a political system that has disappointed them and that they perceive is not open to change. In between these two poles, eclectic and centrist movement party voters seem to fall into a pattern previously labeled as "critical citizens" (Norris, 2011). Their vote may reflect a general support for democracy but dissatisfaction with how political parties currently work. Against this backdrop, they seek to express their demands by supporting electoral alternatives as well as taking part in non-electoral activities.

Conclusion

In recent years, the rise of movement parties has shaken political landscapes across Europe. These parties, which combine elements of traditional political parties and social movements, have disrupted established notions of party politics and opened up new avenues for citizen engagement and political mobilization. Despite their growing prominence, however, our understanding of who the voters of movement parties are has remained limited. This chapter sought to address this gap by providing a comprehensive analysis of the factors that contribute to the electoral success of movement parties, drawing on nationally representative survey data from six European countries. By shedding light on the key correlates of voter support for these parties, we hope to deepen our understanding of the changing dynamics of party politics in Europe.

Overall, our results suggest that movement party voters cannot be seen as a homogeneous group, but rather as exhibiting distinct patterns depending on their ideological orientation. On the one hand, we corroborate an earlier finding that movement party voters value and participate in protests more

than the rest of the population and show this to be the case across ideological lines. On the other, we contend that there are distinct patterns that differentiate the voters of each movement party family. We distinguished four types of movement parties: green/left-libertarian, far-right, eclectic and centrist and identified the sources of voter support for them.

We argued that green/left-libertarian movement party voters fit the profile of the new generation of democrats already identified by Dalton (2017). These younger and more educated voters, who are keen believers in the merits of democracy, view protest participation as another valid means to express their political opinions. Green/left-libertarian movement party voters stand out for their culturally liberal worldview, which may be part of a wider socio-cultural transformation in post-industrial societies (cf. Inglehart, 1977) that has brought new political issues and repertoires into mainstream politics.

Far-right movement party voters' profile is closer to what other authors have referred to as a "protest vote" (Alvarez et al., 2018; Birch and Dennison, 2019). These voters display, on average, greater discontent both with the democratic system and with political elites. Having little faith in the openness of the political system to change and being largely more conservative than the rest of the citizens, their political participation may seek to challenge a political system that has brought rapid social changes and has made them feel "strangers in their own land" as Hochschild (2016) once pointedly put it.

In turn, the characteristics of the supporters of eclectic and centrist movement parties appear to align with what some authors have referred to as "critical citizens" (Norris, 2011). Although they are strong supporters of the democratic system, these voters express disappointment with how the current democratic system works and with the political elites that shape it. Through a political repertoire that spans electoral and non-electoral actions, they turn to new parties that seem more open to listening to bottom-up demands.

In sum, our results indicate that the movement party framework is valuable for dissecting internal party dynamics but falls short when one is attempting to paint a comprehensive picture of their voter bases. Movement parties have been billed as new organizational vehicles for bridging the gap between societies and their electoral representatives. Yet, when it comes to the electorate, aside from a shared belief in the potential of protests, there is not much more tying voters of different movement parties together. Our study, ultimately, encourages scholars to avoid generalizations about the sources of electoral support for movement parties, showing that their profiles differ significantly depending on their ideological orientation. Through our analysis of the profiles of the voters of four distinct types of movement parties, we have sought to offer a more nuanced view of the European political landscape and have highlighted the importance of taking a more refined approach to the analysis of these new parties and their electorates.

Funding and/or conflicts of interests/competing interests

The authors acknowledge receipt of funding for this research from the Volkswagen Foundation (grant no. 98144).

The authors completed this article while in receipt of funding from the European Union – NextGenerationEU – and the Romanian Government, under the National Recovery and Resilience Plan for Romania, contract no. 760038/23.05.2023, cod PNRR-C9-I8-CF204/29.11.2022, disbursed by the Romanian Ministry of Research, Innovation and Digitalization, within Component 9, Investment I8.

Note

1 A similar version of this paper has been published open access in Acta Politica, under the same title. See: Santos, F. G., Mercea, D., 2024. Young Democrats, Critical Citizens and Protest Voters: Studying the Profiles of Movement Party Supporters. *Acta Politica*, 1–22.

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5 Identifying the faultline(s) of social inclusion

The ideologies of USR, Momentum and The Alternative

Dana S. Trif, Diana Mărgărit and Toma Burean

Introduction

The *protest arena* is a place where citizens, protesters, civic organizations, emerging social movements and political parties meet. It is the ground of discursive and ideological re/creation. Crises of mainstream parties and the revitalization of civic participation, as well as political contestation, contributed during the past 15 years to the emergence of movement parties. Besides their common features, such as the critique of the mainstream parties or the repertoires of protest action retrieved from social movements, movement parties have ideological affiliations cutting across the traditional left/right divide (Colantone and Stanig, 2019; Kim, 2023).

Even though scholarship on populism (Mudde, 2004; Ostiguy et al., 2021; Stavrakakis and Katsambekis, 2024; Zienkowski and Breeze, 2019) and movement parties (Della Porta et al., 2017; Giugni and Grasso, 2021; Hoffman and Neumayer, 2023; Hutter et al., 2018; Kitschelt, 2006; Pirro, 2019) is rich, most analyses tend to focus more on the right-leaning populist rather than the progressive movement parties (Cossarini and Vallespín, 2019; Grönegräs and De Cleen, 2023; Kim, 2016; Kim, 2017; Mudde, 2000, 2007, 2017; Pirro, 2016; Pirro and Róna, 2019; Shroufi and De Cleen, 2022; Stavrakakis, 2014) and even fewer analyses have a *comparative* regional focus on Central and Eastern Europe rather than an individual case study approach (Adamson, 2009; Borbáth and Susánszky, 2024; Enyedi, 2024; Kim, 2024; Mărgărit, 2022; Mudde, 2000; Palonen, 2018; Pirro, 2016; Pirro and Róna, 2019). This chapter aims to fill this gap by analyzing the discourses of three political actors that fit the category of progressive movement parties: USR, formerly USRPLUS (The Save Romanian Union, Romania), Momentum Mozgalom (the Momentum Movement, Hungary) and The Alternative (Alternativet, Denmark) – from Eastern, Central Europe and Western Europe.

The term "progressive parties" (Ćetković and Hagemann, 2020; Krouwel et al., 2019) refers to pro-EU parties that have culturally progressive policies (Pető, 2015) and see themselves as protectors of democracy, and several have emerged from street mobilization (Pleyers, 2015). They represent the core of

DOI: 10.4324/9781003532507-5

a comparative approach that aimed to gauge the effects of discursive strategies such as antagonisms, empty signifiers and subject positions (Self, Other and Self-Other relationships) on the construction of three distinct political constituencies. Among these effects, we expected to find: strong polarization between Self & Other, supported by the creation of new collective identities for the "people" and their setting apart from the Other(s); new meanings attributed to older or recent political demands, for example that of *deepening* democracy; or simply the reinvention of political imaginaries focused on a renewed sense of belonging to an alternative "imagined community'" (Anderson, 2016), a community which, in some cases, was juxtaposed to the "nation" (De Cleen and Stavrakakis, 2017). The desired outcome of all these discursive effects would be the (re)inclusion of non-voters into institutional democratic politics.

The public discourse of these relatively new political actors is to be found in their political programs, election slogans and speeches by party leaders. The theoretical framework employs the post-Marxist, poststructuralist definition of discourse as the result of an articulatory practice (Laclau and Mouffe, 2001, p. 105). Discourse both represents and, simultaneously, embodies the materiality of the social world. Ideology has a bidirectional relationship with social practices, from which they arise and which, in turn, they (re)create. Discourses are articulated through the emergence of a nodal signifier capturing other empty signifiers. They give linguistic shape to emerging antagonisms and, through nodal signifiers such as "freedom" or "democracy", coalesce recent and older political demands into a new hegemonic discourse. We argue, that it is the political discourse of movement parties and its anticipated effects on current and future constituencies that delineate the discursive boundaries of social inclusion/exclusion. The readiness of these movement parties to embrace socioeconomic and cultural inclusiveness depends on their ideological backgrounds. The political discourse of these parties is actively engaged in the formulation of new representations of their political communities, in the recreation of antagonistic dynamics between Self vs. Other as well as collective identity-building processes – who are the 'People'? (Panizza and Stavrakakis, 2021) – that elections may or may not validate. We expected all three parties to be inclusive, regardless of their ideological leaning.

Results did not fulfill this expectation, with some important nuances and caveats. All three progressive movement parties publicly expressed a desire to move beyond the Left/Right divide and, their understanding of "inclusiveness" varied. It depended on the reappropriation, within new political imaginaries, on empty signifiers such as "democracy", "freedom" and "equality".

Theory & methodology: a comparative analysis of movement parties' discourse(s)

"Discourse" in the social sciences has acquired various and, at times, very broad definitions (Adamson, 2009; Glynos and Howarth, 2007; Howarth,

2000; Howarth et al., 2009; Linden, 2023). The concept has a theoretically uneasy relationship with ideology. Within the poststructuralist research program it is difficult to find an empirical reference to the social and political actors or "social formation(s)" (Laclau and Mouffe, 2001, p. 97) responsible for its emergence. Laclau and Mouffe's definition of discourse as well as Laclau's later work on populism (Laclau, 2005; Laclau, 2006; Laclau, 2007) have been successfully applied to analyses of European populist parties (De Cleen et al., 2021; Grönegräs and De Cleen, 2023; Kim, 2017; Shroufi and De Cleen, 2022; Stavrakakis, 2014), to transnational European movements (De Cleen et al., 2020) and "privileged groups" (De Cleen and Ruiz Casado, 2023). This success generated a rather awkward juxtaposition between "populism" and "nationalism" (De Cleen et al., 2018; De Cleen and Stavrakakis, 2017). As De Cleen and Stavrakakis argued:

> In an academic context, significant advances in the conceptualization of populism (associated, especially with Laclau and Mudde) have led to more precise definitions that avoid the reduction of populism to nationalism, and that highlight the specificity of populism more clearly. Nevertheless, the term populism continues to be used to refer to what are in fact (ultra)nationalist, nativist, racist and sometimes even neo-Nazi political stances.
>
> (De Cleen and Stavrakakis, 2017, p. 2)

The juxtaposition of "populism" with these "(ultra)nationalist, nativist, racist and sometimes even neo-Nazi" discourses may necessitate the sort of theoretical disentanglement that De Cleen and Stavrakakis (2017, p. 2) recommend. Our own approach follows this recommendation. Political and societal actors such as movement parties, social movements or trade unions and NGOs have used the *protest arena* to contest hegemonic discourses and create as well as promote alternative ones (Zienkowski and De Cleen, 2021). By political discourse we understand the ideological *competition* in the *protest arena*, a competition whose effects on *democratic quality* we gauge analytically by investigating the *inclusiveness* of the respective political discourse. In our research, we aimed therefore to disentangle theoretically the almost exclusive juxtaposition of "populism" with right-leaning movement parties by allowing for ideologically different "populism(s)". We also questioned these actors' ideological posturing and their self-identifications by empirically operationalizing a discourse analysis of the three chosen political discourses.

The theoretical framework draws on previous work in poststructuralist discourse theory (PDT) and the analysis of domestic politics (Adamson, 2009; De Cleen and Stavrakakis, 2017; Glynos and Howarth, 2007; Howarth, 2000; Laclau, 2007; Laclau and Mouffe, 2001; Shroufi and De Cleen, 2022). Earlier PDT but also PSDT (a new acronym for poststructuralist discourse theory) (Jacobs, 2018) studies have focused on the interplay

of hegemonies, identities, political logics and empty signifiers to explain the emergence of new hegemonic challenges to dominant discourses (Adamson, 2009). Our approach focuses on the development of key discursive elements that are suitable for comparative analysis. The empirical analysis of ideology qua discourse draws on central PDT concepts such as antagonism, nodal and empty signifier(s) and subject positions.

The party programs and electoral manifestos of our three chosen movement parties – The Alternative (Denmark), the Momentum Movement or Momentum (Hungary) and USR or USRPLUS (Romania) – ground the empirical analysis. We analyze emerging political articulations that appeal to citizens by (re)creating an alternative meaning for the "people" along with subject positions and nodal/empty signifiers. Subject positions are discursive identities able to refashion, out of preexistent ideological linguistic material, a new hegemonic political discourse. Empty signifiers are key concepts meant to "capture" the political demands voiced by protesters and, potentially, the social movements channeling these demands. The nodal signifier imbues with meaning the rest of the empty signifiers, therefore ensuring discursive consistency across the field of discursivity. The three parties have distinct attempts at reimagining their respective political communities by creating new, viable meanings for the central category of the "people". The social limits of these attempts are circumscribed by the analysis of what PDT scholars, following Derrida, refer to as the "constitutive outside" (Howarth, 2009). We chose to focus on this play of antagonisms by identifying the various "Other(s)" as identity blockages to the "Self", or the "in/out" necessary to distinguish between members and non-members of the community (De Cleen and Stavrakakis, 2017).

This discourse-theoretical inquiry is based on a qualitative analysis of three distinct political discourses. We used a primary dataset including 14 main documents retrieved from the parties' official websites (Table 5.1). The data consisted of political manifestos and election programs issued between 2017 and 2020. We included documents prepared ahead of national and European elections to ensure a thorough overview of these actors' political agendas.

The discourse analysis consists in its initial stages of a two-step coding procedure. Step one is looking at the ways in which the three movement parties portrayed themselves and identified with the "people" as the result of three overlapping analytical levels: perception of Self, perception of the Other(s) and perception of the relationship of Self & Other. Because the European parliamentary system is largely structured in political families, documents released prior to European elections usually included more references to Self & Other relationships than the ones intended for national elections. Step two establishes a list of five empty signifiers: "democracy", "equality", "freedom", "inclusiveness" and "nation/country" as key coding categories. From this list "equality" and "freedom" are the structuring political values of the classical Left/Right divide. "Democracy" was chosen

Table 5.1 Political manifesto(s) and party programs

Country	*Movement Party*	*Document*	*Year*
Denmark	**The Alternative (Alternativet)**	**Party program**	2017
Denmark	**The Alternative (Alternativet)**	**The triple bottom line**	2017
Denmark	**The Alternative (Alternativet)**	**The next Denmark**	2018
Denmark	**The Alternative (Alternativet)**	**A progressive Europe**	2018
Denmark	**The Alternative (Alternativet)**	**Manifesto**	2018
Denmark	**The Alternative (Alternativet)**	**What is the alternative?**	2018
Hungary	**Momentum Mozgalom**	***Let's Start Hungary,* Momentum's 2018 Political Program**	2018
Hungary	**Momentum Mozgalom**	***Let's not Give Up on Our Future,* Momentum's 2018 EP Elections' Program**	2019
Romania	**PLUS**	**PLUS Ideological Manifesto**	2019
Romania	**PLUS**	***My project is Romania,* Dacian Cioloș, Motion, PLUS National Convention**	2019
Romania	**USR**	**USR: A Modern Centre-Right Doctrine**	2020
Romania	**USR**	**The USR Charter of Values**	2020
Romania	**USRPLUS**	***For a Europe of the Future* – Political Manifesto of the 2020 USRPLUS Alliance**	2020
Romania	**USRPLUS**	***The Good Governance Revolution.* 40 Political Pledges and the USRPLUS Political Program**	2020

because this empty signifier we expect to face a particularly intense semantic pressure. "Inclusiveness" is relevant for the empirical operationalization of our hypothesized relationship between a movement party's ideology and its acceptance or rejection of socioeconomic and cultural inclusiveness. Finally, "nation/country" coding category/empty signifier is based on the assumption that constructions of the "people" could entail references to the "nation", and we wanted to investigate to what extent these references overlapped. The presentation of the findings is framed by analytical narratives of the chosen movement parties' development, which helped us historically contextualize our otherwise synchronic discourse analysis.

Brief histories: The Alternative, Momentum and USR

The Alternative (Alternativet, Denmark)

The Alternative founded in 2013 was run by Uffe Elbæk, a former Minister of Culture (2011–2012) in the Danish Government. In its first general election,

in 2015, the party won 4,8% of the votes, passed the electoral threshold and became the third most popular political party. Since its creation, the Alternative maintained a constant presence in the Danish Parliament, the *Folketing*. In 2015, the party gained nine seats but lost four in the subsequent 2019 elections. In the general elections of 2022, they won six MP seats. The Alternative proved less successful in European elections. In 2019, the party failed to gather sufficient votes to pass the 3% threshold for the European Parliament.

Uffe Elbæk, the party's founder, adopted an unconventional political style. Instead of the traditional party program, stating political objectives and public policy proposals, Elbæk set out to present a set of values and principles on how to properly conduct politics. The guidelines and policy issues that the Alternative flagged in its program included: the transition to a sustainable society, support for entrepreneurial initiative, changing the culture of political dialogue and supporting the development of arts and culture (The Alternative, 2017c; see also The Alternative, 2018c). The party held a series of meetings with its constituency, organizing public events and online debates which resulted in a political program governed by the aforementioned principles. The Alternative shares with other European movement parties its propensity for implementing participative democracy initiatives. They value process-oriented politics, and relevant actions are carried out through "political laboratories" (Gad, 2020), where people have been invited to contribute to the party's political agenda. These initiatives are reminiscent of the Green parties' repertoire of actions during the 1960ies. The Alternative did not position itself ideologically on the Left/Right axis (Freinacht, 2022; Husted, 2024). They promoted welfare state policies and advocated for the benefits of a "good" and environmentally friendly market economy. Their political program transcends the conventional Left/Right divide without being acknowledged as a centrist one, thus favoring transpartisanism. The party aims to move beyond the intense polarization of contemporary politics by describing in a positive way the achievements of other political parties. The Alternative's emphasis on arts and culture together with its catering to artists and the "creative class" (Kosiara-Pedersen and Little, 2016) is central to the party's message. This approach resulted in both successful and unsuccessful artists feeling politically represented by and voting for the Alternative. The party actively pursues a European, transnational dimension. Closer political ties have been built mostly with the Alternative party in the UK, but a plan to initiate future connections with other like-minded parties in Europe also exists.

The Alternative's electoral success in 2015 has been attributed, among others, to their publicly stated objective of transforming Danish political culture (Gad, 2020; Kosiara-Pedersen, 2016a, 2016b). Instead of adopting the rather popular "we vs. the others" polarizing approach, the party extolled the benefits of friendly deliberation. The Alternative also emphasized that public discourse should be carried out in a friendlier and more transparent manner. An innovative feature of their program was an openness toward incorporating emotions in political discourse. The Alternative understood

emotions as a tool for shaping collective identities. By accepting such expressions as part of its core message, the party aimed to offer a positive "alternative" to their usually negative usage in Danish politics. The Alternative has been labeled as a populist party that combines participatory democracy tools with advocacy for rather neoliberal topics such as entrepreneurship (Bossetta and Husted, 2017). What is remarkable however about the Alternative and the Danish left political scene is that the movement party succeeded in including emotions in leftist discourse.

There are several hurdles and perils to the Alternative's intention of transforming Danish and, perhaps, European political culture. The party failed to achieve a compromise between the need of inclusion versus that of integrating its members. Programmatically open to all ideas and failing to set clear boundaries for what it deemed unacceptable, the Alternative's organizational culture created room for endless debates and discussions about its ideological direction. Moreover, because other Green parties already existed in Danish politics, the risk of losing the Alternative's specific appeal in favor of other competitors was high from the very beginning. Finally, their public relations strategy, which had started out with unusual and attractive online messages, veered eventually in the direction of a far more conventional digital profile. In 2020, Elbæk stepped down as a party leader and was replaced by Josephine Fock, a former trade unionist and proponent of a more conventional type of politics. Elbæk criticized the turn to conventional politics within the Alternative, relinquished his membership during the same year, and went on to establish a new political party: the Independent Greens, or Denmark's New Left-Wing Party, which failed however to enter Parliament during the 2022 general elections.

Momentum Mozgalom (The Momentum Movement, Hungary)

Momentum Mozgalom is a centrist liberal movement party whose early beginnings as a social movement resemble those of USB/USR (Romania). Founded in 2015 by a group of activists led by Dániel Károly Csala, Momentum became an Association in 2016 and registered as a political party in May 2017. The registration came on the heels of a major protest campaign organized in January the same year by Momentum activists in Budapest, against the city's intention to host the 2024 Summer Olympics. Despite the unexpected success of the NOlimpia campaign, in 2018 Momentum obtained only 3% of the vote, under the 5% threshold required for national elections, and failed to enter the Hungarian Parliament. A sudden reversal of political fortunes came, however, in 2019, when Momentum scored its best result so far in a national or European election. The party obtained 9% of the vote in the European Parliament elections, gaining two MEP seats, and ranking third among its competitors. Its two MEPs, Katalin Cseh and Anna Donáth, would eventually join the liberal RENEW Europe Group at the EP. For the April 2022 Hungarian parliamentary elections Momentum entered the

opposition coalition led by Péter Márki-Zay – *United for Hungary* – together with political parties such as the Democratic Coalition, Jobbik (until 2023), LMP – the Greens, MSZP – the Socialists, and Dialogue. United for Hungary came in second in the 2022 Hungarian parliamentary elections, with more than 36% of the vote. Momentum gained therefore 10 seats on the opposition's list, finally becoming a parliamentary party.

The main message the party ran on during these elections was that Hungary was headed in the wrong direction. Momentum's proposal was to reduce intense ideological polarization in politics by overcoming the friend/enemy division and replacing it with coalition-building and problem-solving thinking. Both party manifestos under analysis – *Let's Start Hungary* (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018) and *Let's not Give Up on Our Future* (Momentum Mozgalom, 2019) – are avowedly pro-European, promoting strategic alliances within the EU as well as the Visegrád Four and rejecting Russian influence. Like other European movement parties, Momentum has been very active in implementing participative democracy initiatives. The party organized several mass events such as protests, referenda and deliberative forums. The NOlimpia campaign in 2017 was a series of highly successful, if local, mass protests against the high price of organizing the Olympic Games in Budapest. The petition organized by Momentum gathered 266.151 signatures from Budapest voters in favor of organizing a referendum on the question of Budapest hosting in 2024 Olympics (Várnagy, 2018, p. 130). Although Viktor Orbán initially refused to acknowledge the petition, in February 2017, a month after the beginning of protests, Hungary officially withdrew from the bid blaming the opposition and citing a lack of "political and national unity behind the application" (Dunai, 2017). A referendum on this issue was never held.

In the 2018 electoral campaign Momentum promoted several innovative campaign activities. They launched a platform called "Real Consultations" (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018), in response to the "National Consultations" organized by FIDESZ – Hungarian Civic Alliance government (Oross and Tap, 2021). The motto of the 2018 electoral campaign – *Let's Start Hungary* – was meant to promote a political platform encouraging citizens to express their views on how Hungary should be governed. Momentum campaigned against the removal of the Central European University from Budapest, claiming that the so-called lex CEU, adopted by the Hungarian government in April 2017, would negatively impact the independence of educational institutions. The party also targeted the Hungarian Diaspora living in Western Europe. As many Momentum supporters lived and worked outside Hungary, a car-pooling app was created encouraging Hungarian expats to participate in elections (Heath, 2017). Similar to other European movement parties, Momentum has so far styled itself as a multifaceted political actor, at the same time a political party and social movement, engaging in elections, but also organizing deliberative fora, proposing referendums and cultivating informal civic groups.

USRPLUS or USR (The Save Romania Union)

The Save Romania Union (USR, and later USRPLUS) was created in 2016 as the successor to another social movement-inspired political party: The Save Bucharest Union (USB). USB had become registered as a political party in 2015. Nicușor Dan, its founder, ran during the 2016 local elections as a candidate for the position of Bucharest's general mayor. Although the Social Democrat Gabriela Firea won the elections, Dan came in second, with approximately 30% of the vote. The success of the newly created party was tied to Nicușor Dan's popularity, the latter a civil society activist previously known for his founding of the Save Bucharest Association (ASB) social movement. The precursor of both USB and USR, the Association had already engaged in a seven-year-long battle with the Bucharest City Hall against what it perceived as corrupt practices and inefficiency in public spending. The social movement had exerted pressure on the City Hall to prevent parks, historic buildings and other public places from being privatized and encroached upon by real estate firms eager to make money in Bucharest's booming housing market (Association Save Bucharest, 2015). Following the 2016 local election results, USB decided to broaden its political agenda and join the upcoming national parliamentary elections. The party changed its name to USR and engaged in a national anti-corruption campaign (USR, 2016). The decision proved successful: during the 2016 parliamentary elections, USR won 8,87% of the general vote, emerging, surprisingly, as Romania's third largest party (Central Electoral Bureau, 2016).

Ideologically, USR defined itself as an anti-establishment center-right and pro-European party. Its political objectives consisted of reforming the political system based on principles such as entrepreneurship, the free market and a minimalist state (USR, 2020a). By contrast to mainstream parties, USR engaged its constituency through participative democracy tools and co-organized two major nationwide campaigns promoting constitutional and legislative reforms: "No Criminals in Public Offices" (2018) and the citizens' initiative "New People in Politics" (2018–2019). The party claimed to have gathered more than 1.000.000 signatures during its "No Criminals in Public Offices" campaign. Coming on the heels of the 2017 mass protests, this political initiative was meant to trigger a national referendum. It had one main objective, that of the changing Art. 37 of the Romanian Constitution to prevent any person having a criminal record from being elected to local and national public office, unless pardoned (USR, 2018b). Although the Romanian Constitutional Court found unanimously in April 2019 that the initiative was constitutional, Parliament would eventually bury it. The USR-endorsed citizens' initiative "New People in Politics" proposed several important changes to electoral legislation among which the elimination of the electoral threshold in local and European Parliament elections, the election of mayors in two ballots, and doubling the number of Diaspora representatives (USR, 2018a). In May 2019, the Romanian Constitutional Court voted

unanimously again, but this time to invalidate it due to the lack of sufficient signatures and their geographic distribution (USR, 2019).

USR entered the 2020 national elections as part of an Alliance: USRPLUS. Its partner was a relative newcomer, the party Freedom, Unity and Solidarity (PLUS). PLUS was the political project of Dacian Cioloș, former European Commissioner for Agriculture and Rural Development (2010–2014) and former Romanian Prime Minister (2015–2017). It was founded in 2018 as a pro-European, right-centrist party, but more left-leaning than USR. USRPLUS ran on a joint list during the 2019 European Parliament elections securing a share of 22.4% of the vote. In 2020, the Alliance almost doubled USR's presence in the Romanian Parliament by achieving 15% of the vote, coming in third once again and joining, from 2020 to September 2021, the Liberals (PNL) and UDMR, the Hungarian minority party, in a governing coalition. In 2021, the Alliance merged into a single party which kept the name USRPLUS. The new political actor joined the Renew Europe Group in the European Parliament together with the Hungarian Momentum and the Danish the Alternative. In November 2022, following the departure of Dacian Cioloș and of his supporters, the party relinquished PLUS from its name and logo, thus coming back, full circle, to its former designation: USR.

Analysis

The alternative: the discourse

Democratic inclusiveness and freedom as equality

The Alternative is a pro-European Green Party which embraces values and principles characteristic of center-left ideologies, promoting sustainability, social ecology, alter-globalization and post-growth (The Alternative, 2017a; The Alternative, 2018c). The party's political program depicts Earth as a limited resource, claiming that industrial and economic activities have weakened the relationship between humans and nature. For this reason, the Alternative proposes a radical transformation of our way of living, beginning with politics and ending with a philosophy of life that addresses the entire humankind. The Alternative's political program covers a wide spectrum of issues from ecological crisis, social inequality and economic challenges (The Alternative, 2017b) to the political underrepresentation of individuals as well as social needs for creativity, culture, education and solidarity (The Alternative, 2017c).

The party embraces a social-democratic political agenda in terms of both institutional procedures and values. For the Alternative, "democracy" means surpassing the traditional limitations of representative democracy, while stimulating citizens' participation and inclusiveness (The Alternative, 2017c). Grassroots civic engagement is the party's envisaged solution to the legitimacy crisis threatening democracies worldwide. "Participatory democracy" is a key element in the party's program, not only with respect to its current

and future constituency, but also within the party and among its members. The Alternative uses intra-party deliberation to ensure consultation, representation, transparency and legitimacy during their decision-making processes, even though these processes come at a cost (Gherghina et al., 2020). Disruptions in their communication with voters and the internal weakening of the party are weaknesses exploited by political opponents (Gad, 2020).

The democratic political imaginary portrayed by the Alternative relies on a specific understanding of "inclusiveness" that, depending on the context, has complementary connotations. From a social services perspective, the party advocates policies for socially disadvantaged groups and reducing the gap between the rich and the poor. From an ecological perspective, the Alternative speaks not only to the Danish population, but to humankind, animals and nature as a whole. According to this view, Anthropocene-specific actions have triggered an ecological crisis that transcends state boundaries (The Alternative, 2018a, p. 2). This calls for a collective response from the European Union (EU) and the United Nations, with both institutions considered as key international actors (The Alternative, 2018b; see also: The Alternative, 2017d). Contrary to right-leaning, populist movement parties, which are rather Eurosceptic, the progressive ones, such as the Alternative, consider the EU as a relevant global actor. However, in contrast to USR, for which the European Union is a valuable supporter of Romanian democracy, the Alternative has a reformist Brussels agenda (The Alternative, 2018b). From this perspective, the party falls in line with other members of the Democracy in Europe Movement 2025, a pan-European, progressive movement that advocates for the continuing democratization of EU institutions.

Diverging from the meanings adopted by Momentum and USR, the Alternative considers "political freedom" as a core value precisely through its association with the ideas of "equal opportunities" and active participation in politics of all members of society (The Alternative, 2017a). The meaning of "freedom" lies in a social understanding of the world, in which "freedom" is accompanied by "solidarity" and "cooperation". The Alternative privileges community-based emancipation for socially underprivileged individuals, as well as redistributive justice at the societal level. Unlike USR and Momentum, which both favor an understanding of "political freedom" closer to a liberal conception of a limited state, free market policies and entrepreneurship, the Alternative advocates a stronger state and redistributive justice. The party's political program is not elections focused. Rather, it tackles issues including the relationship between individuals, their interaction with nature and the inner self. The party did not hesitate to use the term "harmony", historically associated with the utopian socialist projects of the 18th and 19th centuries, in one of its main documents:

> About living in harmony with body and soul – at work and at home. That we can feel that our life is rich in meaning. That we are part of

> systems and relationships which promote creativity, creative power and the freedom to be the best version of ourselves. And that we live in a society which has a framework which gives us the freedom to create a meaningful work/life balance.
>
> (The Alternative, 2018a, p. 10)

A radical solution to systemic issues

The name – the Alternative – suggests the party adopts an opposite approach to politics than mainstream Danish political parties. Unlike other movement parties, presumably born out of anger, discontent and frustration, the Alternative claims to differentiate itself based on "positive values" such as courage, generosity, transparency, humility, humor and empathy (The Alternative, 2017a). Therefore, the party and its leaders' collective self-representation as *the* alternative includes the critique of Danish mainstream politics and a promise for a bright, full of hope future. For the Alternative, the erosion of democracy is not the consequence of illiberal political actors, but the result of "extreme inequality, terror, homelessness, stress and loneliness epidemics and a feeling of upheaval and fear" (The Alternative, 2018a, p. 3). From this perspective, the goal of political competition should be addressing structural social and economic inequalities, rather than fighting other parties for mere electoral gains. The party's discourse is eerily reminiscent of Mahatma Gandhi's political strategy of nonviolent civil disobedience but adapted to a Northern audience.

The party's identity revolves around its international openness and connectivity with the rest of the world: "This transition is characterized by the courage to imagine a radically different future, both for Denmark and for the rest of the world" (The Alternative, 2017c). However, the Alternative does not adhere to the tenets of neoliberal globalization, criticized for its economic, social and ecological consequences. Instead, the party encourages an alter-globalization approach that relies on environmental and economic justice, human rights protection and cultural diversity (The Alternative, 2018a).

The party's foreign policy agenda is based on the assumption that the high scores Denmark repeatedly receives in different international rankings measuring economic and financial performances, quality of life, respect for human rights and diversity should lead to a more significant involvement in international politics. For example, the document "Real friends resist" issued as a reaction to President Trump's administration in 2017, emphasizes the potential role Denmark should play in collaboration with Scandinavian countries, the European Union and the United Nations (The Alternative, 2017d). "Real friends resist" is also one of The Alternative's official documents which gives linguistic shape to antagonisms. The tension between Self and Other is explored as a foe-friend dichotomy. Trumpian politics and American foreign

policy are the "Other" that the Alternative's Self-representation opposes. The party does not hesitate to advocate that:

> Denmark should withdraw from ongoing US led wars and not take part in future US military invasions. . . . In collaboration with Greenland, Denmark should revisit current arrangements regarding American access to the Thule military base and consider how access to the base can be used in future negotiations with the US. Independently and through the EU, Denmark should put increased pressure on Donald Trump and demand that the US lives up to the commitments of the Paris-agreement on climate change.
>
> (The Alternative, 2017d)

The Alternative's position on international relations reflects its domestic political discourse. The peaceful settlement of disputes and the development of a global agenda fighting the climate crisis are two of its main foreign policy objectives. The party constructs an international identity for itself as well as Denmark, one in which friendly relations with global institutions and other states predominate. The "Real friends resist" manifesto highlights these collaborative relationships the party prioritizes with the United Nations, the EU as well as Scandinavian countries, all of whom are trustworthy friends. Moreover, The Alternative shares an ambitious future vision for Denmark as the country that can act as a "global inspiration in the coming century" and "a pioneering country that inspires the rest of the world" (The Alternative, 2018a, p. 2). Finally, the party uses the hashtags "resist" and "friendly revolution" as subtitles to the document, thereby signaling its sympathy or, perhaps, affiliation to the worldwide pro-democratic movement Rezist as well as an endorsement for the idea that peaceful societal transformations are the most appropriate political solution, one in line with the Alternative's values and principles.

Momentum: the discourse

Defending democracy and a diverse Hungary

Momentum entered the April 2018 Hungarian parliamentary elections buoyed by the success of its NOlimpia campaign, which had seen Viktor Orbán unprecedentedly take a step back and give up Budapest's bid to host the 2024 Olympic games. Mass protests in favor of organizing a national referendum, a hugely successful petition and another wave of mass protests against the so-called CEU Lex, a law that critics saw as unfairly targeting the Budapest-located Central European University (CEU), dominated Hungarian politics in 2017. Led by András Fekete-Győr, Momentum seemed poised to significantly shake the establishment. The 2015 European migration crisis had rallied a migration-averse Hungarian electorate around the

ruling FIDESZ – KDNP alliance. The discourse of change and democracy that Momentum touted during its rallies in Budapest however appeared to threaten the current hegemony. In May 2017, in his speech at one such event, Fekete-Győr succinctly summarized the "new" position:

> I'm here with you today to tell you what we need to do in the next year. We need to act. I'm tired of bemoaning what's wrong instead of acting to make things better – because I'm responsible for my future, responsible for my fate. At first I was alone and felt powerless. Then we began to grow in number, we founded Momentum, and I understood that in a community we're strong. Powerlessness was superseded by the strength of action. And now I see that we're many, and that this means nothing's impossible: together, so many of us and more, we're capable of starting Hungary up. We believe, unlike Viktor Orbán, that we need to start things up, not stop them.
>
> (Fekete-Győr, 2017)

Optimism that, for the first time since becoming Prime Minister, Viktor Orbán may have finally encountered a successful challenge seemed, at first, justified. According to a survey conducted by Závecz Research in May 2017, Momentum's support had grown to approximately one-quarter million voters, representing 3% of the vote (HVG, 2017). Seeking to distance itself from the "old" ways of politics, Momentum adopted "Let's launch Hungary!" as the slogan for its 2018 parliamentary elections program. At the forefront of the party's political discourse stood the powerful metaphor of "change" and an equally bold self-identification as "Hungary's new political generation" (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018, p. 11) responsible for "a new political way of thinking" (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018, p. 11). Momentum's ideological choice avowedly transcended the Left/Right divide, which it saw as the root cause of endless debates and of intense domestic polarization. In a vivid representation of the country's political deadlock, Momentum decried a "wall of division", because "our communities have split into hateful camps incapable of dialogue, and most people simply turn away from politics" (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018, p. 11). It fell therefore on Momentum to rejuvenate Hungarian democracy, a task the party assumed as its responsibility toward promoting a different type of politics, one that "built bridges instead of digging trenches" (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018, p. 11).

The counteroffer was therefore based on the party's assumed rejection of the old political class, the revival of active citizenship and measures to relaunch participatory democracy. True to its original intention of developing a grassroots social movement, Momentum heavily emphasized the need for more "democracy", a key empty signifier that captured meaning-wise the party's drive for constitutional and institutional reforms. The party's political program included strengthening the rule of law by rebalancing the various democratic institutions of Hungarian parliamentary democracy. Momentum

heavily advocated the "full restoration of the legislative powers of the Parliament" and the "strengthening of its powers of control over the government" (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018, p. 265). Additionally, it endorsed direct elections for the position of President and an increase in presidential powers that would not however change the political system from parliamentary to presidential democracy. Reacting to the ruling coalition's attempts at increasing the prime minister's authority, Momentum's proposal for the country's future development emphasized the need for modernization and further democratization. A "modern" Hungarian democracy (Momentum Mozgalom 2018, p. 273) was still a parliamentary democracy, but one that fulfilled the aspirations of its citizens, rather than promoting group interests.

In 2018 as in the 2019 electoral programs, Momentum's discourse coalesces around the desire for rejuvenation and innovation. It is a particular vision of a democratic, strong, diverse and European Hungary that Momentum uses to structure its narrative. Contrary to expectations, however, given the party's future liberal orientation and its RENEW Europe membership, "political freedom" rarely appears in both documents. Conceptualized as "freedom of speech" (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018, p. 246), this empty signifier connects with Momentum's proposed legislative efforts to promote free speech as part of its initiatives to strengthen democracy. But such linkages are rather implicit, and no bridges are built, meaning-wise, in Momentum's two political programs that could bring together "democracy" with "equality", "freedom" and "inclusiveness". It is the latter empty signifier that assumes a much more central position in the party's discourse, embedded in its plans to reform social services and education. Momentum's ambitious vision of the future explicitly embraces a particular understanding of "inclusiveness" qua 'non-discrimination'. One of the most important meanings bestowed on "inclusiveness" is that everyone should be treated equally, without any discrimination based on race, ethnicity, social background, or gender (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018, pp. 240–241). The 2018 party program implicitly criticized Orbán's attacks on higher education institutions such as the CEU, portrayed in the government-friendly media as foreign agents subsidized by Hungarian American philanthropist and Open Society founder George Soros. Momentum chose instead to promote family-centered public policies, including the building of more nurseries and schools. Education is therefore one of the centerpieces of Momentum's endeavors to create an "accepting and inclusive society" (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018, pp. 240–241?) in which "people's diversity is a value" (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018, pp. 240–241). The program included explicit references to same-sex marriage, claiming that "the institution of marriage should be made available to all couples who want to get married" (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018, pp. 240–241) and that:

> We aim to strengthen the guarantees of the right to equality: there is no place for negative discrimination based on gender, origin, religion

> or sexual orientation. We consider it a priority task the elimination of discrimination against Hungarian Roma. Momentum strengthens the guarantees of the right to equality and opens the institution of marriage to same-sex couples.
>
> (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018, pp. 240–241)

The integration of people with disabilities, police reform and protection for those from underprivileged social backgrounds are all embraced in the name of diversity. Strong' Hungary's new identity as "diverse, mentally and physically fresh" (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018, p. 294) is grounded in elements such as "culture, religion, and sport" (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018, p. 294). It is in this context that the empty signifier "equality" makes a seldom appearance and is defined as "equal opportunity" and gender equality. Although the message was clearly intended for a domestic audience, this empty signifier vanished from Momentum's 2019 platform for European parliamentary elections.

A New generation for a stronger Hungary

Momentum's political discourse outright rejected the "old" political establishment and the Left/Right divide which it saw as conducive to tribal politics, rather than achieving the higher goals of representative democracy. However, while embracing topics such as the critique of economic and political corruption, Momentum draws a strong line between "us"/Self vs. "them"/Other(s), with the latter identified as the corrupt political class in general, and Viktor Orbán with his allies in particular. The party constructed a future-oriented message, with Momentum politicians self-styled as "Hungary's new political generation" (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018, p. 11) which set itself the goal of "moving forward" (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018, p. 11) to give the country a new beginning in terms of domestic as well as international politics: "The world around us is developing at breakneck speed, but Hungary is a small, inward-looking island where time has stood still for a hundred years" (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018, p. 11).

Refashioning political discourse would not be possible however without a strong collective identity and a new vision for the future. Momentum achieves both these goals by delivering to its audience and future voters an almost messianic image of Hungary's development. In a "democratic society" Momentum sees "a place for all opinions, both good and harmful, pleasant and offensive" (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018, p. 246), where "active" and "responsible" citizens engage in a "discussion culture" (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018, p. 48). The "people" are called upon to embrace an active citizenship and institutional reform, while rejecting the politics of fear – fear of immigration, fear of Europe – and of democratic backsliding. The very loose definition of this collective identity, a catch-all strategy, was in line with the party's public critique of old ideological divisions.

Although it embraced the principles of free market and economic liberalism and advocated for a minimalist, reformed state, Momentum also placed strong emphasis on local communities and community-building initiatives. This powerful new political imagination included references to Hungary's European role and future. In a stark presentation of the alternatives facing the Hungarian public, the 2019 Momentum Program for the EP elections stated: "The stakes of the election are whether Momentum and its allies will strengthen Europe, or whether Fidesz and its divisive friends will further weaken it" (Momentum Mozgalom, 2019, p. 4). Attempting to take over FIDESZ's nationalist overtures, Momentum addressed the issues faced by the Hungarian Diaspora, including specific measures in its 2018 program promoting the interests of these ethnic groups beyond the "Carpathian Basin" and including them in a pan-European Hungarian nation (Momentum Mozgalom, 2018, p. 336). They were not very successful though in promoting themselves as supporters of Hungarian minorities' rights. FIDESZ criticized Momentum during the 2019 Romanian presidential elections for supporting Dan Barna, USR's candidate, and not Kelemen Hunor, representing UDMR (the Hungarian Democratic Union in Romania) (444, 2019; Origo, 2019). Momentum's proposal of Hungary as a "progressive pole" in Europe (Momentum Mozgalom, 2019, p. 16) included a stronger security alliance with the EU and NATO, together with an increased diplomatic role in global affairs. Orbán's government was decried for its murky economic interests that tied him to Putin's Russia and for foreign policy choices that presumably weakened Hungary's allies and its role abroad, as it had happened with the Visegrád Four. The image of a strong Europe, "our home" (Momentum Mozgalom, 2019, p. 4) was therefore superimposed with an image of a strong Hungary:

> Momentum is on the side of the future in Europe as well as in Hungary. We have to take back our future. We must invest in the future and give the new generation the opportunity to feel that we are Europe.
>
> (Momentum Mozgalom, 2019, p. 4)

USRPLUS or USR: the discourse

Free, but also equal? The new generation in Romanian politics and the deepening of democracy

The values and principles embraced by USR, and since August 2020 until 2022, by USR PLUS coalesced around a handful of political programs. One of them is the *USR Charter of Values* published in 2019, an attempt to give voice to a new political constituency. The "people" USR claimed to represent shared a different appreciation of their country's past and international political future. For them, Romania's integration in the European Union is associated with "freedom" and "development" as well as the crowning of a years-,

even decades-long fight for democracy. The document, titled "We are USR", put forward a list of values the party adopted as part of its core ideology: "The values we share are those indivisible and universal of *human dignity*, *freedom*, *equality* and *solidarity*, of *merit* and *integrity*" (USR Charter of Values, 2019, p. 3). The first in the list of core values is political "freedom", which USR defines as "a person's foremost resource to affirm themselves in a world in which ideas and initiatives are a source of identity and prosperity" (USR Charter of Values, 2019, p. 4). Moreover, "freedom is the fundamental value that Europe passed on from generation to generation and which we have the civic and political duty to protect and to pursue" (USR Charter of Values, 2019, p. 4).

The key role the empty signifier "political freedom" plays in this discourse is not serendipitous. This is a value that USR placed at the core of its self-assumed "center-right" ideology (USR: A Modern Centre-Right Doctrine, 2020a), and one the party feels strongly it needs to protect. However, defying traditional expectations of ideological posturing either to the Right, or to the Left, "freedom" is not sharply contrasted to "equality". It serves rather as a nodal point that captures and helps the meaningful reinvention of other empty signifiers, such as "democracy", "inclusiveness" and "equality". "Freedom" fulfills as well other discursive functions, allowing USR to distance itself and the new generation it claims to represent from Romania's authoritarian past. It is not, therefore, surprising that "democracy" in the movement party's discourse takes on a new meaning. USR extols the benefits of "*liberal* democracy" (USR Charter of Values, 2019, p. 4), one that maximizes an individual's options and freedom of choice by guaranteeing the right to property and promoting the spirit of entrepreneurship. Within this reconstructed discursive space "equality" acquires a new interpretation as "equality before the law" and "*equal* access" to the justice system. As such, it fits well with the avowedly Right-leaning doctrine of USR and its pro-democracy, anti-corruption and law and order discourse.

The USR Charter imagines Romania's democracy as inextricably linked to its European membership. Past, present and future blend together in a discursive representation of the country's 2007 accession to the European Union as "one of the greatest achievements of our generation and the most important guarantee of freedom and development" (USR Charter of Values, 2019, p. 18). For USR, Romania's national security is tied to NATO and the strategic partnership with the United States. Romania's European path is therefore dependent on the future of a "strong, united, and solidary Europe, capable of withstanding, more than each of its member states independently, major challenges such as global migration, terrorism, and economic crises" (USR Charter of Values, 2019, p. 18). This relationship with "Europe" facilitates the reappropriation in the USR political discourse of "inclusiveness", another key empty signifier which resurfaces indirectly in references to the European Union as a "union of peoples with different beliefs and cultures" (USR Charter of Values, 2019, p. 18). "Inclusiveness" has nevertheless

certain qualifiers. All these "peoples" are partaking "in the construction of this project for which freedom of conscience and the other freedoms and human rights are valued and guaranteed" (USR Charter of Values, 2019, p. 18).

"Culture", "health", "environmental protection", "sustainable development", "equality of opportunity", "professionalism and meritocracy in public service" as well as the inclusion in these reform plans of the Romanian Diaspora are the party's other political objectives (USR Charter of Values, 2019; The Good Governance Revolution. 40 Political Pledges and the USRPLUS Political Program, 2020b). The Charter's discursive role is therefore broader than that of a party manifesto. This is the cornerstone of a self-assumed generational discursive change in Romanian politics, one revolving around a new political actor: the movement party USR, forged in the decade of civic protests that started with the Save Roşia Montana movement (2013) and ended with #Rezist, a loosely styled social movement which, in 2017, marked the largest post-1989 mass protests in Romanian politics.

PLUS shared USR's ambitious political plan of recreating a liberal doctrine for the 21st century in Romanian politics. In its *Ideological Manifesto* (2019), PLUS founders embraced the principles of "ethical liberalism", one grounded in "freedom, individual rights, *property, keeping one's word, the rule of law* and the responsible usage of public resources" (PLUS Ideological Manifesto, 2019, Chapter III "Values and Beliefs We Share"). For PLUS, however, adopting this political program also meant that "society needs to construct a rightful equilibrium between freedom and justice" (PLUS Ideological Manifesto, 2019, Chapter III "Values and Beliefs We Share", §4), a slight twist that qualifies "political freedom" and connects its meaning with that of "responsibility towards oneself, family, community and for the next generations" (PLUS Ideological Manifesto, 2019, Chapter III "Values and Beliefs We Share"). Paragraph 2 of the Manifesto's Chapter III "Values and Beliefs We Share" makes a reference, even before "political freedom" to PLUS' endorsement of "inclusiveness" and "equality". Similar to USR, but born during the 2017 pro-democracy and anti-corruption protests, PLUS fought to construct a clear ideological position that would differentiate it from the former, with both parties addressing their political programs, more or less, to the same voters. In the 2019 Ideological Manifesto, PLUS explicitly embraced the liberal conviction according to which all people are born free and equal in rights, irrespective of sex, race, ethnicity, religion, class, disability, level of income or other differences that could be imagined and which would restrict or deny civil and political rights.

(PLUS Ideological Manifesto, 2019, Chapter III "Values and Beliefs We Share", §2)

The Manifesto's following paragraph promotes anti-discrimination and equal opportunity policies aimed at ensuring that people can exercise these rights, irrespective of their differences. However, the PLUS founding document stops short of specifically embracing gender as a possible discriminatory

practice, targeting instead poverty and social inequality as the root source of societal polarization.

Dacian Cioloș's 2019 Motion to the PLUS presidency (Cioloș, 2019), a year after the party's official founding, slightly veers in this direction by putting forward the ideas of support for the "modern family" together with people's individual and collective involvement in public affairs as a means of addressing social inequality and power imbalances (Cioloș, 2019, p. 15). In PLUS' political vision, creating a level playing field in the exercise of political and socio-economic rights demanded public policies that addressed the three pillars of Romania's sustainable development: "sustainable use of Romania's natural resources", "active and participatory citizenship" and "quick transition towards a responsible state and institutions based on inclusiveness" (Cioloș, 2019, p. 17).

Declaring itself fundamentally different from the contemporary hegemony of "leftist conservatism" (PLUS Ideological Manifesto, 2019, I "The State of Democracy in Romania", §1) PLUS carefully merged topics traditionally of concern to leftist parties such as education and the reform of the public health system, with more right-leaning convictions regarding the symbolic significance of entrepreneurship, a less bureaucratic and more efficient public administration, and the role of the state as "a facilitator, a creator of the institutional framework necessary for human development and communities' prosperity" (Cioloș, 2019, p. 5). The two movement parties finally joined forces in the production of a common political program for the 2019 European Parliament elections and the 2020 national elections ("For a Europe of the Future" – Political Manifesto of the 2020 USRPLUS Alliance; 40 Political Pledges and the USRPLUS Political Program, 2020). The 40 Pledges continued this tradition of mixing ideological elements from the right and the left: the document promised a "good governance revolution" aimed at eradicating corruption together with the interdiction of people with criminal records from public offices ("No criminals in public offices", Pledge Nr. 1); however, it also included pledges ensuring a patient-centered public health system and better access to education as well as more care for the welfare of children. The Political Manifesto of the 2020 USRPLUS Alliance – "For a Europe of the Future" – was drafted in advance of the 26 May 2019, European Parliament elections, where USRPLUS won eight places with a final electoral score of 22.36% from the total number of votes cast, one of their best election results from 2016 until today. At the time a relatively new political alliance, USRPLUS sought to pledge itself and Romania to a vision of a united Europe, one that was not set to become a two-track Union, and which valued "prosperity and equity" as well as "democracy, freedom, and the rule of law" (for a Europe of the Future' – Political Manifesto of the 2020 USRPLUS Alliance, p. 1).

The avant-garde of political change

USR and then USRPLUS attempted to create a catch-all political discourse that would have, on ideological grounds, as few as possible "excluded"

Others. The USR Charter of Values, for example, claimed that: "USR was born in the XXI century, at a time when we see that the left-right distinction is often used to divide people and to undermine the citizens' legitimate hopes (USR Charter of Values, 2019, p. 3). The party's political counteroffer was meant to overcome such perilous divisions. USR aimed to move beyond old-fashioned ideologies and to focus instead on a post-ideological "living doctrine", giving priority to "people's real needs" USR Charter of Values, 2019, p. 3). Showing its willingness to move past such classic divisions, the party publicly embraced a center-right ideology which it identified however as a "synthesis between European liberalism and the power of the communities" (USR: A Modern Centre-Right Doctrine, 2020a, p. 2).

Not only the doctrine but also the construction of its subject positions and collective identities demanded a fair share of attention. Pressured by the National Liberal Party (PNL), which was competing with USRPLUS both ideologically and through the very pragmatic adoption of new political demands, the party/ies focused between 2019 and 2020 on consolidating their political constituency. They included in political programs the anti-corruption, pro-justice and pro-democracy demands of the 2017 #Rezist protests. The ruptured social and political imaginary emerging in the aftermath of these massive protest events had instilled a sense of crisis and deepening polarization in Romanian politics, one that quickly created, however, the conditions for the emergence of a new hegemonic discourse. Buoyed by what it perceived to be a generational change in Romania's post-communist history, USRPLUS hurried to answer this need by restyling itself and its voters according to the new political demands. Echoing slogans chanted during the 2017 protests, the 2020 USR Charter of Values proudly stated in the document's first paragraph:

> We are the new political force in Romania, the Avantgarde of change for the current political class. We are the union of people who want Romania's real modernization and democratization, of those who chose to make a step towards change.
>
> (USR Charter of Values, 2019, p. 1)

Rather than criticizing its political competitors, the Social Democrats (Partidul Social Democrat, PSD) and the Liberals (PNL), the USR political discourse focused instead on a new articulation of the "people", those who shared the values of liberal democracy and the party's concerns for freedom, equality, justice and the rule of law. The "people" included the large Romanian Diaspora.

In its Charter of Values, USR referred to the massive migration waves of Romanians toward countries in Western Europe of beyond as more depleting to the country's human resources than the two world wars (USR Charter of Values, 2019, p. 17). These Romanians, it was argued, had been betrayed by their own government, oblivious to their needs and blind to the economic

benefits they had generated for their country. PLUS, and later on USRPLUS further developed this narrative, by drawing a stark dividing line between the corrupt establishment and the "honest, serious, well-qualified and meritorious people [who] feel stifled, humiliated and frustrated" and who choose to leave their country instead in order to fulfill their professional aspirations (PLUS Ideological Manifesto, 2019, Chapter II Current Crisis, §10). USRPLUS aimed their political discourse directly at this constituency, naming one of their 40 Pledges, Pledge 26, "The road home for the Romanians from Diaspora" and vowing to facilitate through targeted policies and support for entrepreneurship their return.

The governing party, the Romanian Social Democrats, had lost considerable legitimacy and political sympathy during the 2017 protests, mostly due to its support for Party Chief Liviu Dragnea's proposed reforms of the Romanian justice system. The "red plague", as PSD had been commonly referred to during the protests, was, therefore, officially, the "enemy". However, the "enemy" was more clearly identified as such by PLUS. In its 2019 Ideological Manifesto, PLUS pointed toward PSD as the party which, "particularly, although not exclusively, . . . has a systematic behaviour of a one-party and tentacular state" whose aim was to control administrative power even at the kindergarten level (PLUS Ideological Manifesto, 2019, Chapter II Current Crisis, §9). PSD may have been an important "enemy", but it was certainly not the only one. The contemporary political establishment and corrupt individuals were singled out as well as the root cause of Romania's democratic backsliding. The "people" whom the new parties appealed to were presented, on the contrary, as the honest, hard-working, silent majority that had felt betrayed by PSD's actions. PLUS legitimated its reformist discourse by tracing its ideological roots and, presumably, those of USRPLUS, to the institutional reforms initiated during the early years of a young, 19th-century Romanian state. Dacian Cioloș's 2019 Motion went further: the 1918 Greater Romania Union and the 1989 Revolution joined the list of events foreshadowing the post-2017 political attempts at reimagining a democratic Romania. The country, in USRPLUS' political imaginary, transcended therefore physical boundaries. Steeped in an alternative presentation of history, beginning with the modernization movements of the 19th century, the concept offered a progressive alternative to extreme right, nationalistic, anti-European appeals. USRPLUS' Romania was therefore one inextricably linked to Europe, sharing the same values and principles of liberal democracy.

Discussion

We have hypothesized at the beginning of our research that the readiness of progressive movement parties to embrace socioeconomic and cultural inclusiveness depends on their ideological backgrounds. Empirical results do not support this hypothesis. By comparing the political discourses of three political actors from Eastern, Central and Western Europe – USR, Momentum

and The Alternative – we found that despite their publicly assumed ideologies – Centrist-Right and, respectively, Left-Green – an empirical analysis of foundational party programs, manifestos, and at time speeches by Party leaders paint a more ambiguous picture. USR and Momentum belong to the same European political family, having joined the RENEW Europe Group at the European Parliament. Both parties heavily emphasized the need to protect and strengthen representative (liberal) democracy in their respective countries, but USR focused on its *deepening*, whereas Momentum advocated institutional *reform* and the stopping of its backsliding. The Alternative on the other hand proposes radical reform through more grassroots initiatives that can transform for the better Danish democracy. *Freedom*, one of the linchpin values of liberalism, was strongly embraced by USR, with *equality* reinterpreted as *social inequality* and *inclusiveness* understood in this context as attempts at poverty reduction and the inclusion of the Romanian Diaspora in targeted public policies. Momentum kept a certain semantic distance from *freedom*, which it equated with *freedom of speech*, focusing more on the need for institutional reform and the rebuilding, of ethical and democratic values, of the Hungarian community. In one of its electoral programs (2018), Momentum however inserted explicit references to a policy of non-discrimination, which included gender on its extended list, and support for same-sex marriage. Further up on the progressive meter, The Alternative embraced *political freedom* as *equal opportunities,* advocating for a stronger state and a community-based type of emancipation.

All parties, the Alternative, Momentum and USR vowed to practice a *new* type of politics, one that transcended the pernicious Left/Right divide and focused instead on rejecting corrupt (Momentum & USR) or mainstream (The Alternative) practices of their respective political establishment. Despite the Momentum and USR's strong rejection of polarizing politics as the hallmark of the past, their own definition of "people" saw a line in the sand being drawn between the "corrupt" politicians, sometimes oligarchs with economic ties to Putin (for Hungary), or just "enemies" of those who wish to advance socially based on their merit and professional achievements (for Hungary and Romania). The Alternative, however, saw its Other(s) entrenched rather at the international level, with states acting against the peaceful settlement of conflicts that the party advocated, such as the US under President Trump, gaining foe status. A new political imaginary centering on a *strong European* Romania and, respectively, a *strong*, *European, healthy and diverse* Hungary was matched with an equally symbolic effort at redefining the two nations along more inclusive lines, expanding their geographical reach beyond the physical boundaries of the two states. Embracing a pan-European and global Hungarian "nation" was more relevant to Momentum's discourse, than to USR', whose focus was rather on broadening the definition of the "people" to include the Romanian Diaspora. The Alternative sees itself more as a Danish representative in international relations, and focuses less on meaning ascriptions to the "nation".

Conclusion

Within the *protest arena* crises of mainstream parties and the revitalization of civic participation, as well as political contestation, contributed during the past 15 years to the emergence of movement parties. There is a rich academic discussion, including in the present volume, concerning these relatively new political actors. However, our research into the triple interaction affecting democratic quality has led us to the conclusion that, despite a variety of studies focusing on right-leaning populist parties, the comparative study of progressive movement party ideologies remains an under-researched topic. Various analyses of the discursive construction of the "people" have problematized this theoretical category and its alternative constructions in the political discourse of so-called populist European movement parties. But such constructions, however significant they may be to understanding these new political imaginaries, do not tell us much about other ideological elements structuring such interventions. We have therefore chosen to enquire into constructions of meaning involving several more ideological elements. To that end, we posited that the readiness of progressive movement parties to embrace socioeconomic and cultural inclusiveness depends on their ideological backgrounds. Our three chosen political actors spanned three different regions: Eastern (*USR-PLUS or USR,* Romania), Central (*Momentum Mozgalom*, Hungary) and Western Europe (*The Alternative*, Denmark). The empirical results of our PDT-driven discourse analysis have led us to refute this hypothesis. We found that 'inclusiveness' changed its meaning depending on the semantic relationships it established with key empty signifiers such as 'democracy', 'freedom' and 'equality'. All three parties put forward, therefore, different understandings of 'inclusiveness'. Despite their inclusion under the unifying label of 'progressive movement parties', all three political discourses displayed more ambivalence than their officially assumed ideological position would warrant. This key finding, we hope, will elicit further research and scholarly interest on this subject.

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6 Changing strategies, shifting responses

How movement parties and the traditional media interact

Lorenzo Mosca and Fred Paxton

Introduction

In the aftermath of the financial crisis and the Great Recession, the European media landscape underwent a profound transformation. The ascent of social media and algorithmically driven newsfeeds intensified competition and reduced profitability for traditional media outlets such as newspapers and television, leading to the emergence of a distinctive "hybrid" media environment (Chadwick, 2017). This environment created new opportunities for political forces adept at exploiting digital technologies. So-called movement parties (Kitschelt, 2006; Della Porta et al., 2017), also sometimes referred to as "digital parties" (Gerbaudo, 2018), capitalized on these novel opportunities to disseminate their messages and garner support, disrupting conventional media dynamics through innovative communication strategies (Mercea and Mosca, 2021).

Despite the transformative changes to media dynamics, traditional media outlets continue to wield substantial political influence (Langer and Gruber, 2021). Their interactions with movement parties, however, constitute a noteworthy gap in the existing literature. Empirical research remains lacking regarding how movement parties strategically navigate traditional media channels, compared to the more common research focus on their innovative online approaches (Pepe and Di Gennaro, 2009), and, less often, the approach that the media have taken toward these parties' emergence (Rafail and McCarthy, 2018; Weaver and Scacco, 2013). This gap hampers a comprehensive understanding of the development of new party forms, and the roles played by the actions of party and media actors, as well as their interactions with each other, alongside contextual factors.

This chapter examines the evolution of movement party interactions with traditional media institutions within this evolving context. Drawing on insights from party politics, social movement studies and media studies, we investigate how challengers' media strategies change over time and how media institutions react. Specifically, we ask: How have relations between movement parties and traditional media evolved over time? And to what extent do the distinctive characteristics of these parties help to understand similarities in the evolution of their relations with the media?

DOI: 10.4324/9781003532507-6

To answer these questions, we analyze four countries in Western Europe and examine the interactions between distinct traditional media outlets and one movement party in each. Our sample includes ideologically diverse movement parties across various media systems. We aim to identify commonalities in their approaches and resulting relations attributed to their "movement party" character. The analysis is based on 36 semi-structured interviews conducted with leaders and communication managers of movement parties, and journalists from selected media outlets. We employ a cross-case form of qualitative content analysis (Miles and Huberman, 1994), to explore similarities and divergences in the perceptions of the interviewed actors.

The article shows that, initially, relations between movement parties and the media tend to be mutually hostile, although interpretations of the causes differ between the two sides. Over time, as the parties become more established in the political system, their relations with traditional media outlets undergo significant changes. Many of the perceived causes of these changes are rooted in their distinctive features as movement parties, particularly the significance of leaders and members within a relatively unstructured organizational form, as well as their reliance on digital media. This chapter contributes to the literature on the relations between new political parties and legacy media by demonstrating the significance of the movement party concept to understanding their form and development.

The rest of the chapter is structured in four sections. First, we situate the work within the existing literature regarding the relations between new parties and the traditional media. Second, we form expectations regarding the character of the party–media relations, as perceived by both sides, and the underlying causes. After outlining the data and methods used to test these expectations, we then present the findings and conclude by discussing their implications.

How relations between new parties and the traditional media evolve over time

Social movements and challenger parties often face serious hurdles when attempting to secure coverage in traditional media outlets (Tresch and Fischer, 2015; Dollbaum and Dollbaum, 2023). With their well-established routines and editorial policies, the latter tend to favor incumbent political actors and narratives (Hopmann et al., 2011). In response to the barriers imposed by legacy media, movement parties have devised innovative strategies to circumvent such constraints. Taking advantage of the democratizing potential of digital platforms, these entities have sought to bypass traditional gatekeepers and directly engage with their target audiences (Mercea and Mosca, 2021).

Nevertheless, traditional media outlets retain considerable influence and reach. Their longstanding role as arbiters of public discourse and conduits of information endows them with relevant power to shape public discourse and influence political agendas. Moreover, they still serve as primary sources

of information for a significant segment of the population. Given the persistent role of legacy media (Langer and Gruber, 2021), movement parties are forced to interact with them strategically, despite the allure of digital alternatives. Interaction with traditional media outlets represents an opportunity for movement parties to access different audiences, legitimize their agendas and engage in dialogue with established political actors.

Following the foundational work of Herbert Kitschelt (2006), we can pinpoint three crucial characteristics of movement parties potentially affecting their approach to legacy media and their relationships with them. First, movement parties have a distinctively weak and loose organization. This implies both a lack of formal organizational structure and personnel, as well as an open form of membership. This informal profile is particularly opposed by traditional media that need clarity, constancy, continuity and complicity with their interlocutors. Second, the process of internal decision-making is also conducted in a different way from typical parties, with either "participatory" or "plebiscitarian" forms dominating. That is, members directly decide on internal matters through participatory mechanisms or, by contrast, party leaders decide directly. An important repercussion of this is the key role attributed to their members and a focus on a particular issue niche (which may change in a volatile manner). Participatory methods typical of movement parties translate into dilated and time-consuming decision-making processes that are poorly compatible with media logic. Besides, a focus on niche issues could cause the media to deem movement parties' positions on more significant issues irrelevant. Third, movement parties attempt a "dual track" by combining activities in formal political institutions, working toward elections, with protest actions: "one day, legislators of such parties may debate bills in parliamentary committees, but the next day, they participate in disruptive demonstrations or the non-violent occupation of government sites" (Kitschelt, 2006, p. 281). This means that legacy media may perceive movement parties as contentious actors and enemies threatening the status quo.

At their inception, movement parties are often seen as incompetent newcomers by legacy media, lacking credibility or viability. Coverage may be sporadic or dismissive, depicting them as outliers or protest groups with limited influence. However, as these parties gain momentum, win electoral success and enter formal institutions, legacy media acknowledge their growing relevance and impact (Mazzoleni, 2008). Initially viewed as threats to the media system and democracy, as per the "protest paradigm" (McLeod, 2007), the portrayal of movement parties in the media changes as they gradually integrate into mainstream politics. During this process of systemic integration, several characteristics of the parties undergo significant changes that affect their interactions with traditional media (Mazzoleni, 2008; Rucht, 2004). These transformations are rooted in factors such as increased resources, growing professionalization, strategic adaptations to the political arena and institutionalization (Panebianco, 1988).

First, as movement parties gain traction and support, as well as presence in representative institutions, they acquire greater financial resources. This enables them to invest more in communication and media outreach efforts, hiring communication staff, investing in media relations and allocating funds for advertising campaigns. With increased resources, movement parties can therefore enhance their media presence, as well as their relations with journalists.

Second, movement parties professionalize their communication strategies, and approach to media relations. They develop formalized communication departments or teams dedicated to managing media interactions, emulating traditional parties (Lynch, 1996). They adopt standardized processes for media outreach, including press releases, media appearances and interviews. Party members and leaders acquire media communication skills, including the ability to interface effectively with journalists.

Third, movement parties may shift their issue focus or ideological positioning, influencing their media strategies and interactions. As they expand their policy platforms, and respond to changing societal concerns, they may seek to reframe their messages and moderate (Sánchez-Cuenca, 2004). Their initial hostility toward traditional media outlets can evolve as parties and media develop a more respectful mutual recognition (Mosca and Räsänen, 2022).

Fourth, as movement parties transition from fringe actors to established actors, they may undergo processes of institutionalization, participating in elections, forming alliances, or entering governing coalitions (Panebianco, 1988). This institutional integration requires them to engage more continuously with mainstream media outlets and to meet the expectations of traditional political institutions. Accordingly, movement parties may adopt more moderate or pragmatic stances to gain credibility. As they demonstrate credibility within institutions, mainstream media increasingly recognize them as legitimate political actors worthy of serious consideration. Elite media's critical stance toward challengers is typical of their early phases, tending to change with access to representative assemblies (Pedersen, 1982), and once parliamentary activities become the primary focus of party action. Institutionalization and parliamentarization (Leonardi et al., 1978, p. 162) can act as critical junctures for both party communication strategies and their media coverage. Coverage becomes more nuanced and substantive, moving beyond superficial portrayals to cover policy positions and electoral prospects (Mazzoleni, 2008). As movement parties acquire parliamentary presence and consolidate their institutional role, traditional media outlets increasingly engage with them (van Spanje and Azrout, 2022). Interviews with their leaders, spokespersons and grassroots supporters, along with feature stories, provide insights into the personalities driving these parties and the constituencies they represent. By shifting their focus to people within movement parties, personal relationships between representatives and journalists are established more effectively.

Expectations regarding the relations between movement parties and traditional media

Initial relations

As discussed earlier, we expect that the relations between movement parties and legacy media will be poor initially, due to mutual distrust stemming from unfamiliarity and the challenger status of the former. Traditional media outlets may view movement parties with suspicion, perceiving them as disorganized actors lacking a coherent media strategy. This perceived lack of professionalism can lead legacy media to dismiss them as fringe or irrelevant, with their distrust and skepticism contributing to strained relations. Conversely, movement parties may harbor suspicion toward the mainstream media, perceiving them as biased or attached to corporate or political interests that are antithetical to their grassroots ideologies (Mosca and Räsänen, 2022). This perceived enmity and exclusion from the media can further strain relations.

H1a: movement party-media relations are perceived to have been mutually hostile at the time of the party's emergence.
H1b: media representatives perceive the cause was the movement parties' unprofessional organisation and media strategy.
H1c: movement party representatives perceive the cause was the media's hostility/neglect.

Changes to relations over time

We expect the relationship between movement parties and the media to improve over time due to several factors, as described earlier, including the adaptation of movement parties to media codes and routines, and changes in their distinctive organizational and programmatic character. As movement parties gain experience, resources and access to representative assemblies, they undergo professionalization. They learn to approach journalists effectively, tailoring their communication strategies to meet media expectations and standards, and adapting to media codes and routines (Rucht, 2004). Media representatives, observing these changes, perceive movement parties as more competent and credible actors. As movement parties become more integrated into the political system and gain visibility in the media, legacy media may adjust their attitudes and practices toward them. Media outlets may become less hostile, neglectful, or unfair in their coverage of challenger parties as they recognize their growing influence and legitimacy (Mazzoleni, 2008). This shift in media attitudes can lead movement party representatives to perceive the media as more sympathetic and accommodating, contributing to improved relations over time.

H2a: movement party-media relations become more positive over time as the parties institutionalise.

H2b: media representatives perceive the cause was the movement parties becoming more professionalised in their organisation and media strategy.

H2c: movement party representatives perceive the cause was the media becoming less hostile/neglectful.

Data and methods

The study aims to examine the evolving relationship between movement parties and traditional media from the perspectives of the involved actors. As part of this inquiry, we seek to identify the contribution made by the specifically "movement party" aspects of the parties. To achieve this, we select cases from diverse contexts and ideological standpoints. Despite significant differences between them, a rare point of commonality among these cases is the "movement party" label. We focus on four cases: the Alternative for Germany (AfD) in Germany, Momentum in the UK, The Alternative (Alternativet) in Denmark and the Five Star Movement (M5S) in Italy (see Table 6.1). These parties emerged in the decade following the 2008 financial crisis, offering distinct issue positions and a novel approach to politics. They have already been identified as movement parties in the existing literature (Della Porta et al., 2017; Heinze and Weisskircher, 2021; Husted and Plesner, 2017; Paxton, 2024; Watts and Bale, 2019).

Due to the need for in-depth analysis and detailed data, we adopted a qualitative methodological approach, specifically using semi-structured interviews

Table 6.1 Case selection

	Movement party	*Ideological orientation*	*Phases*			
			1 (Founded)	*2 (Entered parliament)*	*3 (Entered government)*	*4 (Left government)*
Denmark	The Alternative (*Alternativet*)	Green	2013	2015	N/A	N/A
Germany	Alternative for Germany (AfD)	Radical right	2013	2017	N/A	N/A
Italy	Five Star Movement (M5S)	Eclectic populist	2009	2013	2018	2022
United Kingdom	Momentum (Labour Party faction)	Radical left	2015	2015*	N/A	N/A

* The Labour Party, of which Momentum is a faction, was already in parliament when Momentum was founded.

(Knott et al., 2022). These interviews, conducted with participants from both movement parties and the media, enabled us to uncover the individual experiences and perspectives underlying their interactions. For selecting interview subjects, we established specific inclusion criteria for both sides of the relationship. On the media side, we targeted journalists from major newspapers in each country, representing a range of ideological viewpoints, who had reported on political news, including the relevant movement party. On the movement party side, we sought individuals holding senior positions and/or specific organizational responsibilities within the party, leading to ongoing relations with the media. We followed a purposive sampling strategy to recruit subjects capable of providing deep, rich insights. In total, as shown in Table 6.2, we conducted 17 interviews with movement party representatives and 19 with media representatives.

The semi-structured interviews followed a guide containing discrete topics, including: the role of the interview subject; the movement party's approach

Table 6.2 Interviews

	Movement party	*Interviews*	
		Movement party (MP)	*Traditional media (M)*
Denmark	The Alternative (*Alternativet*)	4 [DK_MP1 – DK_MP4]	2 B.T. [DK_M1]), Altinget [DK_M2]
Germany	Alternative for Germany (AfD)	4 [DE_MP1 – DE_MP4]	5 Die Welt [DE_M1], Bild [DE_M2], ARD [DE_M3], Süddeutsche Zeitung [DE_M4], Spiegel [DE_M5]
Italy	Five Star Movement (M5S)	4 [IT_MP1 – IT_MP4]	7 Corriere della Sera [IT_M1, IT_M4], Freelance [IT_M2], Aska [IT_M3], Il Fatto Quotidiano [IT_M5], RAI 3 [IT_M6, IT_M7]
United Kingdom	Momentum (Labour Party faction)	5 [UK_MP1 – UK_MP5]	5 Novara Media [UK_M1, UK_M4], The Sunday Times [UK_M2], The Guardian [UK_M3], The New Statesman [UK_M5]

N.B. Interviews are referenced in an abbreviated format of "country_Media/MovementParty_number"; for example, "DK_MP_1"

toward the media; the media's approach toward the movement party; the evolution of relations between movement parties and the media over time; and the consequences for democracy of movement party – media relations. Each topic comprised a set of questions forming the basis of the discussion, accompanied by probes designed to elicit concrete details and examples. The interviews began with straightforward opening questions to ease participants into the conversation, followed by more open and potentially challenging topics. We transcribed and translated the interviews into English using the software packages Sonix and DeepL. Manual checks were then conducted by team members who conducted the interviews, each of whom was a native speaker of the respective languages.

We conducted a thematic analysis of the interview data using an iterative approach that combined both deductive and inductive techniques (Boyatzis, 1998). We concentrated on three topics: (1) the movement party approach toward the media; (2) the media approach toward the movement party; and (3) the change in relations between movement parties and media over time. We closely read the interview transcripts to identify recurring themes and iteratively develop a hierarchical set of codes within the MAXQDA software. The analysis utilized both data-driven codes, derived from an inductive annotation of the interview responses, using cross-case analysis to detect common patterns across interviews and cases; and theory-driven codes, deductively derived from our expectations of movement party-media relations (Fereday and Muir-Cochrane, 2006). For the latter, the movement party concept was operationalized following the definition outlined in the theory section above. Specifically, these codes referred to (1) party organization; (2) party members and participatory process; (3) party leadership; (4) protests, protesters and social movements. The resulting full set of codes was grouped into four categories: the character of media-party relations; the reasons for the character of the relations; the changes in these relations; and the reasons for changes in the character of these relations.

The coded data are analyzed within each case, considering the perspectives from both sides of the relationship, and then compared across cases. This approach allows us to identify the various forms the relationship takes across different participants. By examining the emerging patterns, we interpret the similarities and differences between cases (Knott et al., 2022, p. 8). The interviews serve as the empirical basis for our analysis, and so we provide quotes throughout to demonstrate and justify the analytical points being made.

Findings

Initial relations between movement parties and the media

We begin by examining the perceptions of the initial relations between the movement parties and the media. We hypothesize that both sides would

perceive these relations negatively, with each side attributing blame to the other. We assess each case in turn, considering the perspectives of interview respondents from both sides of the interaction, and analyze the similarities and differences between them.

* * *

In Italy, the initial relations between the M5S and the media were marked by hostility, stemming from the party's perception of the media as an integral part of a corrupt establishment. This sentiment was epitomized by the V-Day protests of 2007 and 2008 organized by the M5S, during which leader Beppe Grillo singled out the media for criticism, lambasting journalists as members of a political "caste" (IT_M1). For the journalists, the M5S was initially seen as a new and closed political entity that was difficult to understand and interrogate (IT_M2). Party actors stress their approach to the media was emblematic of their novel, alternative vision of politics, leveraging social media and online tools to circumvent the mainstream media and reach the people directly (IT_MP1). However, for some in the media, the party's approach was rather characterized by aggression and reflected a lack of professionalism.

> Attacks were directed at journalists; sometimes even the masses were incited against journalists. . . . It was an objective of the Five Star Movement which was heavily pushed on the blog, on the internet . . . And there was a sort of protest against the very role of the journalist, considered a servant of the powers or of traditional parties.
>
> (IT_M1)

M5S figures interviewees tend to acknowledge their initial adversarial stance toward the media, but emphasize that it was itself a reaction to media hostility.

> The M5S has been consistently vilified, ridiculed, and attacked. Perhaps history books will offer a fairer assessment. Instead of portraying it as a significant revolution for Italy, with both its positive and negative aspects, the focus has been on ignoring its origins.
>
> (IT_MP1)

Media hostility toward the party is actually acknowledged by both sides of the relationship. Various distinctions are made between different outlets and forms of media; it is generally accepted that the party engaged more with television news and talk shows than newspapers, and tended to receive more attention and favorable coverage (IT_M1, IT_M2, IT_M3, IT_M5, IT_M6). The crucial factor to explain the level of hostility given to the party is said to be ownership: more negative coverage of the M5S comes from outlets with

party political or commercial affiliations that are felt to be threatened by the M5S program (IT_M1, IT_M5).

> A very, very confrontational attitude was born – and this is not a justification, but a historical fact – from the poverty of the Italian press, from its conformism, from the fact that it has always been strongly influenced by the boss or the publisher. . . . And within the newspapers, above all. . . . Very often the publisher was totally legitimised to choose an editor in line with the political line of the newspaper. . . . Within the newspapers, one's career was mainly made when one did not disturb the system. . . . In Italy, it is unthinkable that it should happen, as in the United States, that there would be newspapers that investigate the activities of their own publisher. And with such a strong connection to politics, this has consequences. And so many citizens saw in the Five Star Movement a chance for change. It was very evident when they read the newspapers, watched television – and it is here and I say again, not to justify, but to contextualise the anger, and this attitude on the part of the movement, at least in the initial phase, towards the press.
>
> (IT_M5)

* * *

In Denmark, The Alternative initially struggled to receive a satisfactory level of media coverage. Party actors perceived a sense of ridicule, that they were "almost laughed out of the room" (DK_MP2). The party's self-presentation was perceived by the media as unprofessional, as explained by one Danish journalist.

> The Alternative started out as what some in the media call a "clown party". In other words, a party of characters, with people who are very, very skewed in their views and are not at all trained as politicians. These are people who dance together at meetings, they are jumping on bouncy balls, and generally acting very differently from traditional politicians. . . . Before they get into parliament. Before they prove their worth. They are also ridiculed, or at least made fun of, in certain parts of the media as a very unprofessional organisation.
>
> (DK_M1)

This reception was partially rooted in their distinctive media strategy. For those within the party, this was framed as a positive change from the typical mainstream party approach: freer, more fun, "more courageous" (DK_MP3). The Alternative was consciously more similar to a movement than a typical political party (DK_MP2), due to its grassroots-centered approach to internal organization (Husted and Plesner, 2017). Of particular importance was their innovative use of social media, the potential of which was grasped before

other parties, and challenging to the traditional media institutions (DK_M1, DK_M2). For the media, however, of more central importance was their unusual, hippy-style, organizational practices (DK_M1), and their (offline) attention-grabbing stunts. Some of these were described as characteristic of a new party, and explicitly compared to another new Danish party, the radical right Nye Borgerlige (DK_M2). Moreover, the party was held back by its niche issue focus, "only wanting to talk about two or three issues" and lack of organizational size and resources (DK_M1). Yet, rather than a lack of professionalism, the party actors commonly perceive the obstruction from the media as rather a product of the refusal by The Alternative to "play the game" of getting involved in conflictual media debates, typical of media logic.

> We were extremely critical of their constant conflict-mongering . . . and their craving for all kinds of sensational content, which are very often personal matters. . . . Any kind of deeper system criticism or self-criticism is almost non-existent in Danish media. . . . . And because we didn't want to enter into it on those terms, because we didn't smear other parties . . . it was very difficult in the start-up phase of The Alternative to get any interest in the things we were doing.
>
> (DK_MP1)

This novel approach by the party caused mutual misunderstanding. According to the party, The Alternative didn't align with the media's conception of what a party should entail (DK_MP1, DK_MP4).

> There was very, very little curiosity about us, and it was related to the fact that we didn't fit into their schemes and graphs for what a political party should be and how it should behave. . . . They didn't know how to treat us.
>
> (DK_MP1).

As will be detailed in the following section, this dissatisfaction with the media's understanding of The Alternative, and its understanding of politics more generally, continued even amidst significant changes in the party's systemic position due to electoral expansion.

* * *

In the UK, interviewees from both sides of the movement party–media relationship note an initially negative phase of relations, from the creation of Momentum, which immediately followed the election of Jeremy Corbyn as leader of the Labour Party in 2015, until the 2017 General Election (UK_M3, UK_M4, UK_M5, UK_MP1, UK_MP2, UK_MP3, UK_MP4). Actors from both sides agree that coverage was overwhelmingly hostile, across all mainstream newspapers, and that this was rooted in Momentum's close

connection to the new leadership (Cammaerts et al., 2020), and the radical left-wing ideological shift it represented (Watts and Bale, 2019).

> Right-wing [newspapers] were obviously hostile towards Jeremy Corbyn, as they saw Momentum as a political threat, because they were like foot soldiers of the current leadership of the Labour Party, which was treated as a sort of usurpation of the party. And I think that was true across the media really. . . . Even the Guardian, which traditionally people would see as having a more centre-left orientation, was still broadly hostile to Momentum and the political faction it represented. And I think the reason was that they were politically aligned to the other faction of the Labour Party. . . . There are obvious reasons why the right-wing media would be hostile towards a leftward shift in the Labour Party, [which] Momentum was trying to institute and push ideologically and politically. But then I think that was also reflected in centre-left media and public media.
>
> (UK_M1)

The character of these attacks was centered on the members of the movement, discrediting them through alleged similarities to the Trotskyist entryism of the Militant Tendency faction in the 1980s (UK_M3), and broader negative stereotyping, as described by an editor of the New Statesman:

> In general, the approach was: "look at these . . . Marxist extremists, millennials, posh, vegan. . . ."Anything that could be thrown at them was thrown at them like that. To paint them, first of all, as a sort of threatening group, but also to mock them as . . . people with far too left-wing ideas; they were idealists, but also champagne socialists, and that kind of thing.
>
> (UK_M5)

In response, Momentum tried to bypass the traditional media, with distinctive alternative strategies to mobilize voters using social media and multimedia content, as well as creative and youth-oriented public events (UK_M1, UK_M4, UK_M5, UK_MP3). A "hybrid" strategy, across various forms of media and online platforms was also used to respond rapidly to (often innovative and underhand) media attacks. One tactic was to "play the media game", wherein, anticipating a potentially damaging story, Momentum's activists would create newsworthy drama to divert attention away from it.

> I got a phone call from this guy, who had been a weird volunteer in our office, saying: "Hi, you know me as. . . . I'm actually a Mail on Sunday undercover reporter. And I've been in your operation and we're publishing tomorrow with all these allegations". So we quickly went. . . . How do we knock this off the front page, and how do we make them

> look a bit silly? . . . So we gave the story to BuzzFeed, as: "Momentum infiltrated by Mail on Sunday". . . . The BuzzFeed story goes out. We put our statement up on Facebook and Twitter. And it knocks it off the front page of the Mail on Sunday.
>
> (UK_MP4)

For some within Momentum, the success of its media strategy, the use of digital technologies and media forms to connect and mobilize supporters, was clearly demonstrated by the better than expected election results for Labour in the 2017 General Election (UK_MP1). This election marked a turning point in media relations, as the following section will explore.

* * *

In Germany, the AfD initially received limited media exposure. Looking back to the period immediately after its formation in 2013, party representatives recall more "neutrality" than in later years, even a relatively positive media reception at times (DE_MP1, DE_MP3). Where the party offered distinctiveness from other parties was in its issue positions. None of the interviewees, however, pointed to distinctive media strategies that are considered typical of movement parties, such as the use of digital media, as being crucial to the initial media strategy of the AfD.

> If you ask everyone else for a position on a certain topic, they will all be very similar. . . . With the AfD, journalists will notice: "Okay, that's interesting, when I bring them I get added value – journalistic added value – because they have a different position".
>
> (DE_MP1)

In the early years of the party's emergence, tensions between the AfD and the media quickly escalated into mutual hostility. The underlying cause of this divide is commonly attributed to ideological differences between the two sets of actors (DE_MP1, DE_MP2, DE_MP3, DE_MP4, DE_M1, DE_M2, DE_M3, DE_M4). However, while both parties acknowledge these differences, they frame them differently and assign blame differently. The party attributes the tensions to what they term "attitude journalism" (DE_MP2), according to which reporting is driven by ideological biases, and an intolerance of the alternative perspectives offered by the AfD. Individual journalists who engaged with the party are said to have faced backlash, in professional and personal terms (DE_MP1, DE_MP3).

> [There was] one journalist who published really big headline articles about us in the [newspaper name redacted], and then I noticed afterwards that he was being massively criticized in his private life. Friendships were destroyed simply because he reported relatively neutrally

> about us. . . . Since then he has treated us more or less neglectfully; on the contrary, he has even shared posts on Facebook in order to take aim at the AfD.
>
> (DE_MP3)

For journalists, on the other hand, their hostility is rather a response to the ideological extremism which was increasingly evident within the AfD. They viewed this extremism as a threat to democracy which merited closer attention and scrutiny.

> We should look at the AfD differently when they convey statements that – let me say it very carefully – touch the border of our constitution, our free democratic basic order. . . . When it comes to national ideology, when it comes to terms that originate from the time of National Socialism, or at least have references to that time. . . . Then I believe that these things should be particularly emphasised and focused upon, because [they are] a test for our free democratic basic order and constitution.
>
> (DE_M3)

This democratic threat was revealed directly in the interactions with the media, from obstructive behavior toward media attendance at party events (DE_M1, DE_MP3), to violent behaviour from party activists toward journalists (DE_M1). The following section will discuss further the development of media relations as the AfD continued to radicalize.

* * *

In summary, our analysis of the initial relations between this diverse set of movement parties and the traditional media reveals shared perceptions of mutual hostility, alongside differences in attributions of its causes. These hostilities are particularly severe where ideological differences with journalists are more prominent – that is, in the case of radical (left and right) movement parties. The tone of the media response to the movement parties' emergence ranges from the ridicule directed toward the (less radical, green) Alternative in Denmark, to the outright hostility toward (the radical left) Momentum in the UK and the (radical right) AfD in Germany. The media approach toward the M5S in Italy combined aspects of both, with the party facing both mockery and heavy criticism. Besides offering new issue positions, these movement parties also demonstrated new forms of party organization and media strategy. While the use of digital media forms may have provided some advantages of reaching people directly (Mercea and Mosca, 2021, p. 1330), and helped them to project an image of novelty and youthful excitement, they are also accompanied by disadvantages. In particular, they reinforced a common media interpretation of the parties as poorly organized and ineffective.

Evolving relations between the institutionalizing movement parties and the media

Now we turn to explore the perceptions regarding the changes in the relations between the movement parties and the media over time. We hypothesize that both sides would perceive relations to have grown more positive as the parties have become more institutionalized. However, we expect contrasting attributions of responsibility (or blame) to be made by each side of the interaction. As in the preceding section, we assess each case in turn, considering the perceptions from interview respondents on either side of the interaction, with particular attention paid to any turning points in the evolving relations.

* * *

In Italy, both sides agree that the relationship has improved over time. Having initially tried to circumvent the traditional media entirely through the use of alternative means, including a notorious ban on party representatives appearing on television, the M5S began to engage more with journalists.

> We consciously decided to confront them in hostile arenas, when not overtly rigged. . . . It was decided to expose ourselves to the media meat grinder in order to try to talk about our issues anyway. The citizenship income was an example, we were slaughtered for everything but it was an issue that we managed to impose and conquer.
>
> (IT_MP1)

The crucial turning point commonly cited for a positive change in the character of relations between the party and the media was the entry of the M5S into government in 2018 (IT_M1, IT_M2, IT_M3, IT_M4, IT_M5, IT_M6, IT_MP2).[1]

> Following the 2018 elections, when [the M5S] became the majority and subsequently formed the government, the relationship softened, perhaps out of necessity. Holding institutional roles inherently grants more discretion; it's like saying, "Now you're in charge, so you have the authority to set things right." As a political entity, you have greater autonomy in deciding your course of action. You must overcome any previous reservations because your responsibilities have changed; you have a different mission now. This involves not only providing timely news updates but also offering detailed explanations of the government's activities across various departments. Therefore, by necessity, things have changed.
>
> (IT_MP2)

Other factors perceived to have brought change to the party's media approach include the death of the party co-founder and "guru" Gianroberto

Casaleggio in 2016, with whom the idea of direct democracy and communication faded in importance (IT_M7). Additionally, the adoption of new party statutes signaling a new level of professionalization, and particularly successful election campaigns, such as the 2012 Sicilian regional election, are cited as influential (IT_MP2). As the party's systemic position evolved, and with their proximity to governmental power, journalists noted a professionalization of the party's organizational and media strategy (IT_M1, IT_M3, IT_M4, IT_M5, IT_M7). This professionalization is characterized by a more open approach, contrasting with their earlier strategy of avoidance and obstruction. There emerged a greater willingness to engage with the media, described as "political maturity" (IT_M4, IT_M6, IT_MP1). This maturity improved respect on both sides of the relationship and fostered a mutual understanding of the convergence of interests and the need to collaborate (IT_M2, IT_M3, IT_MP3).

> What was once a movement has increasingly solidified into a political party. . . . It's a shift that follows both in communication – how the Five Star Movement presents itself – and organisationally, resembling more and more that of a traditional political party. . . . There's also a move toward a relationship with the press, television, and journalists much more akin to that of a traditional party.
>
> (IT_M1)

Nevertheless tensions between the M5S and the Italian media persisted, even in this latter phase. The party has faced particular difficulties during times of crisis, which were numerous as it transitioned into a party of government. In such moments, according to one journalist "compared to other political forces, they have more difficulty in managing them from the point of view of communication, in a coherent and rational way" (IT_M7). Organizational weaknesses also persisted, affecting their relations with the media. Lacking territorial roots, the M5S maintained a strongly centralized system of communication, centered around the leader, leading to difficulties for journalists to contact specific candidates (IT_M1 and IT_M7).

* * *

In Denmark, there have been shifts in the relations between the media and The Alternative, tracking the party's varying level of importance to formal parliamentary politics. There is a commonly held perception of an increase in the party's newsworthiness following its entry into parliament in 2015 (DK_M1, DK_MP1, DK_MP2). Amidst its increasing electoral success and institutionalization, there followed a developing effectiveness of the party's organization (DK_MP4), and its media strategy more specifically (DK_M2, DK_MP2, DK_MP3). The Alternative, while still a small party, was proving itself to be newsworthy in the eyes of journalists. Yet scandal followed soon

after, with a leadership crisis in 2020 and the departure of many senior figures from the party.

> People started to realise that The Alternative was very unprofessional and not in control. That's the kind of thing the media look for; the hair in the soup. And that hair is very, very big in The Alternative because of deep conflicts within the party. . . . Well, they are again labelled a bit of a clown party.
>
> (DK_M1)

Since then, some recovery in the party's performance, and media coverage has followed, helped by the selection of a new leader, Franciska Rosenkilde, in 2021, and her election to parliament the following year (DK_M1, DK_MP2, DK_MP3).

> It's because The Alternative have more seats now, and they also have a better and bigger organisation to be able to push stories to the media, and to assert themselves in various debates. . . . The Alternative is still a party that doesn't have a super strong dialogue, or much co-operation with the traditional media, but it is clearly improving that they have elected their party chairman, Franciska Rosenkilde, and it always helps that you have a party chairman who . . . sits in the parliament and can act politically there.
>
> (DK_M1)

> In the last six months she [Franciska Rosenkilde] became much more known in the media, also because she got a lot of national media time. . . . Then some of the young people who don't remember The Alternative's collapse and don't remember [preceding party leader] Uffe's "la la la circus stuff" start to think: "Wow, that Alternative, they're the only ones who do what they say and say what they do . . . they can really offer something."
>
> (DK_MP3)

At the core of the party's appeal to both voters and the media is their focus on an increasingly salient issue in Denmark: climate change (DK_M1). According to some within the party, the media had been slow to recognize the importance of an issue which the party had been engaging with. This neglect of emerging societal trends was attributed to the fact that the Danish political media establishment is rooted in the capital city, and, just as in the case of the radical right Danish People's Party which emerged in provincial areas decades prior, journalists missed the rise of a new issue with growing salience in areas distant from Copenhagen.

> Because the media live in Copenhagen, and Aalborg is far away, and Sønderborg is far away. And therefore it becomes an echo chamber

> here. . . . The media simply didn't have a sense of what it was that we were hitting them with.
>
> (DK_MP2)

Even as The Alternative received increasing attention in this latter phase, as acknowledged by both sides of the relationship (DK_M1, DK_MP2, DK_MP3, DK_MP4), the party continues to view the media as offering a narrow and inadequate perspective on politics, with reporting too heavily focused on personalities rather than policies.

> I detest the traditional media because they are so extremely system-preserving, without even realising that this is what they are doing. . . . Their focus on people has no bearing on changing the system at all, because everyone has grown up in the same system. . . . They may well be able to topple individual politicians on a personal matter, but they simply cannot carry out the systemic structural criticism. . . . That's my huge frustration with traditional media, then and now.
>
> (DK_MP1)

* * *

In the UK, the relations between Momentum and the media underwent several shifts over time. The first significant change occurred after the 2017 General Election, which caused widespread surprise in the media. Despite negative opinion polls, Labour managed to improve on its previous election performance and gain seats. While not an outright victory, it was widely interpreted as a success, attributed to the ideas and campaigning activities of Momentum and party leader Jeremy Corbyn (UK_M3, UK_M4, UK_M5, UK_MP1, UK_MP2, UK_MP3, UK_MP4). In the aftermath of the election, more attention was given to the movement, hostility was reduced, and Momentum was taken more seriously (UK_M3, UK_M4, UK_M5).

The second significant change came with the increasing prominence of two divisive issues within the Labour Party. The Brexit negotiations between 2016 and 2019 exposed differences in opinion between those who thought the party should advocate finding a way back into the EU, and those who thought it would be better to support leaving the EU, and so avoid alienating the so-called Red Wall Labour voters with more nationalist and traditional values. Even more divisive and damaging was the issue of anti-Semitism. Media reports accused the radical left side of the party, including in Momentum, of harboring anti-Semitic sentiments. Divisions emerged within Momentum between those who believed it was a serious issue that needed to be addressed and apologized for and those who felt it was being exaggerated by the media in order to damage the leadership of Corbyn (UK_M5). The media closely covered incidents of alleged anti-Semitism involving party figures, and the divisions opening up within the movement. Given its form as a

movement party, the members of Momentum were perceived as particularly crucial to the organization. As a result, their controversial ideas and divisions were seen as reflective of the movement more broadly and were thus more damaging.

> I would say that as time went on, it became clear that parts of Momentum were just different. I mean, like you can't tar all of these organisations with one brush . . . it's not as simple as saying that everybody within Momentum was a swivel-eyed Jew hater or anything. But I think that as time went on, people did become attuned to the reality. . . . I think that failures within Corbyn's office to address this problem did mean that Momentum sort of became part of this wider factional battle. (UK_M2).

The third significant change came with the crushing defeat of the Labour Party at the 2019 General Election. This was widely interpreted as demonstrating the rejection of the radical ideas of Jeremy Corbyn and Momentum. Particularly following the selection of the more centrist Sir Keir Starmer as Labour leader in April 2020, the relevance of Momentum to the media was perceived to decline (UK_M3, UK_MP2, UK_MP4). However, some within the party saw this defeat as the culmination of a concerted effort by a media establishment threatened by Momentum's radical challenge to the political system. According to such viewpoints, an alliance had been formed between journalists and the centrist, anti-Corbyn wing of the Labour Party, who shared similar views, backgrounds and networks, and collaborated on a hostile approach to Momentum to neutralize its threat (UK_MP4).

* * *

In Germany, both sides of the party–media relationship agree that media attention to the AfD has increased over time, and relations have worsened. Journalists attribute this change to the ideological radicalization of the AfD, along with its increasing vote share and growing proximity to power. The party's entry into parliament in 2017 prompted greater attention from the *Bundesamt für Verfassungsschutz* (Federal Office for the Protection of the Constitution). This raised the level of threat perceived by journalists, and the need for greater scrutiny of the party. Given the normalization effect of parliamentary representation on radical right parties (Valentim, 2021), this seems a rational response from actors who perceive the party to pose a democratic threat.

> I think that we should look more closely at the AfD, at what the AfD wants. . . . Is the AfD actually still a democratic party; is it still in line with the Basic Law, or no longer? That is, of course, of great importance. . . . And if [the party programme] becomes more radical, it

> naturally also means that one has to deal with it more intensively, in order to see what these points actually mean, what is being demanded. And then, at the same time, for various reasons, they have an increasing level of support among the electorate and that, of course, always drives us to look very closely at: A) Where and what are the reasons for this? And B) what would actually happen if this party came to power or gained power and implemented parts of its election programme?
>
> (DE_M2)

However, members of the AfD argue that the attention received by the media still does not reach the levels, nor the character, justified by their growing popularity. The negativity in coverage is claimed to demonstrate bias and a deliberate attempt to suppress the spread of their ideas and limit their electoral growth. As a consequence, there is a perception within the party that the media system is united in opposition to the party in an undemocratic manner.

> The mainstream media, through this course of defamation, and this ignorance, are trying to keep the AfD down, not to appear. Even now that the AfD is on the rise in the polls, you don't see AfD politicians on talk shows, on public broadcasting, and they suddenly don't have any interview requests in the relevant major print media. . . . You then experience the media as some kind of system media. . . . The system doesn't want the AfD to establish itself in any way and, above all, its arguments and opinions. . . . And generally speaking, this is a completely undemocratic and unprofessional behaviour of the *Vierte Gewalt* ('fourth estate'), which is actually not there to defame the opposition, but rather to control the government, and not to prevent the opposition from becoming stronger.
>
> (DE_MP2)

This approach from the media is considered by those within the AfD to be rooted in the biases of journalists, who hold different views on the core issue of immigration in particular, as well as the pressure exerted on the media by other parties (DE_MP1). Despite these differences of opinion, and the perception of anti-democratic behavior on either side, there are still suggestions of a productive working relationship, characterized by professionalism and trust (DE_MP4). The AfD and the media share a mutual understanding of the mutual benefits accrued from their interaction, and so a "love-hate relationship" has developed (DE_MP3, DE_MP4).

> Both sides depend on each other, so the journalists, no matter how critical they may be of the AfD, have an interest in receiving exclusive information as naturally as possible. And of course you only usually get that if you are friendly. So. . . . if you are always poisoning each other,

> then of course not. . . . So that's what I would describe as professional. However, you are always aware that we are viewed particularly critically by most journalists, if not all of them.
>
> (DE_MP4)

Discussion and conclusion

Examining perceptions of the evolving relations between movement parties and the traditional media, this analysis has revealed differences between the four cases. The M5S in Italy most closely aligns with expectations. Following initial mutual hostility, relations improved as the party achieved electoral successes and became more institutionalized. The Danish and British cases are less consistent with expectations. Both The Alternative and Momentum underwent dynamic journeys, with positive developments from the initially negative relations thanks to electoral successes and greater recognition of their place in the political system, as well as significant setbacks amidst internal crises. The German case contrasts with expectations. The initial negativity of relations only worsened over time, as the increasing extremism of the AfD led to intensifying hostility with both sides accusing the other of behavior threatening democracy. An overview of the findings from each case is provided in Table 6.3.

To understand the evolution of relations between these four parties and the media, it is helpful to consider their particular features as *movement parties*. Despite profound ideological differences between them, there are two features typical of this type of party in particular which, according to our interviews, generate commonalities. First, the fluid and relatively unstructured organizational form of movement parties. On the one hand, this tends to give a heightened role to party members. An open model of membership generates risks, as the controversial views of the relatively unregulated membership are interrogated by the press. They receive a high degree of attention, as they are perceived to be reflective of the party's leadership and the party as a whole. On the other hand, the movement party organizational form also tends to elevate the role of a charismatic leader, with less prominence given to other senior party figures and MPs. This carries similar risks for the parties, as the media tend to concentrate their attention on leaders and heavily mediatized crises are prone to erupt and circulate around them. Both party members and leaders have created challenges to the relationship with the media in the British, Danish and Italian cases.

Second, movement parties' reliance on digital media. Their use of online/social media to circumvent legacy media and directly reach the public is crucial to their strategy to grow and establish themselves. It also presents a challenge for the traditional media, sometimes intensifying tensions. The use of digital media is particularly evident in some cases – The Alternative, M5S, and, to a slightly lesser extent, Momentum, but much less so with the AfD.

Table 6.3 Summary of findings

Country	*Movement party*	*Initial media–party relations*	*Changes in media–party relations*	*Turning points in media–party relations*	*Movement party characteristics most commonly referred to as contributory factors in the interviews*
Denmark	The Alternative (*Alternativet*)	Negative – hostility from media	Varied – positive changes immediately following 2015 election, then more negative with leadership crisis, then more positive again	– Parliamentary entry – Changes in leadership	– Key role of members – Charismatic leadership – Use of digital media – Organizational weaknesses – Distinctive issue positions (environment)
Germany	Alternative for Germany (AfD)	Negative – mutual hostility	Worsened – more critical attention from media, more obstruction and disengagement from party	– Ideological radicalization – Parliamentary entry	– Distinctive issue positions (immigration)
Italy	Five Star Movement (M5S)	Negative – mutual hostility	Improved – more attention from media, more professionalism from party	– Parliamentary entry – Entry into government	– Key role of members – Charismatic leadership – Use of digital media – Organizational weaknesses
United Kingdom	Momentum (faction of Labour Party)	Negative – hostility from media	Varied – positive changes immediately following 2017 election, then turn more negative with internal divisions and crushing electoral defeat	– Electoral results – Rise in salience of divisive issues	– Key role of members – Charismatic leadership – Use of digital media – Distinctive issue positions (various)

Additionally, as expected, shifts in media relations experienced by the parties are connected to their institutionalization. Initially perceived as irrelevant due to their small size or niche issue focus, the parties gained popularity, electoral successes and entry into formal political institutions. Journalists perceive their influence to grow as a result. Only after entry into parliament, and in the case of the M5S into government, does the media provide more attention and take them more seriously. Entry into institutions provides greater resources, allowing parties to take more professional care of communication and relations with journalists.

Another essential factor to understand the evolving relations between movement parties and the media is the ideological positioning of the parties. The perceived radicalism of the AfD and Momentum led to fears from journalists about their threat to democracy, influencing their coverage and their relations with the parties. This is less evident with the M5S, in the light of its recent government participation and ideological moderation. It is even less evident with The Alternative, as an environmental party, whose issue positions are much closer to those held by many mainstream journalists.

In conclusion, our analysis highlights the most crucial factors in the relationship between movement parties and the traditional media, as perceived by the actors involved. It is important to clarify that our results are based on the factors most frequently cited in interviews to explain these interactions. Additional factors that the literature commonly cites as important, such as M5S's novel positions (Conti and Memoli, 2015) and AfD's organizational exceptionalism (Heinze and Weisskircher, 2021), may have also played a role, but were not mentioned in our interviews.

Note

1 A nuance is added by one party representative, who claims this productive shift only followed after the second government involving the M5S (IT_MP4). In September 2019 they joined a governing coalition with the center-left PD, after the breakdown of their first governing coalition with the populist radical right Lega.

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7 Movement parties on social media between protest and polity arena

Matthias Hoffmann and Christina Neumayer

Introduction

In this chapter and based on findings of a social media analysis of movement parties across country cases (for original publications, see Hoffmann and Neumayer, 2024a; Hoffmann and Neumayer, 2024b), we highlight how the conceptualization of movement parties at the intersection of institutional and extra institutional politics, or the protest arena and the electoral arena, is reflected in the realm of digital communication. Social movement strategies toward media in the "Quadruple A" model – abstention, attack, adaptation, and [search for] alternatives – (Rucht, 2004) are increasingly dominated by the use of digital and social media (e.g., Facebook, X(Twitter), YouTube). In contemporary "hybrid media systems" (Chadwick, 2017), social movements and movement parties can actively shape their public representation. Social media communication has become more and more relevant in political campaigning throughout Europe, particularly for less-established parties, the "underdogs" of the political system (Larsson and Kalsnes, 2014), such as movement parties. Alongside their links to traditional media, movement parties may establish connections to interest and civil society groups, social movements, religious organizations, traditional political institutions, and alternative media (della Porta et al., 2017). Social media are the public space in which parties communicate with their electorate, with social movements, and with political competitors. Interactions on social media are markers of recognition, hence building blocks of relational fields, which serve to position actors vis-à-vis one another.

Based on that understanding, we aim to scrutinize shifts over time in movement parties' social media presence. We employ several datasets on movement parties' social media activity (such as likes, mentions, posts, recommendations, retweets, shares, follower patterns, and images) across our six country cases for evidence of realignments in movement parties' relationships in the protest and the electoral arena. The media ecology now incorporates broadcast, interactive (i.e., audiences engaging with media outlets), and participatory media (driven by user-generated content). While political parties, interest groups, and social movements borrow digital

DOI: 10.4324/9781003532507-7

organizational and mobilization repertoires from one another (Chadwick, 2007), observing alignments of movement parties on different social media platforms over time provides an understanding of how their general network structures diverge as well as of changes in their organizational networks and linkages to media in transitional periods, such as electoral success or failure. This furthers understanding of relationships to political elites, other social movements, elite/fringe/tabloid media, and competition among them as well as enables identification of changes in their organizational structures, such as increasing or decreasing levels of centralization. We add a temporal perspective on movement parties by identifying key moments in the movement party life course. Through an analysis of social media communication, this chapter maps the social media presence of movement parties and identifies moments of substantial shifts over time and patterns across country cases.

Movement parties' social media communication

As movement parties enter the polity as "newcomer parties" (Gerbaudo, 2019), digital communication and particularly social media play an important role in their "progressive recognition" (Pavan, 2017, p. 443) as established members of institutional politics. Movement parties often lack organizational resources and access to other possibilities for dissemination and communication. They rely heavily on digital communication (della Porta et al., 2017) and embrace digital media for internal organizational processes and political communication. This also invites a research agenda geared toward "understanding movement parties through their communication" (Mercea and Mosca, 2021, p. 1327) which this chapter is concerned with. Social media communication allows us to observe interactions between challenger parties, incumbent parties, and parties with an established position in the polity arena and interrogate their ties with the protest arena.

Not only movements' transitions from extra institutional to institutional politics but also subsequent electoral gains can trigger repositioning in the polity. Relationships in relatively stable fields of actors (such as members of the polity) can be subject to change due to "the rise of new actors, new interests, or exogenous shocks that change power positions" (Zietsma et al., 2017, p. 404). Institutionalization of movement parties can be understood as the "establishment . . . of spaces or focal points within the institutional milieu" (Morgan, 2007, p. 276) in spatial terms. This does not happen in a deterministic process following the "iron law" of oligarchy (Michels, 2001); but the shifts and changes brought about by these processes are "subject of elucidation" (Morgan, 2007, p. 276). One aspect of investigating the consequences of social movements is that institutionalization fundamentally changes the "continuous interactions between different actors in the political system" (Bosi, 2016, p. 338). Referencing practices in the form of likes, shares, retweets or favors are ways to produce visibility for individuals or

organizations on social media (Neumayer et al., 2021). Therefore, processes of institutionalization or deinstitutionalization in a movement party's lifecycle over time can shift, and their institutional positioning can be observed as a change in referencing patterns in the digital communication of movement parties in the polity (Pavan, 2017).

In their self-representation on social media, movement parties seize control of the narrative that they send to potential voters rather than merely supporting the grievances expressed through the (visual) performance of protest. Throughout their organizational lifespan in a continuum between polity membership and challenger status, movement parties constantly position themselves vis-à-vis established parties, civil society, and media, and hence, may embrace different action strategies (including protest) at different points in time (Goldstone, 2003). In their own narratives of these processes, they use images of collective action (like protest) which activates boundaries and signals openness to social groups and organizations from the challenger spectrum (Tilly, 2004). In other words, as movement parties enter the polity, their narrative as part of the polity changes due to their entering the new positioning. We observe these adjustments through their linkages to protest events and social movements via referencing practices to other actors, via their protest-related language, and via the use of images of protest. The latter includes visual cues on social media (McSwiney et al., 2021); yet, social media can also deactivate boundaries by inactivity or by distorting and mainstreaming protest issues. Hence, studies have shown various degrees of differentiation between movements and parties across Europe (Borbáth and Hutter, 2021), as well as a complex interplay between parties and various forms of protest (Hoffmann et al., 2022).

Politicians or aspiring party leaders often receive attention on social media from the news media, other political parties, and journalists (Kruikemeier et al., 2018). One example of that is Rasmus Paludan, the leader of the Danish far-right political party *Stram Kurs* (Hard Line), who was constantly featured in the media, and his performances were broadcast widely on social media (particularly on YouTube). While he was criticized and mentioned by established parties for his performative acts of burning the Quran wrapped in bacon in inner-city areas of Copenhagen predominately inhabited by immigrants, his party never received much attention as a political institution (Kosiara-Pedersen, 2020). On the contrary, party organizations often fail to do so unless they are established actors in the polity. Focusing on official accounts of political parties allows us to shed light on movement parties' social media communication, as they institutionalize and become established actors in the polity. The recognition in the form of social media interactions given to a political party (rather than an individual political actor) allows us to identify different positioning in the polity and various trajectories of their significance in relation to established political parties.

Within this line of arguing, our working hypothesis is that movement parties will devote more of their public digital communication to protest than

traditional parties, as this can serve to strengthen ties with actors outside of institutional politics and ultimately bridge the divide between the protest and the electoral arena. This also includes their connecting to movements through linkages and using protest images being dependent on their positioning in between the institutional and protest arena. To that end, we examined how movement parties use images of protest in their social media communication and what crucial narratives they seek to convey. While this assumption flows almost logically from theorizing around movement parties, we argue that systematic empirical investigations on that matter remain rare, and hence attempts to study the public engagement of political parties' communication with the protest arena (in its widest understanding) can help address this research gap.

Cases of movement parties

In this chapter, we apply a broad definition of movement parties to test the heuristic potential of the concept against a variety of cases. Hence we examine a diverse range of parties, each with unique characteristics and trajectories. For instance, Germany's far-right AfD evolved from an ordoliberal critique of the European financial regime to incorporate right-wing protest and civil society ties, ultimately embedding protest in their action repertoire (Heinze and Weisskircher, 2023). In contrast, Denmark's The Alternative (Alternativet) exemplifies a value-driven, deliberative organizational approach (Husted, 2018), a characteristic also shared by its splinter group, the Independent Greens (Frie Grønne), which emerged in response to Alternativet's crisis and disintegration in 2020. This critical juncture presents an opportunity to investigate how these processes are reflected in their digital communication. Other cases include Hungary's Jobbik, which transformed from a far-right Christian student movement into a fully fledged party that eventually took a centrist turn (Pirro, 2019); Italy's Five Star Movement (M5S), a populist party that transitioned from challenger to governing party (Mercea and Mosca, 2021); Romania's Save Romania Union (USR), which evolved from civic protest into an institutionalized party (Dragoman, 2020); the United Kingdom Independence Party, which lingered on the margins of British politics and eventually disintegrated after Brexit (Klein and Pirro, 2020); and Momentum, a movement party within a party, originating from within UK Labour and reactivating its movement roots and ties (Dennis, 2020). Despite their differing trajectories and ideological orientations, all these movement parties share the common characteristic of being recognized challengers within their respective political landscapes (Hoffmann and Neumayer, 2024a), and they all utilize social media platforms for public communication. For a systematic assessment of movement parties' distinct communicative patterns, we contrast them with parties from the more traditional spectrum of conservative, social-democratic and liberal families. For an overview of parties in our dataset by country, see Table 7.1.

Table 7.1 Selected parties by country

Country	*Movement Parties*	*Traditional Parties*
DENMARK	ALTERNATIVET/FRIE GRØNNE	SOCIALDEMOKRATERNE, DANSK FOLKEPARTI, VENSTRE
GERMANY	ALTERNATIVE FÜR DEUTSCHLAND (AFD)/DIE LINKE	SOZIALDEMOKRATISCHE PARTEI DEUTSCHLANDS, CHRISTLICH DEMOKRATISCHE UNION
HUNGARY	JOBBIK MAGYARORSZÁGÉRT MOZGALOM (JOBBIK)	FIDESZ – MAGYAR POLGÁRI SZÖVETSÉG/MAGYAR SZOCIALISTA PÁRT
ITALY	MOVIMENTO CINQUE STELLE (M5S)	PARTIDO DEMOCRATICO, LEGA, FORZA ITALIA
ROMANIA	UNIUNEA SALVAȚI BUCUREȘTIUL/ROMÂNIA (USB/USR/USRPLUS)	PARTIDUL SOCIAL DEMOCRAT, PARTIDUL NAȚIONAL LIBERAL
UK	UNITED KINGDOM INDEPENDENCE PARTY (UKIP)/MOMENTUM	LABOUR/CONSERVATIVES

Research design, data collection, and methods

Our analysis comprises three parts. First, we collected over 890,000 Facebook and Twitter posts from six movement parties and 12 traditional parties across six countries (see Table 7.2), covering the timeframe from January 2010 to June 2021 (see Hoffmann and Neumayer, 2024a, for details). In these social media posts, we identified movement parties' references to traditional parties and *vice versa*. To operationalize referencing patterns, we employed a platform-agnostic approach and included instances of party-to-party referencing, including @mentions, hashtags, hyperlinks, and free-text mentions. These indicators correspond to "connective affordances" (Kalsnes et al., 2017) that acknowledge one another, redistribute content, or interact with other parties. We added the temporal perspective by visualizing the frequency of referencing practices over time, allowing us to identify distinct trajectories of movement parties in the polity arena. These trajectories are characterized by changes in their political positioning and referencing patterns. By summarizing these referencing patterns, we developed a rough measure of positional balance, which indicates the degree to which referencing is skewed toward movement parties or established parties.

Second, as the crucial conceptualization of movement parties lies in the intersection of protest and electoral arena, we also seek to shed light on the way movement parties engage with protest as the ideal-typical form of extra-institutional political participation. To do so, we queried our dataset on Facebook and Twitter posts for what we call protest-related communication, meaning posts that engage with collective contentious action, in a

Table 7.2 Number of social media posts by country and party family

Country	*Traditional Parties*	*Movement Parties*
DENMARK	28,290	35,480
GERMANY	89,863	8,731
HUNGARY	33,838	20,684
ITALY	450,592	71,834
ROMANIA	28,286	11,615
UNITED KINGDOM	66,932	47,733
TOTAL	697,801	196,077

Source: Hoffmann and Neumayer, 2024a

supportive, critical, or neutral fashion. We rely on a two-step quantitative content analysis. As a first step, we limited our study to the Danish, German, and UK country cases, but expanded the list of parties within each county. As a second step, we collected data from the additional parties' respective official social media accounts to cover the period from 2015 up to and including 2021. In total, our dataset includes 548,067 unique posts from Facebook and Twitter, created by the official accounts of 27 different parties. Next, these underwent dictionary-based filtering for texts that were potential references to protest events. Creating and fine-tuning dictionaries that contain indicators (i.e., words or n-grams) of protest is an established practice in protest event analysis to distinguish irrelevant from relevant texts (Lorenzini et al., 2022). We drafted language-specific dictionaries for Danish, English, and German, that contained words like "protest", "demonstration", "sit-in", or phrases like "take to the streets". These were rewritten as regular expressions to account for different conjugations and declinations. Furthermore, language-specific variations were taken into account when defining word boundaries in these regular expressions, like the German tendency to create compound nouns. The principal purpose of these dictionaries was to capture as many instances of protest-related communication in parties' posts, while at the same time reducing the rate of false positives that are inevitably caught by a dictionary-based filter.[1] After multiple rounds of validating the dictionaries through an assessment of false positives and false negatives and subsequent dictionary fine-tuning by native speakers, we still had to accept a certain number of false positives remaining in the dictionary-filtered dataset. Therefore, in a third step, we trained human coders to annotate each post in the resulting corpus based on a codebook that first asks coders to interpret the post in light of a false or true positive, and, in the latter case, annotate a range of other properties, that go beyond the scope of this chapter. After three rounds of coder training on random samples (n=100), we reached sufficient inter-rater reliability.

Third, we complement these quantitative approaches with an inspection of visual representations of protest in movement parties' communication. This

addresses the question of how protest is visually referenced by movement parties, and it takes the multimodal affordances of digital media into account, that is, the visual dimension along with the textual. Our dataset for this part of the analysis includes most of the movement parties and traditional parties outlined earlier and amounts to over 197,000 posts from Twitter, Facebook, and Instagram between 2010 and 2021, with about 58,500 of them being image posts. To analyze these image posts, we employed a mixed-methods approach that combines quantitative content analysis (Snelson, 2016) with qualitative visual inspection, following established methods in the field of political image analysis. First, we developed a codebook to capture various forms of extra-institutional political interest articulation, including collective street protests and symbolic representations. The coding manual was developed inductively through three rounds of coding randomly selected samples of 700 images for each coder. In addition to analyzing the images themselves, we considered multimodal information such as location, time, and text to inform our coding. We coded a random sample of 1,500 posts for each party (total: 9,584), thus preserving their temporal and platform distribution. We collectively reviewed and discussed each coding decision, resulting in 522 posts that we labeled protest image posts. For each of these, we also coded the respective party's evaluation of the depicted protest as supportive, neutral, or critical. We repeated this step on 2,200 image posts from traditional parties (200 each), to have a baseline comparison. Through a close reading of protest image posts, we sought to decode latent semantic meanings in posts, that are embedded in the textual, visual, and contextual information of each post (Doerr, 2021; Richardson and Wodak, 2009; Spector-Mersel, 2011).

Movement parties and their positioning in the polity

Our findings illustrate how movement parties reposition themselves within the political landscape, interacting with traditional party families in diverse ways. For the research presented in this chapter, we surveyed the interactions between movement parties and established parties in each of the six ProDem case countries (for detailed results, see Hoffmann and Neumayer, 2024a). At the heart of our investigation lies Kitschelt's crucial observation of the transitional nature of movement parties. This transition must not be misunderstood in the sense of the iron law of oligarchy (Michels, 2001), in which we expect a linear trajectory from social movement to fully fledged party. On the one hand, the lifecycle metaphor often applied in studies of parties' development acknowledges several transitions in the organizational nature of movement parties: first, the shift from social movement to movement party, and second, the transition from movement party to "any other form of party" (Kitschelt, 2006, p. 281). On the other hand, the metaphor falls short of recognizing Kitschelt's conceptualization of the *transitional nature* of movement parties, which is an inherent organizational trait, meaning that the outlined transitions are reversible, as movement parties are more likely

than traditional parties to adopt movement modes of political participation and hence revert to a previous point in their lifecycle.

Our research acknowledges these transitions and seeks to outline various trajectories that movement parties may follow, once they begin to position themselves in the polity arena by fielding candidates and competing in elections. While the existing literature has shed light on the genesis of these parties and their interactions with movement organizations (McAdam and Tarrow, 2010), our research seeks to understand their positioning and trajectories within the institutional framework. As Lucardie (2000) notes, newcomer parties generally face significant challenges in their struggle for electoral success, particularly in political systems that facilitate the formation of new parties (Harmel and Robertson, 1985). However, a select few do manage to overcome these hurdles and gain representation. Our study focuses on these "happy few" (Lucardie, 2000, p. 175) that have crossed the "threshold of representation" (Pedersen, 1982) and gained seats in parliament. Furthermore, we recognize the importance of European Parliament elections as a "stepping stone" for new and emerging parties to reach national parliaments (Blombäck, 2020). Therefore, our study maps out patterns of interaction between movement parties and established parties and understands turning points and moments of transition from the perspective of movement party lifecycles. According to Pedersen (1982), there are four critical thresholds in parties' lifecycles: declaration (the announcement to form a party), authorization (passing the legal requirements to field candidates), representation, and potentially, the threshold of relevance. Despite passing thresholds, parties may still succumb to "organizational death" through dissolution or merger, even after having passed several thresholds (Bolleyer et al., 2019).

From a relational perspective, each transition marks a significant shift in the party's institutional positioning relative to other parties, when movement parties "make the transition from acting outside of institutional politics to being accepted as a legitimate actor in the field of parties" (Goldstone, 2004, p. 336). From a perspective of relational fields (Crossley and Diani, 2019), patterns of (mutual) recognition with other members of the institutional arena serve as a point of reference to understand a movement party within a field, as each actor within a relational field seeks and grants recognition from and to others. From this onset, we seek to understand how thresholds in movement parties' lifecycles correspond to reconfigurations of recognition patterns in the field of institutional politics. Building on the cyclic perspective, we identify different types of movement parties' trajectories in the polity arena by observing transitions and alignments in their interactions with traditional party families on social media, which serve as a proxy for their positioning in the polity. From the relational perspective of contentious politics, these transitions reflect the reconfiguration of relationships between members of the polity (Crossley and Diani, 2019), expressed through shifting patterns in their social media communication. As the existence of a field "depends on actors' reciprocal recognition" (Diani and Pilati, 2011, p. 226),

visualizing the referencing practices between movement parties and traditional party families on social media allows us to outline their institutional positioning in relation to other parties – and, by adding a temporal layer, their trajectories in the institutional arena.

Figure 7.1 illustrates our operationalization. In the top half, we can observe the monthly fraction of the movement party's (in this case, USR) Twitter and Facebook posts, that contain a reference to one of the two established parties (PSD & PNL) in Romania. The lower side of the plot shows the respective referencing activity from both established parties toward the movement party. Vertical lines in the plot indicate national (dot-dashed) or European (dashed) elections. As the data shows, there was little to no recognition of the movement party by established parties before the 2016 election, in which USR passed the representation threshold for the first time. After which, however, recognition starts and stabilizes at a low level. USR, however, shows more or less consistently high engagement with the two established parties. A crucial turning point was marked by the December 2020 election, which saw another electoral victory for USR (in alliance with the PLUS party), which led them into a coalition government as PNL's junior partner; Clearly, USR had now crossed the relevance threshold in its lifecycle. In terms of referencing patterns, we can observe that this not only changes but for some months even reverses the challenging-vs.-established dynamic, with established parties

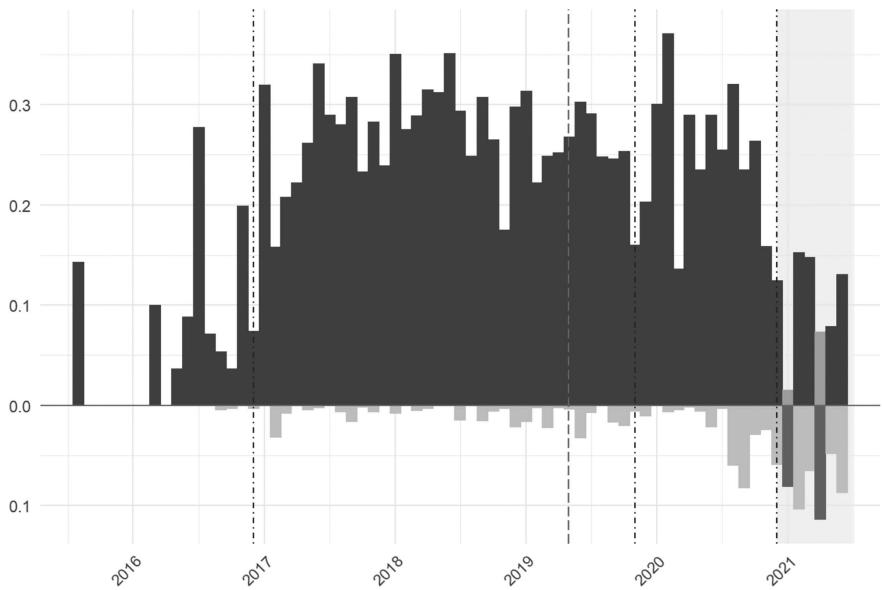


Figure 7.1 Movement party and traditional party references in Romania over time (dot-dashed lines: national election/dashed line: European elections)

Source: Hoffmann and Neumayer, 2024a

increasing their referencing of the movement party, which in turn drastically reduces its own mentions of the two established parties.

Our second example of a movement party, UKIP (Figure 7.2), shows that a process of growing relevance in recognition in the polity can be followed by a return to an outsider pattern of communication. While UKIP had existed for a considerable time, the one-sided pattern of relatively high engagement with established parties (Labour, Conservative) with little to no recognition in return characterizes UKIP's outsider status before the European elections in 2014. UKIP's landslide success, winning 26% of the votes, saw them pass the representation threshold. Despite Britain's first-past-the-post electoral system, UKIP won a seat in the House of Commons in 2015, with 12.6% of the national vote. It is this period during which we observe a reduction in relative engagement from UKIP toward established parties, with Labour and Conservatives in turn showing a consistent, albeit limited, engagement with UKIP in their own social media communication. Strikingly, once the Leave vote in the Brexit referendum was passed, UKIP suffered crushing electoral defeats in local, national, and European elections. The pattern of communicative recognition hence shifts back to the outsider mode, with UKIP increasing its references to established parties, while the latter returns to non-acknowledging the movement party.

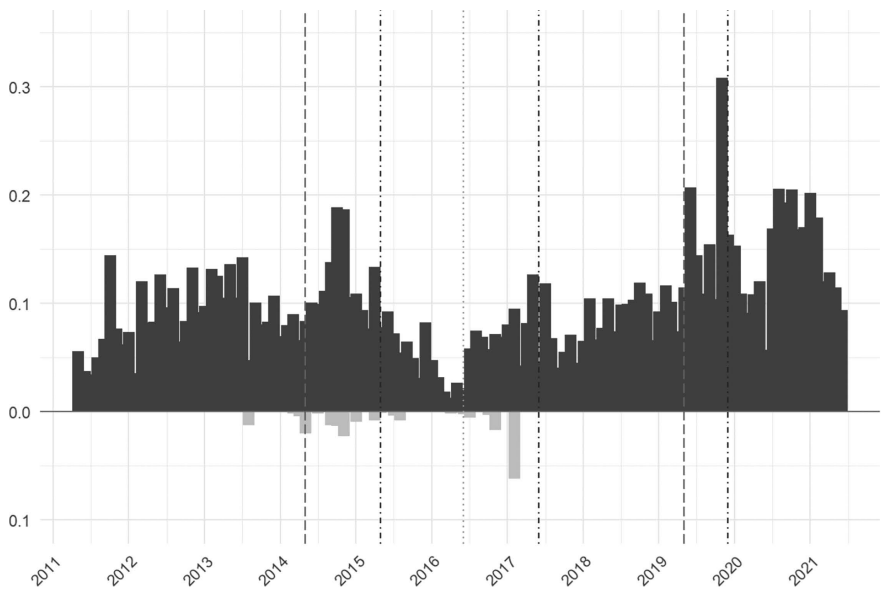


Figure 7.2 Movement party and traditional party references in the UK over time (dot-dashed lines: national election/dashed line: European elections/dotted line: Brexit referendum)

Source: Hoffmann and Neumayer, 2024a

Table 7.3 Balance measures by movement parties positioning, including group mean and standard deviation

Positioning	*Balance Score Mean (sd)*
OUTSIDER	.070 (.086)
INSTITUTIONALIZED CHALLENGER	.134 (.112)
INCUMBENT	.684 (.178)

Overall, we find common patterns in these positionings (we prefer this over the more static "position", as it implies the constant repositioning of actors in a relational communicative field) across different country cases. Our example of a trajectory from outsider to incumbency position in Romania is equally observed in Italy, where M5S followed a similar route. The trajectory from outsider to institutionalized challenger and back to an outsider position that characterized UKIP could similarly be applied to Alternativet in Denmark. Third (but not shown here), Jobbik in Hungary and the AfD in Germany illustrate another trajectory, from outsider status to an established position as a challenger within the polity, neither threatened by immediate organizational death nor afforded with a realistic option toward incumbency. This taxonomy of party positioning and repositioning in a longitudinal perspective allowed us to operationalize a score, which reflects an aggregate measure of the imbalance in movement parties' and established parties' referencing patterns (Table 7.3).

Our findings support the transitional nature of movement parties: a stabilized position within the polity as an institutionalized challenger or incumbent party is by no means the only or even the most expected outcome once movement parties cross the representation threshold. Instead, movement parties may just as well return to an outsider position in a county's polity. On the one hand, understanding movement parties in their life cycle thus crucially helps our understanding of this new breed of party organization. On the other hand, we understand the lifecycle metaphor not only as a deterministic one that results in maturity and establishment, but, rather like F. Scott Fitzgerald's Benjamin Button, it might just as well go the other way.

Movement parties' references to protest

While we have shed light on movement parties' relationship with other actors of the polity, the crucial conceptualization of movement parties lies in the intersection of the protest and the electoral arena. From a perspective of social media and digital communication, we thus seek to inquire about the way movement parties engage with protest as the ideal-typical form of extra institutional political participation. With that step, we turn our attention to the potential for movement parties to transfer grievances and protest issues from the protest arena to the polity by publicly signaling engagement

with protest in their communication. To that end, we queried our dataset on Facebook and Twitter posts for what we call protest-related communication, meaning posts that engage with collective contentious action, in a supportive, critical, or neutral fashion. Applied to our corpus, the dictionary identified between 0.3% and 7.2% as potentially protest-related (except for one outlier, the Danish far-right party Stram Kurs at 21.2%), and human coding validated between 36% and 96% percent of those as true positives. Tables 7.4–7.6 present the percentage of posts that were found to be true positives relative to the overall amount of posts for selected parties from traditional party families as well as movement parties. These empirical results support the initial hypothesis of movement parties being more engaged with protest in their public digital communication. Although to varying degrees, in each country the numbers for movement parties are higher than for traditional parties. Notably, where the political landscape is dominated by the rivalry between conservatives and social democrats, that is, in Germany and the UK, social democratic parties surpass conservatives by more than double the relative protest posts. This striking finding shows that social democrats, with their roots in labor struggles of the 19th and 20th centuries, might be

Table 7.4 Protest-related social media communication in Denmark by party

Party Family	*Party Name*	*Percentage of Protest-Related Posts*
MOVEMENT PARTIES	ALTERNATIVET	1.3
	FRIE GRØNNE	2.1
	STRAM KURS	20.4
TRADITIONAL PARTIES	SOCIALDEMOKRATIET	0.2
	VENSTRE	0.1
	DANSK FOLKEPARTI	0.4

Table 7.5 Protest-related social media communication in Germany by party

Party Family	*Party Name*	*Percentage of Protest-Related Posts*
MOVEMENT PARTIES	AFD	2.7
	DIE LINKE	6.3
TRADITIONAL PARTIES	SOZIALDEMOKRATISCHE PARTEI DEUTSCHLANDS (SPD)	1.3
	CHRISTLICH DEMOKRATISCHE PARTEI DEUTSCHLANDS + CHRISTILICH SOZIALE PARTEI DEUTSCHLANDS (CDU/CSU)	0.5

Table 7.6 Protest-related social media communication in the UK by party

Party Family	*Party Name*	*Percentage of Protest-Related Posts*
MOVEMENT PARTIES	UNITED KINGDOM INDEPENDENCE PARTY (UKIP)	0.7
	REFORM UK	3.1
TRADITIONAL PARTIES	LABOUR	0.5
	CONSERVATIVES	0.2

characterized as proto- or first-generation movement parties. However, all our selected movement parties that surged in the 21st century surpass social democratic parties in terms of relative protest posts. Hence, we may conclude that the conceptualization of these parties at the intersection of the protest and the electoral arena is empirically supported by the traces of public communication we analyzed. As members of the polity, they not only find themselves in a position to bridge institutional and extrainstitutional political participation, by talking about protest issues, but they actively use the visibility and outreach afforded to them as political parties to communicate on protest more than their traditional counterparts.

Naturally, these findings invite further inspections into how protest is talked about by political parties. To cater to that research gap, we present findings from our analysis of visual narratives around protest in movement parties Twitter, Facebook and Instagram communication in the following section.

Protest in movement parties' visual communication

As we cannot discuss all findings of this analysis in this part of the chapter (see Hoffmann and Neumayer, 2024b, for detailed findings), we limit ourselves to the presentation of one crucial visual narrative that we identified in movement parties' communication and that complements the above sections with a qualitative glance. This allows us to identify overarching visual narratives, their reproduction, and use them to challenge existing hegemonic orders, to align with protest and express solidarity, or to de-legitimize protesters. The trajectories of movement parties and their visual narratives offer insights into the processes of *deradicalization and reradicalization*. Jobbik, for instance, initially employed radicalized forms of action in its visual representations, frequently emphasizing strength in numbers and impending danger through pictures of disorderly masses, huge amounts of national flags, and smoke-filled air. However, over time, the party's repositioning toward a more conservative stance is reflected in its visual representation of protest. In contrast to earlier images featuring nationalistic marches, Jobbik later shared images of individualized, domesticated protests, where national

symbols become used in playful subtleties of color. Likewise, protest issues tend to change from more contested issues such as revisionism, toward more mainstream issues like environmental protection.

Similarly, the Danish Alternativet, emerging from environmental movements, initially aligned with radicalized imagery, including depictions of mass protests. However, by 2021, Alternativet had shifted away from direct radical action in its visual language, opting for a more stylized and often purely symbolic representation of protest, shifting from a documentary style toward a professionalized framing of mainstream political statements within its party colors and logo. The Danish case illustrates the transitional nature of movement parties (Kitschelt, 2006), as well as the dynamic nature of contention (McAdam et al., 2004). The emergence of a split-off party, *Frie Grønne*, came with a reradicalization, as seen in images of resistance and disruption that portray activists as political subjects and lend legitimacy to disruptive actions like blockades and demands for citizen participation. Hence, both the examples of Jobbik and Alternativet exemplify a move toward a more conservative visual language, that – as the example of Frie Grønne shows – must not be misunderstood as an inevitable linear process. Ultimately, through visuals of protest on social media, movement parties can seek distance or proximity to activists, thus leaving or reentering the disruptive arena of protest.

Conclusion

Across the findings, the empirical results support the initial hypothesis of movement parties being a transitional actor constantly and publicly negotiating their place in both the protest and the electoral arena. Particularly, we have shown that digital public communication on social media is a crucial venue for these processes of positioning and repositioning as parties employ the affordances of platforms to send signals to other actors, their electorate and a wider public. The visibility and hence capital parties possess in a digital public sphere is both accumulated and activated through acts of recognition, references to protest events, and the visual narratives around protest. At the same time, our social media analysis highlights the transitional nature of movement parties and their shifting relations to social movements and protests but also to other political parties. These shifts sediment in referencing practices as well as their use of images of protest as part of their social media communication. Through these linkages, we see on the one hand, that during the life cycle of movement parties, they may establish themselves as a political actor in the polity, moving further away from social movements and radical forms of political interest articulation, and hence closer to political parties established in the polity. On the other hand, this is not a deterministic process, or "iron law", but can just as well be reversed and/or coincide with the organizational disintegration of a movement party. Of course, our analysis fuels the need to understand better how movement parties and traditional parties talk about protest and under what conditions they seek to activate

ties to extrainstitutional political actors like social movements – and whether these are reciprocated. While we do acknowledge this need, we leave it to future research and content ourselves with the non-trivial conclusion that theoretical reasoning around movement parties finds its empirical expressions also in the digital public sphere.

Acknowledgments

This chapter is based on the following two articles:

Hoffmann, M., & Neumayer, C. (2024a). Movement parties' interactions on social media: positioning and trajectories in the polity arena. *Journal of Information Technology and Politics*, *21*(3), 303–322. https://doi.org/10.1080/19331681.2023.2239817

Hoffmann, M., & Neumayer, C. (2024b). Images of protest in movement parties' social media communication. *New Media & Society*. https://doi.org/10.1177/14614448241243352

Note

1 For example, a "strike" as a form of organized labor struggle can be disentangled from its military usage by disallowing preceding words like "missile" or "air", or its usage in phrases like "it strikes me as odd", by disallowing the term to be followed by a personal pronoun. Some false positives are harder to exclude: the word "demonstration" is a crucial term for any protest event coding, yet can just as likely be used in a sense of "to display"/"to show".

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8 The fate of social movements' demands

Varieties of movement parties' policy influence in institutional settings

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Introduction[1]

Are movement parties successful transmitters of movements' policy demands into institutions and legislatures? In other words, do they succeed in representing their associated social movements at the institutional level? Movement parties, as originally defined by Kitschelt (2006, p. 280), are parties formed by political activists originating from social movements and often trying to apply social movements' modes of organization and strategic practice to the arena of party competition. They are thus actors of a hybrid nature: with one foot in the party system and the other one in the social movement world (Mosca, 2019, p. 357).

In this chapter, in order to assess the policy influence of movement parties representing the agenda of social movements, we look at actual policy demands: do they survive institutional settings and the hurdles towards becoming law? Do they get watered down or completely die? Which variations of processes exist? Thus, instead of focusing on movement parties' success or failure in elections, we assess their political success with regard to their contribution to the key policies, which the party and the social movement it is linked to are concerned with. Even if single movement parties are not major contenders for government formation (for example, because other political parties ignore the movement party), they may nevertheless be successful in bringing forward some of their vital policy demands and putting them on the agenda of the deliberative institutions, as well as possibly seeing them decided. We describe what kinds of survival or failure of policy demands occur on their journey from appearing on the movements' agenda to being represented by the movement parties in parliament or government.

To this end, we analyze movement parties and their affiliated movements in Denmark (Alternative and the New Right), Germany (Alternative for Germany and the Greens), and Italy (Five Star Movement and the Greens). The following section introduces the country cases, the analytical framework, and the data collection process. The third section presents our findings on

DOI: 10.4324/9781003532507-8

the types of policy success that movement parties are able to achieve within the institutions as well as different varieties of policy failures. In the final section, we present some conclusions.

Research process

Is policy success of a social movement dependent on its movement party's electoral performance? Is being part of a government coalition necessary for the policy agenda of a movement party to be achieved? Are there other ways towards policy influence and policy success that social movements and movement parties might benefit from? To answer these questions, we implement a comparative design with two parties for each of the three country cases.

Country cases

Our country cases Denmark, Germany and Italy are well-established Western European democracies, characterized by multi-party systems. All three have seen social movements gain notable popularity (representing agendas as different as ecological and climate topics, migration, doubts about democracy and facts, etc.). In our view, social movements indicate a malfunctioning transmission belt between the citizens' agenda and the conventional elements of the political system: the emergence, persistence, and intensification of social movements can be a sign of a (partial) failure of political representation which, in the countries under research, predominantly means a failure of established political parties. Movement parties then connect the social movements with state institutions.

As party cases, we have selected: for Denmark the Green Alternative (*Alternativet*) and the New Right (*Nye Borgerlige*), for Germany the Greens (*Bündnis 90/Die Grünen*) and the *Alternative für Deutschland* (AfD), and for Italy the Greens (FdV, *Federazione dei Verdi*) and the *Movimento Cinque Stelle* (M5S, Five Star Movement).

These party cases differ in their time of foundation and their associated movements. The German and Italian Greens are among the pioneers of movement parties. They originated in the 1980s as a result of the New Social Movements of that time and promoted their ideas on the structure and organization of a party as a challenge to the notion of traditional political parties (Rihoux, 2016, pp. 209–300). Yet more recently, both experienced a revival as movement parties in the context of the nuclear phaseout after the Fukushima catastrophe in 2011 and the initiation of the Fridays for Future (FFF) movement in 2018.

Alternativet, the New Right, AfD and M5S are younger actors. The AfD did not originate from a social movement per se. It was formed in 2013 as a reaction to the handling of the Euro-crisis by the government, presented by Chancellor Merkel as a "no alternative" frame (Decker, 2022). However, later, the AfD shifted its focus toward radical right positions and campaigned

for stricter migration policies, as well as, recently, against anti-COVID regulations (Lehmann and Zehnter, 2022). Born out of frustration and disappointment with mainstream politics, the AfD was envisioned, as the name suggests, as a "true alternative" to the established parties. Its early members perceived it as a "non-party party" with a different organizational structure and ideals of direct democracy. Protest movements such as *Pegida*, *Identitäre Bewegung*, and *Querdenken* became known as the party's followers and supporters. Although formally rejecting any links with these movements, the AfD party members were nevertheless seen at some of the rallies and some of the party leaders even called *Pegida* protesters the AfD's 'natural political allies' (BBC, 2015; Amann et al., 2018; Chambers, 2018).

The Danish *Nye Borgerlige* (NB) emerged in 2015 as the result of the conflict between its two founders Pernille Vermund and Peter Seier Christensen with their then-political party, the Conservative People's Party (DKF), over Denmark's EU participation. With NB, they pushed right-wing politics further to the right with an even stricter anti-immigration agenda and libertarian economic program. Within a year, the party gained enough signatures to run for the general elections of 2019 (Panagiotopoulos, 2017). The NB had close links with the *For Frihed* anti-Muslim movement (formerly *PegidaDK*). Several of its main board members and party founders appeared to give speeches in *For Frihed* demonstrations, and many party members regularly participated in their demonstrations (Redox, 2016). The new party chairman Henriksen, elected in 2024, has previously accepted an award from "For Frihed", after pushing through the law on banning burqas in 2018 (Graham-Harrison and Rasmussen, 2018). In addition, several people occupying key positions in the NB have ties with, participated in the protests of, or are even central activists of the pan-European nationalist, right-wing *Generation Identitær* movement, which is against mass immigration and multiculturalism in Europe (Nielsen, 2021; Redox, 2021).

The Italian Five Star Movement (M5S) party grew directly out of the Five Star Civic Lists movement: a blog started by the comedian Beppe Grillo and Gianroberto Casaleggio in 2005, followed by local meet-up groups and "V-Day" demonstrations, led to the official foundation of the M5S party in 2009. In addition, it acted as the voice and hub of the already existing protest movements in Italy (e.g., *NoTAP, No Tav, No Gronda, No Dal Molin*), becoming a "movement of the movements" (Casaleggio and Grillo, 2011; Biancalana, 2020; Campus et al., 2021). Although sharing similar organizational practices and principles as the early Green parties in Europe (ideals of grassroots democracy, assembly-based organization, rejection of hierarchy and professional politicians as leaders, etc.), the M5S is a different kind of movement party as its success is a product of the digital revolution of the 2000s and of the reaction to the Great Recession in Europe between 2009 and 2013 (Campus et al., 2021; della Porta et al., 2017).

In contrast, the launch of *Alternativet* in 2013 was not the result of a bottom-up mobilization but rather the top-down attempt of the former

Minister of Culture, Uffe Elbæk, to create a movement for sustainability and a new political culture. *Alternativet*'s participatory approach to developing policy proposals through political laboratories and the digital "Dialogue Platform" as well as its association with different social movements united in the so-called 92 Group (*92-gruppen*), a coalition between 25 Danish environmental and developmental NGOs, characterize it as a movement party.

Younger parties are often challenger parties, while older parties might already have become part of the political game in the institutional arena. Indeed, while the German Greens at the time of their foundation called themselves an "antiparty" party, they are now fully integrated into the political system and do not challenge it dramatically (Bukow, 2016, p. 112). The same can be said of the Italian Greens (Biorcio, 2016, pp. 186–194). This also holds for structural components. While initial choices in favor of low levels of formalization, the separation of office and mandates, more direct participation of ordinary party members, collective leadership and leadership rotation, gender parity, etc., illustrate the Green parties' connection with the movement sector, nowadays only a few of these features have remained, such as the dual leadership for both the German and Italian Greens, and the women's quota, especially in the case of the German Greens. The M5S and the AfD are also on their way toward integration into the respective political systems, but still claim to be radically anti-establishment. Both still retain the proposals of introducing more elements of direct democracy as well as the need to fight the establishment and the traditional political "caste" (Mosca and Tronconi, 2019; Pirro, 2018; AfD, 2021).

Alternativet, too, reached a stage of institutionalization to handle day-to-day *realpolitik* over the course of its first years in the Danish parliament. Despite the subsequent weakening of its bottom-up policy approach, a party-internal reconfiguration of the policymaking process has been initiated to make it again more participatory (Husted and Mac, 2022). In contrast to M5S, AfD, and the New Right, *Alternativet* does not follow anti-establishment rhetoric. Instead, it ascribes the distance between established politics and the population to a "political and media culture where mudslinging, tactics and media spin occupies too much space" (The Alternative, 2014).

Our design also captures variation in ideology. The Green parties possess a center-left/left-wing ideology focused on environmental politics, while the AfD, the New Right, and the M5S represent the relatively new phenomenon of a populist party, with the AfD and the New Right falling into the right-wing populist camp and the M5S remaining at least ambiguous in its ideology (Casaleggio and Grillo, 2011; Campus et al., 2021, p. 137; Romei, 2017), exhibiting an "eclectic" type of populism (Mosca and Tronconi, 2019).

There is a further differentiation: some movement parties are more successful in their electoral results than others. The Italian Greens have negatively impacted their own popularity after joining the center-left coalition in the 1990s because this decreased their autonomous political role (outside of the coalition) and cost them the ability to widen their electoral base (Biorcio,

2016, pp. 182–183). Always oscillating between 0.5 and 3% in the general parliamentary elections, they have not yet managed to regain momentum or perform well electorally, although their performance slightly improved in the 2022 elections.

Bündnis 90/Die Grünen in Germany, on the other hand, reaching their best result of 14.8% in the federal election 2021, entered the coalition government as a major success. Already before, they were part of the federal coalition from 1998 to 2005, and they were discussed as a partner in the later Merkel governments. They have been regularly part of *Land* level governments, and the prime minister of the *Land* of *Baden Württemberg* also belongs to the Green Party. The German Greens have arrived at the heart of the German political system, with regard to both parliament and government representation.

To understand *Alternativet*'s election outcomes, it has to be considered that it is only one of three essentially Green parties represented in the Danish parliament. In the three general elections in which *Alternativet* took part so far, it reached vote shares of 3–5% (DR, 2024). While it has never been part of a government coalition, the established Danish system of negotiating legislative settlements (*politiske forlig*) on specific policy items can give small opposition parties a "quasi-governmental" status that entails informal veto power and a privileged access to information (Christiansen and Nielsen, 2022, p. 81).

Likewise, *Nye Borgerlige* is also far from being the only right-wing party in Denmark: apart from challenging the nationalist and right-wing populist Danish People's Party (DPP) party, it also had to compete with parties like the right-wing libertarian Liberal Alliance (LA), the center-right *Venstre* (V) and the Conservative People's Party (DKF), as well as, recently, with the right-wing extremist *Stram Kurs* party, and the right-wing populist Denmark Democrats (*Danmarksdemokraterne*). After rapidly growing since its foundation, the NB took 2.4% of the votes in the 2019 Folketing election (The Danish Parliament, 2019). Importantly, by 2021, the NB polled 11% of the general vote, remarkably surpassing the *Venstre* party, which had held government power and the Prime Minister seat just two years prior (Løvkvist, 2021). With the launch of the Denmark Democrats, however, the NB's popularity started to decrease, receiving 3.7% of the votes in the snap elections of 2022 (The Danish Parliament, 2022). After three defections by the NB parliamentary representatives, a suggestion by the party founder Vermund to dissolve the NB in early 2024, and a rejection of this proposal by the party members, the party now faces the challenge of becoming a parliamentary party again (Klinge, 2024).

The M5S party entered the Italian parliament in 2013 with a huge success, but remained in opposition, despite having received the highest number of votes (25.6%). The real challenge for it as an anti-establishment actor was its success in the 2018 elections (32.7%) and the decision to form a government coalition as a major partner, first with the right-wing populist *Lega* and

then, in 2019, with *Partito Democratico* which was especially unpopular among the core members of the party, thus marking an important turning point for M5S: the very nature of the protest movement with its rejection of the traditional political establishment was swept away by the M5S joining the system it had campaigned against (Corbetta, 2018). This, together with the 2021 adoption of a new party statute with a clear hierarchy, finally instituted the M5S as a fully-fledged political party. Simultaneously, forming alliances with parties from different ends of the political spectrum and pulling out of the "national unity government" after the COVID crisis made the M5S lose popularity, resulting in only 15.4% votes in the 2022 elections.

The AfD has never had the option of getting access to the government so far. It preserved its anti-establishment rhetoric and position after entering the parliament in 2017 with 12.6% of the votes. Although their performance in the 2021 federal elections (10.3%) was not much lower than that of the Greens, the AfD was and is far away from forming agreements with other parties to become part of a governing coalition. In fact, all other political parties have agreed to reject any governmental cooperation with the AfD in federal and *Land*-level coalitions as well as to abstain (if feasible) from single-policy cooperation.

Analytical framework and data collection

Are the movement party's election results decisive for a successful transmission of the movement's demands into the parliament? Although it was shown for radical right populist parties that the highest level of influence on public policies is reached when they are part of government (see Minkenberg, 2001; Zaslove, 2004; Lutz, 2018; Hayes and Dudek, 2020), at least some capacity of populist parties to influence public policies regardless of their access to government was confirmed (Biard, 2017, p. 22; Schain, 2006; Caiani and Kröll, 2017). In particular, a notable influence of populist parties in opposition was concluded for the agenda-setting phase (Schain, 2006). We posit that also movement parties of elusive ideology, such as M5S (Mosca and Tronconi, 2019), and of the left have policy impact not only and not primarily through government positions and direct policy-making, but through their influence on agenda-setting and pressure on the established parties. We expect that the movement parties' influence on public policies will take different forms.

To see how policy success was achieved (or not), we rely on a variety of sources for movements, parties, government coalitions and national ministries. We combine written documents (party programs, dossiers, election manifestos, coalition agreements) and website material (blog posts of the movements, press releases, draft legislature), as well as secondary sources. For example, for the AfD policy agenda, we examine their 2017 and 2021 election manifestos. For the movement phase of the M5S, we refer to the blog posts on Beppe Grillo's blog, which came to be known as the official organ

and mouthpiece of the movement (Mosca and Tronconi, 2019). Likewise, the German Fridays for Future and the Danish 92 group websites provide written documents of the movements' demands and policy agenda. For the outcomes of policy-making processes, we consult ministerial and parliamentary websites and news reports.

Varieties of policy results

Based on our Danish, Italian and German cases, we differentiate between three policy outcomes (A-C). All of them presuppose the adoption of the movement's demand by the movement party, by explicit or implicit cooperation. However, the outcomes differ in whether a demand successfully entered the legislative process or not, and whether the implementation has been durable.

Type A: Success and policy adoption

The most favorable policy outcome for the movement and the movement party is the success of their demand within state institutions. The following three types of successes distinguish cases where the movement party was successful through direct policy-making either as part of the government coalition or as an opposition party that explicitly or implicitly influenced the agenda-setting and issue prioritization. We start with the latter as in our sample they turned out to be more durable, while some of the successes through direct policy-making were watered down by subsequent governments (see type B).

Sub-type A.1: Success through implicit *agenda-setting impact and influence on issue priorities*

The agenda-setting impact of a movement party is not always evident at first sight. Even when not being part of the parliament or only being a small opposition party, it can influence policy-making through its impact on public discourse and by silently supporting the initiatives of others. Due to the refusal of all other parties in Germany to cooperate with the AfD and its official denial of links with right-wing protest movements, the AfD is an obvious candidate for being a potential example of implicit policy successes.

The demand for stricter migration policies was raised in both the *Identitäre Bewegung* and *Pegida* movements. *Identitäre Bewegung* (in 2013/14) demanded a change in immigration policy to "prevent a swap-out of the population" and was opposed to unregulated mass migration and "parallel societies", especially Islamic ones (BPB, 2023). The *Pegida* movement, as its name suggests (translated as "patriotic Europeans against the islamisation of the occident"), demands an end to the "islamisation" of Germany and stricter legislation to limit "uncontrolled quantitative immigration", claiming

the duty of integration (Pfahl-Traughber, 2015). The AfD has a very similar approach to migration policies in their election programs of 2017 and 2021. For example, multiculturalism and migration are viewed as threats to social peace and the integrity of the nation as a cultural union (AfD, 2017, p. 92). More deportation is deemed necessary (AfD, 2021, p. 90), as the AfD claims that migration is connected to crime and terror attacks (AfD, 2017, p. 91) and opposes "uncontrolled, predominantly illegal immigration of unqualified people" (AfD, 2017, p. 123). The AfD also advocates harsher penalties and more deterrence against illegal migration (AfD, 2021, pp. 93–94).

These policy demands were successful in influencing legislation to some extent. After the refugee crisis of 2015, asylum policies in Germany took a right turn. This was prior to the entrance of the AfD to the *Bundestag* in 2017, but at the height of the popularity of *Pegida* protests and against the background of soaring popularity of the AfD in the polls (Forschungsgruppe Wahlen, 2017). Adopted measures, such as *Asylpaket I* and *II*, and the Law for the improved enforcement of the duty to leave the country, tightened German migration policy (Mediendienst Integration, 2022). Follow-up regulation was adopted after the AfD's success in the 2017 elections, introducing stricter rules, fewer freedoms and harsher penalties for immigrants, as well as easier deportations (Deutscher Bundestag, 2019). The agenda-setting power of the movements and the party and their growing popularity meant a changing political dynamic around migration policy and put pressure on the established parties to seek ways to undermine their support by adopting measures of similar character.

Similarly in Denmark, *Nye Borgerlige* appears to have influenced the discussions on and subsequent changes in migration policy through implicit agenda-setting both before and after entering the Folketing. The NB's "three invariable demands" regarding immigration – namely, full asylum suspension, self-support obligation for foreigners and deportation of foreigners on first conviction (Bahn, 2018) – were the cornerstone of the NB's election program in 2019 and remain so till now (Nye Borgerlige, 2024b). While these demands would imply steps that most other parties refuse (e.g., withdrawal from the International Refugee Convention or changing the "discrimination against religions" section of the Criminal Code) (Damsgaard, 2021), they are indicative of the increasingly critical positions of the other parties on immigration. According to party chairman Vermund, NB played an important role in this shift: *Nye Borgerlige* was the first to claim that Denmark needed a new asylum system and an end to spontaneous asylum (Bruhn and Flinch, 2024). Indeed, given the proportional representation system in Denmark and the tendency for new parties to gain momentum on the political scene quite fast (Panagiotopoulos, 2017), the foundation of an anti-immigration right-wing party with a policy agenda closely echoing the demands on asylum of the *For Freedom* (formerly *PegidaDK*) and *Generation Identitær* movements in 2015, in the context of the unraveling migration crisis in Europe, posed a certain credible threat for the already established Danish parties. The NB's

fast growth over 2015–2021 and the switching of voters from Venstre and DPP to the NB served as a case in point (Løvkvist, 2021).

Notably, the center-left Social Democrats (SD) took a big right-wing turn in their immigration policy (O'Leary, 2018). After being defeated in the 2015 elections by the right-wing bloc, which then formed a minority government, they did not only not oppose the harsh anti-immigration legislation enacted by the new government, but embraced it significantly, the SD party itself calling for a cap on "non-western immigrants" and more restrictive welfare measures (Orange, 2019). Most restrictive legislation adopted in 2016 with the support of the SD corresponded to the spirit of the NB demands, such as demands for a stop to spontaneous asylum and for no permanent residence permits or public welfare for migrants (Nye Borgerlige, 2024b). The SD has adapted their policy agenda regarding Islam and utilized much of the anti-immigration language of the far right, including opposition to the existence of "parallel societies" in their new political program (Socialdemokratiet, 2017, p. 21). Such a radical turn on the part of the center-left Social Democrats was evidently the result of the pressure on the Danish politicians across the spectrum to make concessions to the populist nationalism of, first, the highly successful in the 2015 elections DPP party, and then of the even more extreme right-wing NB (O'Sullivan, 2016). This change in policy, as admitted by the pro-immigration Social Liberal party, came as a result of an actual change in public opinion after the refugee crisis and the rise in terror attacks by the Islamic State (Orange, 2018).

The NB and its leader Vermund put further pressure on the main parties, capitalizing on the anti-Islam and anti-immigration slogans and polling at 3.2% of the vote before the 2019 elections (Bahn, 2018). In addition, another new far-right party *Stram Kurs*, openly racist and advocating for the deportation of all Muslims from Denmark, quickly gained popularity and also presented a challenge to both the centrist parties and the NB (Stolton, 2019). After the 2019 election victory, the SD pursued some of the toughest immigration policies in Europe (Duxbury, 2024). In addition, the foundation of the populist right Denmark Democrats party a few months before the 2022 elections with its strong stance against illegal migration and the party's extremely successful result of 8.1% in the elections, further underlines the significance of including anti-immigration rhetoric as one of the key issues in election campaigning. The Danish People's Party, at the same time also moved to a more conservative and anti-migration position, which the NB and Vermund were aiming for when founding the party in 2015 (Orbán, 2024). After the 2022 elections, the grand coalition government continued toughening Denmark's immigration policy, which ultimately resulted in the current consensus on immigration across most political parties and seemingly more content with the immigration and integration policies electorate (Duxbury, 2024).

Thus, the foundation and quickly gained popularity of *Nye Borgerlige* on the political scene of Denmark increased the salience of immigration and

integration issues in Danish politics, and impacted the policy agenda of most centrist and right-wing parties – first from outside of the parliamentary arena, and then, after the NB' entrance into the Folketing, from the inside – and ultimately, contributed to the extremely restrictive Danish immigration politics.

In a different policy field, in 2020, the Danish parliament adopted a new climate law setting the ambitious target of a 70% reduction in greenhouse gas emissions by 2030 compared to 1990. The fact that the law was drafted by the social democratic Ministry for Climate, Energy and Utilities and that the parliamentary vote was based on a broad alliance of government and opposition parties seems to imply no outstanding role of *Alternativet* within the legislative process. However, it can be seen as an implicit policy success of *Alternativet* from two perspectives. First, the new climate law is the result of the citizens' proposal "Danish climate law now" that was launched at the beginning of 2019 by the 92 Group (*92-gruppen*), a coalition between 25 Danish NGOs working on environment and development. Successfully collecting more than 68,000 signatures within less than two weeks, the proposal demanding Denmark to adhere to the 1.5-degree objective of the Paris Agreement (which was later specified as the 70% reduction goal for 2030 (92-gruppen, 2019)), was delivered as a citizens' motion in the Folketing. As elaborated later, the realization of the instrument of citizen-driven bills is a central political achievement of *Alternativet*. In contrast to this indirect but obvious impact on climate law, the movement party has also influenced agenda-setting in a second, more implicit manner. While only calling for a general reduction of CO_2 emissions in their bottom-up party program in 2014, *Alternativet* specified the demand of "a linear reduction path of . . . 70 per cent in 2030 and zero per cent in 2040 compared to 1990" in 2017 (The Alternative, 2017). In fact, *Alternativet* was the first party in the Danish parliament to demand the 70% target which was later adopted by most other parties fearing *Alternativet*'s competition in the election campaign in 2019 (Alternativet, 2019) and finally becoming part of the new coalition's agenda (Socialdemokratiet et al., 2019). The momentum of the climate protests in 2019 allowing for the successful usage of the citizen-proposal instrument on the one hand (Nash and Steurer, 2021, p. 12), and the "normalization" of the 70% target in the political discourse and the electoral threat posed by *Alternativet* in the national elections on the other hand, jointly led to the adoption of the ambitious Danish climate law act in 2020.

Sub-type A.2: Success through explicit *agenda-setting impact and influence on issue priorities*

The second sub-type of durable policy success is achieved by the movement party explicitly influencing the agenda-setting process and the voters' issue priorities.

We observe this kind of success, for example, in the case of the abandonment of Italy's nuclear program in the 1980s – possibly the most significant

and lasting result of the Italian Green Party's initiatives. With respect to the Italian nuclear power questions, *Federazione dei Verdi* (FdV) was perfectly aligned with the environmentalist movement, which demanded a stop to the nuclear program and the construction of new nuclear power stations in Italy. Since 1974, environmental associations, such as *Italia Nostra* and the World Wide Fund for Nature – Italy, campaigned against nuclear power plants, which, according to a national energy plan, were to be expanded to a total of 20 nuclear power plants (Standish, 2009, p. 951). The newly established Green Party took over this policy issue from the Italian environmentalist movement and included the goal of stopping the nuclear program in its manifesto of 1987 (Europa Verde/Verdi, 2021). Although the Greens gained just 2.5% of the votes in the 1987 general elections, three referenda against the development of the nuclear program, jointly organized by various environmentalist associations, the Green Party and several leftist parties, were held in November 1987 and were approved by the majority of the voters, resulting in the cutting of government support to the nuclear industry, termination of work on the power plants under construction, and early closure of the functioning power plants in 1990 (World Nuclear Association (WNA), 2022). Furthermore and specifically, a motion of the Greens in 1987 was approved in the parliament, leading to the five-year moratorium on new nuclear constructions (Europa Verde/Verdi, 2021). It is to be noted, however, that this success was influenced to a large degree by the 1986 Chernobyl nuclear disaster, swinging public opinion against nuclear power (Standish, 2009). As a result, major parties in the parliament previously supporting nuclear power chose to back the anti-nuclear referendum campaign (Hardenberg, 2011). Thus, through influencing the issue priorities of the electorate and setting the agenda, the Greens were able to co-opt other political parties from the establishment and impact the result of the policy-making process. The Greens maintained their influential role in this question and anti-nuclear position throughout the years. Also the attempt of the Berlusconi government to revive nuclear power after 2009 failed in the context of the Fukushima nuclear accident in 2011 and the FdV's successful campaign mobilizing the population against nuclear power (Europa Verde/Verdi, 2021). A referendum resulted in the definitive rejection of nuclear power production (WNA, 2022).

The adoption of a scheme for citizens' proposals to be presented to the Danish parliament in 2016 depicts an example of an explicit policy success by the Danish *Alternativet* as a movement in itself and as a movement party. Next to its thematic focus on a more sustainable future, the call for a new, more participatory political culture is at the heart of *Alternativet*'s agenda. Its first party program in 2014 was constructed on the basis of open political laboratories across Denmark (Husted and Mac, 2022, pp. 65–66). Therein, the "opportunity for a citizen-driven bill" is demanded with reference to the established Finish system (The Alternative, 2014). While a motion calling to establish a similar model in Denmark by *Alternativet*'s founder, Uffe Elbæk,

from outside of the parliamentary groups, lapsed in 2014, *Alternativet*'s entry into the parliament in 2015 brought the issue on the agenda again. Depicting a typical example of the Danish system of negotiating legislative settlements, in 2016, *Alternativet* achieved to successfully lead the motion "on the right to have citizen-driven motions for resolutions considered by the Folketing" together with a majority of the other parliamentary parties. The adopted policy allows citizens-driven proposals to be tabled, debated and voted in the Folketing when they have been signed by at least 50,000 citizens.

Sub-type A.3: Success through direct policy-making or by governing

Finally, the most obvious variant of policy success we identify is achieved by movement parties when they have a role in government. In this case, the party has many more resources to achieve its policy goals directly through participation in policy-making. Depending on the share of the majority in a parliament, it does not even have to give much consideration to other parties' preferences. However, the sustained policy influence depends on how well the party is able to secure its position in power, or, if it does not perform well in subsequent elections, on whether the policy previously got sufficient support from coalition partners or other political parties that take over the governmental position.

One of the key demands of the FFF movement and the Green Party regarding the expansion of renewable energy in Germany is a good example of this type of success. Although no official direct cooperation exists between the FFF movement and the German Greens, between the beginning of the movement's protests at the end of 2018 and 2022 the membership levels of the Green Party rose significantly by 67% (Statistisches Bundesamt, 2024), likely due to the popularity of the FFF demonstrations. FFF claimed "[t]he removal of all (political) brakes on the expansion of solar and wind energy" (Fridays for Future, 2021). Interestingly, the proposals to that end in the Green Party's election manifesto are more specific (Alliance 90/The Greens, 2021, pp. 22–23). And the 2021 coalition agreement of the Social Democrats, the Liberals and the Greens even suggests measures that are again more detailed, proposing to "significantly accelerate planning and approval procedures [and] effectively reliev[e] the regulatory authorities by using external project teams", as well as a clarification of the implementation deadlines (SPD et al., 2021, p. 56). This indicates that the three coalition partners were able to reach an easy agreement on the topic (SPD et al., 2021, p. 56). Consequently, the German parliament successfully resolved the so-called Easter package in 2022 and the Solar package I in 2024 to significantly accelerate the expansion of renewable energy in Germany. For example, the EEG amendment 2023 (as part of the Easter package) foresees the legal priority of renewable energies, higher remuneration for solar panels and better financial participation by local authorities for wind energy (Bundesregierung, 2023).

Type B: Receding success

The policy successes presented earlier survived until the time of our writing. There are, however, some policy successes that turned into failures. Interestingly, in our sample these cases all have been former successes through direct policymaking that were then watered down by a new government strongly weakening or completely abolishing the policy.

The Italian Greens took up the environmentalist movement's demand of protecting water resources and incorporated the pledge for a rational and responsible use of water resources into their party agenda. After the decision on a law regarding water supply modernization in 1994, water resources management bounced between pushes for privatization (largely by several Berlusconi governments) and calls for re-municipalization (center-left forces, trade unions, NGOs, civic associations). During the 2006–2008 legislative period in which the Greens controlled the Ministry of the Environment, they were able to secure financial measures in order to help the regions in the protection of water from pollution, management of water resources, and monitoring activities for hydrogeological stability, as well as to work toward guaranteeing access to water as a common good (Europa Verde/Verdi, 2021). These results are noteworthy, since the Greens were only a minor part of the governing coalition at the time, with around 2% of the votes in the 2006 elections. Even in a weak bargaining position within the coalition, the Greens were able to influence policy by working with like-minded groups from other parties in the coalition (Little, 2016, p. 271). However, once the Greens were out of the parliament after the 2008 elections, the new Berlusconi government progressively reduced the funds against hydrogeological instability and pushed once more for privatization of water resources management. In the 2011 referendum, the population was asked to vote on repealing the law that would have allowed the privatization of the public water service management and the law that allowed setting up tariffs for water supply with a view to receiving profit on the invested capital. Although, on both questions, the public voted in favor of repealing these laws, this outcome of the referendum in this policy area was disregarded by successive governments (Europa Verde/Verdi, 2021, p. 10): the service provision currently has a mixed-ownership structure (public, private, or mixed). Therefore, without the power to influence policy-making in the parliament and in government, the Greens were not successful in sustaining and further promoting public water provision.

Another example of this type is the introduction of the universal basic income (*reddito di cittadinanza* (RdC)) in Italy by the M5S, which was in fact considered their most prominent policy success at first. The proposal stems from 2013 (Senato, 2013), when the M5S was already a party, but the policy orientation toward welfare expansion and a strong economic role of the state was already clear during the social movement era. In his "Tsunami tour" in 2013, M5S founder Grillo often stated that "no one will be left behind", hinting at the idea of the guaranteed minimum income

(Mosca, 2015, p. 159). Then in 2013, the Senate M5S group submitted a proposal for a universal basic income of 780 euros per month for all people below the poverty threshold (Senato, 2013). Moreover, the continuity with the policy preferences of the movement was supported by the two national "Five Star Marches" in 2015 and 2017 in order to attract public attention to this proposal (della Porta et al., 2017; Mosca, 2019, p. 364). The M5S managed to introduce this proposal as a state policy early during their first government term in 2019. The success was largely due to its high relevance for the party itself, the support from the protesters' movement base and the significant role of the M5S in the coalition government with the *Lega*. In fact, approval of the RdC measure was a condition of the M5S for forming the coalition government (Fischer and Giuliani, 2023, p. 227). Being the majority party in the coalition, the M5S played a crucial role in garnering support for the proposal in parliament. Moreover, it continued to communicate with its base and the wider public, emphasizing the importance of the RdC as a means of addressing economic inequality and providing assistance to those in need. Among others, the RdC was meant to offset the economic decline in Southern Italy, where the M5S enjoys a large electoral base. However, this strong policy success was only short-lived. In the 2022 elections the center-right coalition, which also included the *Lega*, won after having campaigned for the complete abolition of the RdC. The new government substituted the RdC with two alternative anti-poverty subsidies. Hence, the universal basic income did not survive the M5S losing its governing position.

Type C: Failure

While the policy examples earlier have been at some point successful, the next type of policy impact by movement parties contains cases in which the movement parties failed to transmit the movement's demand to the political arena either due to a lack of allies in parliament or by becoming part of the establishment.

Sub-type C.1: Failure by lack of allies in parliament

Nye Borgerlige's proposal to bring back nuclear power into Denmark's energy mix provides a good example of a policy failure by a lack of allies in parliament. Denmark was once leading the world in nuclear research and had three nuclear reactors, but a 1985 Parliament resolution banned the construction of nuclear plants and power production from nuclear energy ever since (World Nuclear Association, 2024). In 2011, the only party supporting nuclear power in theory was the Liberal Alliance (LA) (DV News, 2011). But the NB was the first party in the Danish Parliament to suggest that nuclear power is indispensable to a stable energy supply and long-term green transition of Denmark, following the COP-19 climate discussions. In their program, NB is very clear on the need to include nuclear power as an energy

source in Denmark, citing its stability, non-dependence on natural elements, innovative technologies available now, cheaper, smaller and more efficient new types of nuclear power plants under development, and the actual safety of nuclear energy production (Nye Borgerlige, 2024a). Specifically, they are strongly arguing for removing the de facto ban on publicly supported research in nuclear power (Christensen, 2022).

In this policy demand, the NB is echoing the demands of the increasingly popular association *Atomkraft – Ja Tak* ("Nuclear Energy – Yes, thank you"), which believes nuclear power to be the most efficient way toward a fossil-free future and the safest of all energy sources (Foreningen Atomkraft Ja Tak, 2024). The NB supports their claims, notably on social media: for example, Vermund herself posted on Facebook, referring to the association's slogan: "In Nye Borgerlige we say yes thank you to nuclear power" (Vermund, 2023). The NB also argues for supporting several Danish successful start-up companies (i.e., Seaborg and Copenhagen Atomics) that develop new nuclear technologies that are safer and more efficient, but are deterred from completing their experiments and testing new reactors by the 1985 ban (Folketinget, 2023).

The four NB party representatives submitted a proposal to the Danish Parliament in 2020 for a resolution "that public energy planning is organized on the basis that nuclear power can be used", de facto suggesting a removal of the ban on nuclear power research and production. They argued that there is now more knowledge and better technology than in 1985 and that nuclear power can be relevant again in energy planning and that its research should be publicly funded, potentially having a decisive role in reducing CO_2 emissions (Christensen et al., 2020). The proposal was rejected by most parties, except the NB, DPP and LA (Folketinget, 2021).

In 2022, the NB submitted another proposal for the inclusion of nuclear power into the public energy planning, adding to the previous arguments the need to deal with the crisis of energy prices, Europe phasing out fossil fuels without stable sufficient alternatives present, and security policy gains from ensuring independence from Russian and Arab gas and oil (Christensen et al., 2022). This proposal was again rejected by the majority against the NB and LA's position (Folketinget, 2022).

However, recently in 2023, an inquiry was launched by the LA, Conservative People's Party (DKF) and DPP, asking the government how it will ensure that the new generation of nuclear power can compete on equal terms with other green and safe forms of energy (Folketinget, 2023), essentially bringing up the topic of reintroducing nuclear energy to Denmark. In the debate, they were supported by the NB. Their proposal suggested that the government deals with the nuclear energy ban and allows nuclear research in the country (Messerschmidt et al., 2023). However, instead the parliament adopted a proposal by the grand coalition stating that the government appreciated and supported research in new nuclear power technologies, but that solar and wind energy can be developed faster, safer and cheaper than nuclear power

(Langhoff et al., 2023). Nonetheless, there was much more division in the Parliament on this adoption, with 59 in favor of the government proposal and 46 against it, including other parties apart from the DPP, LA, KF and NB (Folketinget, 2023). Thus, although in the end, the policy demand of the NB to include nuclear power in the energy supply planning of Denmark was a policy demand failure, it did encourage more parties to lead the discussion on the subject.

In a different example, inspired by similar proposals in Norway and the Netherlands, *Alternativet* demanded in 2016 to stop selling new fossil fuel cars by 2025 (Alternativet, 2016). Together with the Red-Green Alliance, the Socialist People's Party and the Social Liberal Party, *Alternativet* prompted the government in 2017 to conduct a detailed analysis of the effects of a phase-out of the sale of cars running on fossil fuels in 2025 and 2030, which the government refused. One year later the Danish Council on Climate Change, an independent body of experts, recommended stopping selling diesel and petrol cars by 2030 (Klimarådet, 2018). This timeline conflicted both with *Alternativet*'s demand and the calculations of Greenpeace Denmark (2018), which argued in favor of 2025 based on the long average life expectancy of cars. During the 2020 discussions on the new climate law adoption, the 92 Group demanded a series of measures for a climate action plan. Among these, there was the call to stop the sale of fossil passenger cars by 2025 at the latest (92-gruppen, 2020). At the end of 2020, the Danish government agreed to work for a 2030 target at the EU level. However, in 2023, the Council of Europe and the European Parliament decided that newly sold cars must be CO_2 neutral only by 2035 (Klimarådet, 2024). This successive extension of the promised phase-out led the Red–Green Alliance to submit a new proposal to the Folketing to ban the import and sale of new fossil fuel cars by 2025, supported by *Alternativet*. Mainly criticized for its potential violation of the EU law, the motion was rejected. Thus, the climate movement's and *Alternativet*'s demand for a 2025 phase-out of fossil fuel cars failed by a margin of ten years because of a lack of sufficient allies in the Danish parliament.

Sub-type C.2: Failure by becoming part of the establishment

One of the defining elements of the M5S movement's program was their anti-establishment rhetoric together with the anti-Euro and anti-globalist stance (Tarchi, 2014), with Grillo often invoking the need for a referendum on Italy's membership of the Eurozone (Barigazzi, 2018). With the official foundation of the party, this general anti-Euro sentiment persisted, although the M5S continued to be mostly focused on domestic politics and local issues, without having a coherent position on European issues (Corbetta and Vignati, 2014). However, upon entering the parliament in 2013, the M5S had to develop its foreign policy stance (Diodato, 2023). Attacks on the EU-proposed measures, including the Stability and Growth Pact, the

bail-in legislation and the Fiscal Compact, were made in blog posts (Mosca and Tronconi, 2019, p. 1272), and the proposal to hold a consultative referendum about Italy leaving the Eurozone was even prominently included in the 2014 European Parliament Elections Manifesto (M5S, 2014). When the M5S won the 2018 general elections and formed a coalition government with the *Lega*, the parties agreed on making it a "government of change" (Chiaramonte, 2023). However, the ministerial positions for foreign affairs and European affairs were both given to independent non-party politicians. Despite the rhetoric of both parties, which implied their determination to defy Brussels, their actual budget instead showed compliance with European obligations (Newell, 2019).

Furthermore, although Di Maio, one of the party leaders, stated his support for organizing a referendum in Italy on the question of leaving the Eurozone in 2017, he already abandoned this idea soon later and argued that his party was actually pro-European (Barigazzi, 2018). When the M5S formed a new coalition with the *Partito Democratico* (PD), this was generally perceived as a turnaround toward a more pro-European position (Diodato, 2023, p. 60). Moreover, in 2021 Di Maio supported the new Draghi government and reiterated that, instead of a long-gone "Italexit nostalgia", the government would support a "United States of Europe" (Diodato, 2023, p. 61). The huge EU recovery funds for Italy during the COVID pandemic were an additional argument in favor of the pro-European stance of the M5S-formed government. One of the explanations for this policy change is that, by the time of the 2018 elections, the Italian economy was growing, and the voters seemed to be in favor of common European policies and not explicitly against the Euro currency (Barigazzi, 2018). However, the fact that the M5S did not implement any of its anti-EU policy proposals even during the coalition government with the *Lega*, which was also considered Eurosceptic, indicates that there may be a difference between running an election campaign and being a party in government, which has to face the realities of the economy and European politics. The policy demand for defying Brussels and even holding a referendum about leaving the Eurozone is an example of the policy issue that died completely during the process of the movement party's institutionalization and government participation.

Likewise, M5S's campaign for a "clean parliament" is another example of a movement party's demand that was initially successful but failed in the process of becoming part of the establishment. Grillo advocated in favor of this concept and even created lists of parliamentarians with previous criminal convictions, which the movement would have liked to see removed from office. A popular initiative for this goal was initiated (Campus et al., 2021, pp. 146–147). The M5S managed to gather 450,000 signatures for their legislative initiatives (Biorcio, 2014, p. 40). This topic was kept in the movement party's agenda after the party's official foundation. The M5S argued against corruption, for "zero-cost politics", meaning that politics should not become a person's career or a way to make money. Within their party, M5S

prohibited those who had a criminal record from running for public office and introduced the rule to limit the terms of office for MPs to two, without any possibility to run again (Beppe Grillo's Blog, 2011). However, already in 2019, the party representatives, including the leader Di Maio, started to look for ways to get around the rule based on the practical consideration that, if it was held up, a lot of M5S councilors and MPs would have had to resign in the near future, and their political experience would go lost for the party (Reuters, 2019). Hence, when the parliamentary experiences rendered the movement's demand inconvenient, it was abolished. This example shows the consequences of a party becoming part of the establishment. The subsequent alienation between the party and its associated movement illustrates why several minor movements in Italy that supported the M5S during its initial moments are quite critical of the political representation by their respective movement parties.

Conclusion

This chapter looked into the ability of the movement parties to transmit the policy demands of the social movements they are associated with into the political institutions. We were interested in the varieties of how movements and movement parties can channel policy demands and bring about policy success and identified several possible pathways. We contrasted this with episodes of policy failure.

Regardless of whether a party is in government or in opposition, there are ways to influence policymaking or to fail doing so. Electoral success is not automatically translated into policy success. Rather, implicit agenda-setting on particular policy issues or explicit cooperation with protest movements and other political parties in parliament might ensure longer-lasting success. Our policy cases show that direct policy-making by a party from a position of power in a coalition can at first produce more visible and significant policy results, but, if this is achieved without being based on a real consensus about the issue with coalition partners or other allies, it can be followed by policy reversal when a different governing coalition comes to power.

Next to the natural possibility of lacking allies in parliament, the development of a movement party into an established actor depicts an interesting condition for policy failure. Although having similar policy demands to the ones of the associated social movement and partially advocating for them at first, parties might undergo deep changes in their policy preferences when occupying a diametrically different position from a movement, namely a government position. This suggests that movement parties are more parties than movements. Upon becoming part of the establishment, they sometimes depart from the original policy demands of the associated movement due either to compromises of the policy-making process or to their own political expediency.

The insight that moderate to low electoral success of political parties does not preclude significant policy influence is especially important in the context

of newly emerging movement parties, navigating the complexities of institutional politics. It appears that even if the movement is only able to secure little representation through a movement party, this political representation can help achieve important policy goals for the movement. However, the hybrid constitution of movement parties bears the risk that the transmission of the demand into the political arena fails either through alienation from political allies or through departure from movement goals.

Note

1 We are grateful to László Boroffka, Ralf Keil and Lex Metzeld for their help with the empirical work for this chapter.

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9 On movement parties and democratic quality

Fred Paxton, Daria Glukhova, Matthias Hoffmann, Diana Mărgărit, and Felipe G. Santos

How have the interactions between citizens, social movements, and so-called movement parties influenced democracy in Europe? This book has sought to answer this question and chart a new pathway toward a fuller understanding of how changing party political practices and shifting divisions in citizens' values, ideologies and attitudes have affected democratic quality in Europe. It has done so by focusing on what we term the *triple interaction* between these three sets of actors that have been taking place across both the protest and institutional arenas. We have considered three main dimensions of democratic quality, in terms of *participation*, *competition* and *responsiveness*. The overarching argument of the book is that an understanding of democratic quality in contemporary societies, in all its forms, requires more careful consideration of extra-institutional participation. Relative to the transmission of traditional representative politics, we argue that protests and their associated movements (as well as the novel "movement parties") have developed a substantial degree of influence in relation to democratic quality in Europe. In this concluding chapter we outline the findings of the empirical chapters in the book, before discussing broader implications and policy recommendations.

Summary of findings from chapters

Santos and Mercea's chapter explored the patterns of voter support for movement parties, considering ideological orientations across four distinct categories: green/left-libertarian, far-right, eclectic and centrist. Through an analysis of nationally representative survey data from six European countries, the chapter revealed that while movement party voters share a common belief in the capacity of protests to influence the state of the country, the characteristics of movement party voters with different ideologies diverge significantly on most other bases. Green/left-libertarian supporters are distinguished by their youth and education, along with a strong commitment to democracy and online political engagement. In contrast, far-right voters tend to express discontent with democratic institutions and political elites, reflecting conservative values and skepticism toward rapid societal changes. Eclectic and centrist movement party backers exhibit greater support for

DOI: 10.4324/9781003532507-9

democratic values but dissatisfaction with the current democratic system and engage in diverse political actions to seek alternatives. While the authors argue that movement parties represent a genuine innovation in how party organizations are structured, which allows these parties to have a closer connection with societal dynamics, this chapter also calls for caution when using the movement party concept to understand electoral behavior. The heterogeneity of movement party supporters, as well as research that points at ideology as a main driver of movement party vote (Mercea and Santos, 2024), suggests that a one-size-fits-all approach to analyzing their electorates can be misleading (see also Santos and Mercea, 2024). Movement parties of different ideological orientations attract voters with distinct motivations, political practices and attitudes toward democracy and societal change. Therefore, it is essential to consider these nuances to avoid oversimplifying the complex reality of movement party voters.

The next chapter, authored by Trif, Mărgărit and Burean, analyzed the discourses of progressive movement parties. In contrast with the recent surge of populist parties, these progressive entities have built anti-establishment narratives on pro-European and pro-democratic principles. The research presents a comparative study of three such parties: The Alternative (Denmark), Momentum (Hungary) and USR, formerly known as USRPLUS (Romania), representing Western, Central and Eastern Europe respectively. It focuses on the specific and transnational discursive strategies used in social and political mobilization. The analysis of programmatic documents released by the parties from 2017 to 2020 examines two types of narratives: perceptions of self/other/self & other, and the meanings of four empty signifiers – democracy, equality, freedom and inclusiveness. In all three cases, perceptions of self and others resulted from overlapping political references to both domestic and international actors. The parties employed an antagonistic argumentative strategy, contrasting domestic political faults with a promising new political approach that balanced domestic and European elements. This narrative indirectly addressed the increasing backlash against transnational European institutionalism. Through a poststructuralist lens, the chapter reveals that socioeconomic and cultural inclusiveness did not necessarily depend on the parties' ideological backgrounds. All three parties promoted improved citizen participation by giving voice to the voiceless and innovating with alternative civic engagement instruments. This explains their close ties with civic movements and, in some cases, their leadership in grassroots campaigns using mobilization strategies and discursive frames similar to social movements. Despite ideological diversity ranging from left-green to center-right, all three parties employed narratives of "political rejuvenation", critiquing mainstream parties and transcending the traditional left/right divide.

The subsequent chapter from Mosca and Paxton analyzed the evolving relationships between movement parties and traditional media outlets. Despite the substantial political influence that newspapers continue to wield, their interactions with movement parties have been so far overlooked in the

literature. This chapter sought to address this notable gap and asked two research questions: first, how have the relations between movement parties and traditional media evolved over time, and, second, to what extent do the distinctive characteristics of these parties help us to understand similarities in the evolution of these relations across different contexts. Focusing on an ideologically diverse sample of movement parties in Denmark, Germany, Italy and the United Kingdom, the authors employ a qualitative analysis of interviews conducted with both movement party representatives and journalists. Initially, relations between movement parties and the media tended to be mutually hostile, although interpretations of the causes differ between the two sides. Over time, as the parties became more established in the political system, their relations with traditional media outlets underwent significant changes. The dynamic interactions in each case were shaped by the characteristic traits of movement parties. The chapter identifies two primary features shared by movement parties that contribute to similarities in their relations with the media: informal organizational structures and a reliance on digital media. Despite significant ideological variation among the parties analyzed, therefore, the authors argue that there are some commonalities in how movement parties approach the media and their resulting media relations, along with significant contrasts due to contextual differences.

In the next chapter, Hoffmann and Neumayer deepen the inspection of movement parties' usage of social media. They use digital public communication data from both movement parties' and traditional parties' official accounts to probe the conceptualization of movement parties at the intersection of institutional or extra-institutional politics, or, in other words, the protest and the electoral arenas. They parse different trajectories in the positioning and re-positioning of movement parties toward traditional parties (and vice versa) through the referencing patterns in digital public spheres. They find that electoral success and failure correspond to distinct patterns of movement parties as outsiders, institutionalized challengers, or incumbents. Crucially, these trajectories are not linear toward further institutionalization and integration into the polity, but movement parties may revert back to outsider status. Second, the chapter discussed how movement parties signal their interaction with the protest arena, by mentioning protest events in their social media communication. Our findings suggest that movement parties, as members of the polity, are indeed more engaged with issues of protest than traditional parties. Finally, through a qualitative reading of protest images in movement parties' communication, the chapter highlights several visual narratives. These support the transitional nature of movement parties, whose visual language tends to de-radicalize with growing institutionalization, but may revert back to more radical narratives that emphasize ties to protesters and social movement organizations.

Finally, the chapter by Wagemann, Glukhova and Geyer examines how movement parties translate policy demands from their associated social movements into their own agendas and broader political institutions. The

authors investigated various pathways through which movement parties can channel policy demands to achieve policy success, while also identifying episodes of policy failure. The chapter highlights that electoral success does not automatically translate into policy success and that some types of policy achievements may not be sustainable in the long run. Movement parties can influence policy-making, regardless of whether they are in government or opposition, but their success is not guaranteed by good electoral results alone. Cooperation or alignment on specific policy issues with protest movements or other political parties can ensure more enduring success. Direct policymaking from a coalition government position can yield significant policy results, but without agreement on the policy direction with several political parties, these policies are prone to reversal with shifts in governing coalitions. Therefore, forming government coalitions with ideologically aligned parties that share at least a basic agreement on the major issues is crucial for lasting policy achievements of movement parties. The chapter also discusses the evolution of movement parties into established political actors or government entities, noting that this transition often leads to changes in policy preferences. Although initially advocating for similar demands as their associated social movements, movement parties are prone to depart from these demands when they occupy government positions due to the need for political compromises or expediency. Interestingly, even low to moderate levels of electoral success can yield significant policy influence, an encouraging insight for newly emerging movement parties. Even with limited parliamentary representation, these parties may help to achieve important policy goals for their associated movements in the early stages. However, as movement parties become more integrated into the political establishment, they tend to prioritize their role as political parties over their movement origins, recognizing that real decisions and legislation occur within these formal institutional frameworks. Thus, while movement parties can be an effective means for social movements to articulate their demands, their integration into the political establishment often leads to a shift toward party politics at the expense of movement ideals.

Implications and policy recommendations

In the light of the aforementioned empirical findings, there are several implications for future research that we will outline subsequently, along with concrete recommendations to policy-makers. These policy recommendations are intended to help with sustaining and improving democratic quality in Europe, across three main areas.

First, regarding institutional interventions to address low levels of satisfaction with democracy and trust in political institutions. Research shows that, with few exceptions across Europe, there are concernedly low levels of satisfaction with democracy (Santos and Mercea, n.d.). In southern and eastern European countries, trust in democratic institutions is also low, and there is an increasing proportion of the population that does not share the

belief that democracy is the best system of government. Moreover, new anti-mainstream parties that seek to improve democracy by stimulating inclusiveness and political engagement, such as the Alternative in Denmark, Momentum in Hungary and USR in Romania have failed to convince voters and performed poorly in elections. Our research has shown that when citizens are more concerned about democratic quality, they are less willing to participate in politics. More specifically, they are less willing to join political parties and civil society organizations, to participate in demonstrations, and instead more likely to stop participating in politics altogether. This means that institutions cannot stay passive in the face of democratic decline, hoping for citizens to react and demand greater democratic quality. There needs to be decisive action to reverse the cycle of democratic deterioration and foster greater political participation. Notably, in countries with particularly low levels of trust in national institutions (Romania, Italy and Hungary), the level of trust toward the EU is higher. This presents an opportunity for EU institutions to take advantage of their more trustworthy reputation and take action to improve citizens' attitudes toward democracy and promote democratic quality. It is paramount that interventions are made to foster greater political participation to confront attempts to erode democratic principles and to demand necessary institutional reforms.

Second, regarding measures to target widening inequalities in democratic participation. Declining democratic quality has the effect to also deepening already existing social inequalities. When presented with the notion that democracy suffers from multiple problems (for example, unresponsive governments, difficulties in participating in elections or demonstrations), the political participation of women and low-income groups is more heavily hampered than that of men and higher-income people (Santos and Mercea, n.d.). Thus, when made aware of an erosion of democratic quality, women are more likely than men to say that they will not vote in the next election and that they are not willing to participate in demonstrations. When it comes to low-income groups, their exposure to problems with democracy leads to them being less willing to join a political party, to vote in the next election and join civil society organizations, in comparison with higher-income citizens. Consequently, beyond the institutional problems that are created by the deterioration of democratic quality, such an erosion is also likely to discourage women and low-income citizens even further in their attempts to participate politically to redress social inequalities.

To remedy these inequalities, institutions should implement measures aimed at fostering the participation of women and low-income groups. National and European institutions should target these groups through dedicated campaigns aimed at restoring their confidence in European democracy and the value of participation. In addition to such electorally centered campaigns, representatives should also facilitate participation in non-electoral activities. Academic research convincingly shows that participation in protests and social movements is an effective tool for empowering groups

underrepresented in politics (McAdam, 2010; Santos, 2024). However, scholars have also pointed out that these groups are more risk-averse when it comes to participating in politics (Grasso and Smith, 2022). Institutions need to make participation in demonstrations and social movements safer, to encourage wider political engagement by women and low-income groups. This objective requires significant reforms to the policing of demonstrations and social movements, decreasing the number of instances when police agents crack down on these groups during non-violent activities.

Third, regarding initiatives to safeguard a media environment conducive to free and fair electoral competition, we suggest actions from news media organizations and regulatory bodies. We recommend that established parties and media institutions carefully review their stance toward challenger parties in digital communicative arenas. While some movement parties have promoted democratic measures, others on the radical right side of the political spectrum have sought to use the media arena to advance ideas more challenging to democratic norms (Paxton, 2024). In response, established parties and media institutions may seek to co-operate and form "cordon sanitaire" to contain anti-democratic forces and avoid steering attention toward their narratives. The effectiveness of a successful *cordon sanitaire* has been demonstrated in the case of the Belgian region of Wallonia where the populist radical right is extremely weak, contrasting with the neighboring Flanders that lacks such a measure and where such parties are highly popular (De Jonge, 2021). However, on the other hand, withholding recognition from challengers to the establishment might lead to (further) alienation of their supporters from institutional politics. Citizens in Spain, where the radical right Vox party has recently risen to prominence, tend to oppose the idea of such strategic exclusion and prefer for Vox to be treated like any other party (Turnbull-Dugarte, 2024). A careful balancing act must be maintained between defending democracy from threatening forces and preserving political pluralism.

Turning to social media, we also support the use of platform regulations to effectively contain the development of anti-democratic content and networks. As we have observed, social media is a crucial venue for movement parties to signal their alliances with social movements and to interact with established parties (Hoffmann and Neumayer, 2024a, 2024b). Thus, movement parties from outside the democratic spectrum might use social media to legitimize organizations and their claims that target democratic norms. Hence, effective monitoring of anti-democratic accounts and pages can severely limit the capacity to (publicly) network between civil society organizations and movement parties. While networking activities among far-right parties and civil society organizations may still take place on less visible and recognized social media platforms, effective regulations on major social media platforms can help to contain the spread of anti-democratic content. It is therefore crucial that online content is actively moderated in accordance with EU regulations to restrict the spread of anti-democratic content in the public sphere.

In conclusion, while trust in democracy in Europe appears to be shaken, our research has generated several evidence-based recommendations for politicians and civil society organizations to work toward remedying the situation. Following these steps will help to repair the "bridge" between citizens and their elected representatives and so to restore confidence in a strengthened European democracy.

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